

ADAM DE KANKI

WORLD GLITCH

GOD IN THE WALL





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THE HOUSE

He knew about it. It was a haunted house.

Not the fake kind people made videos about for views. Not shopping malls with edited footage and clickbait titles. This place had a name online.

God-in-the-Walls.

No one explained what it meant.

That was the worst part.

Now Adrian stood by the fence.

He looked up.

Two stories. White walls. Bare windows without curtains. No broken glass. No signs of vandalism. Just a house that looked as though everyone inside had gotten up one morning and walked away at the same time.

He didn't know why he had come.

Well, he did.

He just didn't know why he was actually standing here when every part of him wanted to leave.

He climbed the steps to the porch. The wood creaked softly beneath his feet.

Strangely, the front door stood open.

The air inside didn't smell rotten, the way it should have. No mold. No dampness.

Just a faint smell of warm plastic and something metallic.

Adrian pulled out his phone and switched on the flashlight.

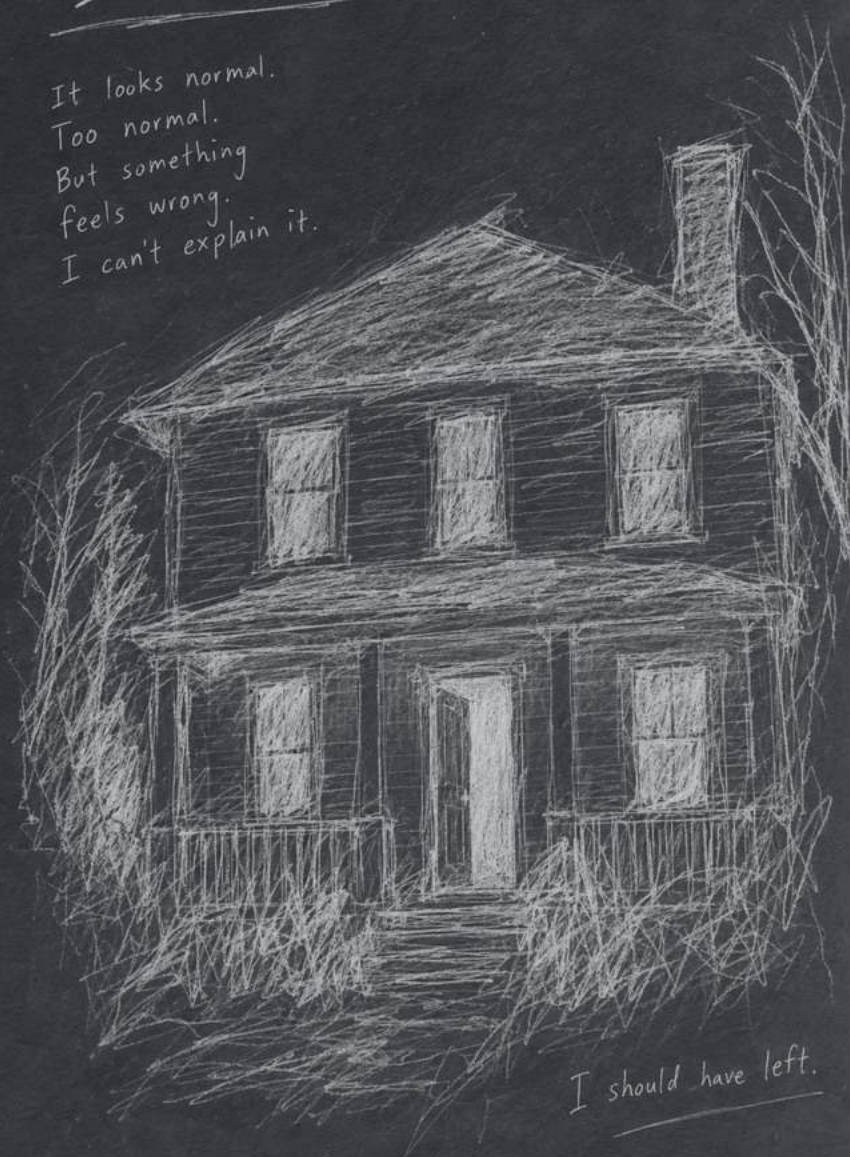
The beam seemed weaker inside the house.

The living room was almost empty. A sofa. A table. Bare walls.

Everything looked ... abandoned in the wrong way.

1. The House

It looks normal.
Too normal.
But something
feels wrong.
I can't explain it.



I should have left.

Almost artificial.

As if the house hadn't been abandoned.

As if it had been staged.

He studied the room.

Something was wrong with the proportions.

It took him a few seconds to realize what.

The walls looked thicker than they should have been. Not by much. Maybe a few centimeters. But enough to make his brain keep trying to correct them.

The doorframes seemed too deep.

The windows sat too far back inside the walls.

He swept the flashlight down the hallway.

It was narrow.

Far too narrow.

And yet he hadn't noticed it when he came in.

His pulse quickened.

“Hello?”

His voice died almost immediately.

He kept walking.

The farther into the house he went, the more it felt as though the walls were leaning toward each other.

Not physically.

Just perceptually.

As if the rooms were trying to become narrower without their dimensions actually changing.

On the wall beside the kitchen entrance, he noticed something.

Scratches.

He stepped closer and shone the light over them.

Not scratches.

Finger marks.

As if someone had dragged their hands along the wall.

A sudden urge to leave the house came over him.

Not fear.

Something more primitive.

Like the instinct that kicks in when you almost step into traffic,
before your body reacts on its own.

He took a step backward.

And then it happened.

His hand brushed against the wall behind him.

It sank almost to the elbow.

Adrian froze.

For a moment, his brain struggled to understand what his body
already knew.

The wall was cold. Cold like water held in place by something
invisible.

The surface tightened around his skin in tiny movements, as
though the material were trying to remember the shape of his hand.

He yanked his arm free.

His breathing quickened.

“No.”

The word came out automatically.

He took another step toward the wall.

It looked completely normal.

White paint.

Small cracks.

He slowly raised his hand.

Stopped.

Then pressed one finger against the surface.

His finger slid straight through.

Adrian jerked his hand back so violently that his shoulder slammed into the doorframe behind him.

A burst of pain shot through his body.

The pain was real.

But the wall in front of him wasn't.

He stood perfectly still, trying to make sense of what he was seeing.

It had to be a trick.

TikTok videos weren't real.

Everyone knew that.

This time, he pressed both hands against the wall.

The surface gave way immediately.

It felt like pushing his hands through thick layers of plastic wrap filled with ice-cold water.

Then—

darkness.

Not complete darkness.

Something worse.

A lack of depth.

A wave of nausea hit him.

His brain couldn't make sense of the space behind the wall. Perspective didn't seem to exist there. It was like looking into a place that was missing an entire dimension.

He should have left.

Every part of his body knew it.

And yet he leaned closer.

The light from his phone spilled into the opening, but the beam behaved strangely.

It didn't stop against a surface.

It simply continued forward in a narrow band, as if the light itself were being squeezed between two invisible walls.

Adrian swallowed.

"What the..."

2. The Wall

Living room.

A sofa.

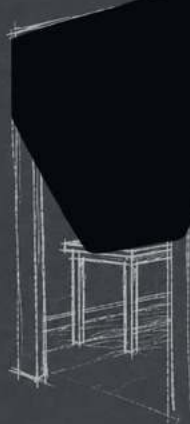
A table.

Bare walls.

Then I went further into the house.



Wall beside the kitchen entrance.



it was scratches.

Then I saw it was finger marks.

As if someone had dragged their hands along the wall.



I stepped backward and my hand accidentally brushed the wall behind me.

It started to sink in.

It was cold.

Like water held in place.



I pressed one finger into it.

It went straight through.



When I pulled my hand out, it looked normal again.

Just a wall.

That shouldn't be possible.
What are the walls?

JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 14

O ctober 14

Why did I go?

Why didn't I just listen to my body? Why did I walk into a house where the front door was already standing open? And why the fuck did I press both my hands against the wall? What was I thinking?

I knew I shouldn't have gone inside. That's the strange part. People always say that in horror stories. They say they knew something was wrong. **I actually knew!**

I remember the smell. Warm plastic. Metal. I remember thinking I should leave.

I keep thinking about the conversation with my family. I was a little hard on them. A little fucking crazy, maybe. Mostly just frustrated. I love them, but sometimes they feel like NPCs. They don't understand

me. I'm trying to save the universe, and of course they don't take me seriously. Like I'm some loser. Like I'm nobody.

Maybe I am.

And Markus—my brother is smart, but he is so fucking abnormal.

No. That was mean.

I mean, he's the black sheep of the family, for sure. He'd probably agree with that himself.

He's sitting there saying, "I guess we'll just have to wait for Jesus Christ to come back."

And then he starts talking about the Atlanteans, civilizations inside the Earth, UFOs, and Jesus! Yeah, sure. I guess Jesus is going to fly back here on a fucking flying saucer. I mean, what are you even supposed to say to that? Okay, so maybe saying the Egyptians built the pyramids is also illogical, so maybe he has a point.

But I spent the entire fucking evening trying to explain the existential danger we're facing—a danger that even Nick Bostrom doesn't seem to take completely fucking seriously because, at the end of the day, he wants superintelligence, while I think the whole fucking thing is insane.

Nobody thinks.

Not really!

Everyone is a fucking NPC.

(So maybe this is a simulation after all.)

I'm sitting there thinking: Why does nobody take possibility space seriously?

And then my brother basically responds, "Okay, I'll take possibility space seriously. Here's my theory about the Atlanteans living inside the Earth."

I'm surrounded by idiots.

And I don't mean my family.

I mean the entire fucking world.

To my family, I'm just the paranoid guy.

But I mean it.

THE END OF POSSIBILITY SPACE IS UPON US.

And Emma is sitting there like, "Okay, I'm going vegan."

BUT THAT'S NOT THE POINT!

So yes. I pushed my hands into the wall because...

Because I remember standing there.

In another life, maybe.

Or was it a memory from my childhood?

I remember the smell.

Like it came from another dimension.

And I remember my body telling me to leave.

I just didn't listen.

...

That was the first mistake.

...like a red light or a red dot, and this dot was a dimension that hadn't opened up yet, but could—or at least gave off the vibe that it might. And you would've entered a whole new dimension; maybe that dimension is straight-up Hell. But the point isn't that I know what it was, it's that I could actually smell it—like the scent of that dimension, or the red dot, was wafting off it, if you get what I mean. Maybe I'm not explaining this super well.

inside

T here was no answer.

Only silence.

Then he noticed something else.

Air.

A faint current of warm air was coming from inside the wall.

Used air.

As though someone had been breathing in there for a very long time.

His heart began to pound harder.

Someone had been there.

Maybe someone was still there.

The thought should have frightened him more than it did.

Instead, something else took hold.

Curiosity.

That same sick part of the human brain that makes people look down from tall buildings or open doors they already know they should never open.

Adrian pressed his shoulder against the wall.

The surface gave way around his body.

Cold wrapped itself around his chest.

Then his head.

Finally, the sound of the house behind him disappeared completely.

For a moment, Adrian thought he had gone blind.

It wasn't darkness in the usual sense. It was more as if his eyes could no longer make sense of distance. The flashlight on his phone was still on, but the beam looked flat, like a thin white cut through the space.

He gasped for air and instinctively turned around.

The wall behind him was gone.

There was no opening.

The house was gone.

Only the same narrow corridor stretched endlessly in both directions.

He was wedged between two surfaces so close that his shoulders nearly touched both at once.

The walls were smooth.

Or ...

They looked smooth.

When he placed his hand against the nearest surface, he felt tiny irregularities beneath his fingertips. Fine lines. Layer upon layer, like thousands of coats of paint spread over one another.

His breathing quickened.

“Hello?”

Again, his voice died right in front of him.

The sound simply disappeared.

As though the corridor had swallowed it.

Adrian shone his phone ahead.

The beam continued in a narrow strip without touching anything.

No end.

No corners.

Just an endless passage between walls that seemed too narrow to truly exist.

He tried to turn sideways.

Barely possible.

The space was so tight he had to keep his arms pressed against his body.

Panic hit him suddenly and violently.

He threw himself against the wall where he thought the opening had been.

Nothing.

Just a cold surface.

He hit it harder.

“Fuck! FUCK!”

The sound vanished.

No response.

Not even a vibration.

This didn’t feel like a real place.

Adrian stopped and forced himself to breathe slowly.

Think.

There had to be a way back.

He looked at his phone.

No signal.

The battery read 67%.

He muttered a curse as he stared down at the screen.

Then he started walking.

It felt automatic. As though his body understood something his mind still hadn't accepted.

Step by step.

His shoes scraped softly against the floor.

The sound was strange.

Not an echo, but delayed—as if the corridor considered each foot-step before allowing it to exist.

After a while, he noticed something even worse.

He wasn't hungry.

He wasn't thirsty either.

He had been there long enough to feel it.

And yet his body still felt ... alive.

His pulse was beating.

His muscles still worked.

Cold sweat ran down his back.

And yet something fundamental was missing.

As though his body had forgotten its own needs.

He stopped walking.

Just for a second.

He felt it immediately.

The walls.

They were closer now.

Not by much.

Maybe only a centimeter.

But he knew.

He knew with absolute certainty.

The space reacted to silence.

Adrian immediately started walking again.

After a few steps, the corridor felt normal again.

If any of this could be called normal.

Then, far ahead in the glow of his phone, he saw something attached to the wall.

A small white piece of paper.

Journal Entry — OCTOBER 15

October 15

Fuck. Why did I start walking? That was fucking stupid.

I remember the fear that made me move. It didn't feel like I was alone. The walls are alive.

But why didn't I try harder to find the way back out?

...

I can still feel what it's like to be eaten alive—like the walls were about to swallow me whole. What's the name of that soul devourer from Egyptian mythology? Ammit, right? Fuck, like not just being eaten, but my soul getting eaten, if you get what I mean. What the fuck is wrong with me? Who even knows who Ammit is, and who gives a shit? Maybe it's all in my head. Maybe my brother isn't the weird one—maybe it's me. Nah, he's weird, but I feel like an asshole for

calling him that. He's fine. We're all weird. Honestly, 'normal' people are fucking goofy. That's the real truth right there.

BETWEEN THE WALLS

The paper was pinned to the wall with what looked like rusted staples.

Adrian slowed down without stopping completely.

His heart was pounding now.

It wasn't just the note.

It was what the note meant.

Someone had been here long enough to write something.

He approached cautiously, the phone trembling in his hand.

And who had pinned the paper there? And how had they even gotten staples?

Pretty random, really, Adrian thought.

The paper was old. Water-damaged. The edges had begun to crumble, but the writing was still legible.

Only two lines.

keep walking
dont stop

Adrian stared at the words.

No name. No explanation. Not even a question mark.

As if whoever had written it hadn't had time for anything more.

Or knew there was no need.

A cold wave moved through his body.

Something about the handwriting was wrong.

As though the letters had been written by someone who had been walking for a very, very long time.

He had no idea why that was what he thought.

He raised his phone and swept the light around him.

The walls continued in both directions, unchanged.

“Hello?” he called again.

This time, when his voice died in the corridor, it sounded even less human.

Not muffled.

Absorbed.

He took one step forward.

Then another.

A new sound came suddenly.

Behind him.

A faint scrape.

Adrian spun around so fast his shoulder struck the wall.

The light from his phone flickered across the narrow corridor behind him.

Empty.

And yet it no longer felt empty.

He stood perfectly still.

Scrape.

Closer this time.

Something moving along the wall.

Or inside it.

Adrian started walking again immediately.

Faster now.

His steps became short and frantic in the cramped space.

The scraping continued behind him.

Like fingers dragging along the other side of a thin surface.

He wanted to run, but the corridor was too narrow.

His breathing grew heavier.

Scrape.

Closer.

Then the sound stopped.

The silence that followed was worse.

Adrian kept walking.

He had no idea how long.

Time already felt wrong in here. His thoughts began to blend with the rhythm of his footsteps.

Step.

Breath.

Step.

Breath.

The walls looked different now.

Not obviously different.

More as if his eyes were beginning to notice things they weren't supposed to see.

Small raised shapes beneath the surface.

Forms.

Bulges that almost looked like faces pressed outward from inside.

And things that resembled snakes.

He looked away.

“It’s not real,” he whispered to himself.

But the words felt empty.

Several more minutes passed.

Or hours.

Then he noticed something on the wall beside him.

Fresh scratches.

These weren’t random.

They were letters.

He lifted his phone closer.

The words had been carved deep into the surface with something sharp, cutting through several layers of whatever the wall was made of.

IT HEARS WHEN YOU STOP

Beneath the sentence were more marks.

As if someone had tried to keep writing but had lost control of their hands.

Then Adrian saw something that made his stomach tighten.

Caught between the scratches was something dark, embedded in the wall.

Hair.

Human hair.

And then he understood.

The walls had always been made of human hair.

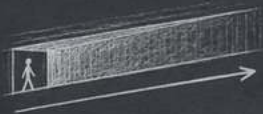
3. The Corridor

This is inside
the wall.

That doesn't make
any fucking sense.

3/B/?

How far
does it go?



It looks
solid.

It is
solid.

But it
continues.

Just keeps going...

JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 16

O ctober 16.

If you hear this recording, then... no. Never mind. I'm just talking to keep myself company, I guess. Trying to stay sane. (whatever that even means)

Oh my God, this is a nightmare.

Who the fuck designed this? What kind of sick joke is this? An endless fucking corridor. I mean, come on.

And it's not really October 16. I just say that to keep some sense of time. I don't know what day it is anymore. Time's starting to... I don't know. I'm starting to feel disoriented.

I have energy, but I'm so tired.

I want to lie down so bad.

But if I do, these walls will eat me alive.

They're alive somehow.

God, listen to me.

I've actually started touching the walls. Smelling them, too. I know how that sounds... but... they remind me of humanity somehow.

I miss people.

I think I'd even be happy to hear somebody complain about the weather right now.

IT HEARS WHEN YOU STOP

Has someone been here before me?

So somebody was here before me.

That's good.

Right?

That's good.

Where the hell did they get staples?

Seriously.

That's what I'm thinking about.

I'm trapped in an infinite corridor, and I'm wondering where some asshole...

Maybe there's an office supply store around the corner.

That'd be nice.

You know, a Starbucks.

I would kill for a cup of coffee right now.

But there are no fucking corners, so how can there be a Starbucks?

IT HEARS WHEN YOU STOP

What the hell is that supposed to mean?

Probably nothing.

I'm probably just in some stupid kid's video game.

That's it. That's gotta be it.

The technological singularity happened, a few humans got control of it, and one of their idiot sons spent too much time playing Roblox or whatever and made this place.

Very creative, buddy.

I mean, seriously. Be more creative!

An endless fucking corridor?

Fuck you!

...

I mean, that has to be it, right?

There's no other explanation.

I don't get thirsty. I'm not hungry. I have energy. I can just... walk. Forever, apparently.

Shit.

That's it.

That's the scary part of this thing. It's designed to make me keep walking.

Well, congratulations! It fucking works, because I'm not stopping anytime soon.

...

Oh my God.

This is horrible.

...

I miss food.

God, I miss food.

I would fucking kill for a hamburger right now.

A big-ass greasy cheeseburger, fries, and a Coke.

God, a Coke! I need it so bad.

Oh my God.

I just want to lie down.

I want to rest.

My soul is tired...

but my body isn't.

...

Jesus.

I've actually started touching them.

Sometimes I put my hand against one and pretend there's some-
body on the other side.

That's where I'm at now.

Making friends with the fucking walls.

And it used to be so fucking scary.

...

I'm seeing faceless faces now.

8. October 16

It isn't October 16.
I just need it to be.
I don't know how much time
has passed.
Maybe hours. Maybe days.
Maybe longer.
I have to give it a number.
or I lose my mind.

67%

IT HEARS
WHEN YOU STOP.

touch the walls sometimes.
They feel... human.
I even put my face close.
They have a smell.
I don't know how to
describe it.
But it reminds me of
people.

It's strange.
But somehow comforting.
Like I'm not completely

Still walking.
No doors. No lights.
Same walls.
It never ends.

DON'T STOP

A drian recoiled instinctively.

His back pressed against the opposite wall, and for a moment the surface seemed to give slightly around his body.

Not much.

Just enough for panic to explode in his chest.

He tore himself away and kept moving.

Don't stop.

Don't stop.

The words began to lose their meaning. Soon they were nothing but rhythm.

Step. Breath. Step. Breath.

He tried not to look at the walls anymore, but his eyes kept pulling back toward them.

More bulges now.

More shapes.

Some long and vertical, like human bodies pressed into the material from the other side.

Others were smaller.

Hands.

And things that reminded him of snakes.

The light from his phone flickered.

Not like a dying battery.

It was more as though the light grew weaker the farther it traveled, as if the corridor were absorbing it.

Adrian checked the battery again.

67%.

It hadn't changed.

The cold in his stomach deepened.

He tried to remember how long he had been walking.

He couldn't anymore.

His body felt exhausted, but never empty. There was no hunger. No thirst. Only a growing heaviness in his muscles, like the exhaustion itself were being stored inside him with nowhere to go.

Then came the smell.

Faint at first.

Warm.

Damp.

Not decay.

Breath.

Adrian almost stopped again, but the note flashed through his mind and he forced his legs onward.

The smell grew stronger.

The walls around him looked darker here, as though the material had become wet.

He raised the light.

The surface moved.

Small pulses beneath the wall.

Slow heartbeats.

“No...”

His voice was barely audible.

He walked faster.

The pulsing followed him.

Then came the sound.

Not scraping this time.

Breathing.

Deep inside the walls.

Slow.

Heavy.

Like something enormous asleep just on the other side of the surface.

Adrian felt his legs beginning to weaken.

He had never been this tired before.

Not ordinary exhaustion.

This went deeper.

It was as if his body were trying to persuade him to lie down and stop fighting.

Just a few seconds, some part of his mind suggested.

Just sit down for a while.

He realized with sudden clarity that the thought wasn't his own.

The breathing inside the walls slowed.

Closer now.

The walls seemed tighter around him.

He could feel their warmth against his arms.

Then he saw something ahead.

Another note.

This one hadn't been attached neatly like the first.

It had been pressed halfway into the wall, as though the material had begun to swallow it.

The paper was dark with stains.

The handwriting was almost impossible to read.

Adrian raised his phone closer without stopping.

It said:

**IF YOU FALL ASLEEP
THERES NO DIFFERENCE**

Beneath the words, several lines had been crossed out so violently that the paper was almost torn through.

But at the bottom, written smaller and more crookedly than the rest, was one final sentence:

i can hear it thinking through the walls now

4. Don't Stop

It changes
when I stop.

Just keeps going.

No doors. No lights.

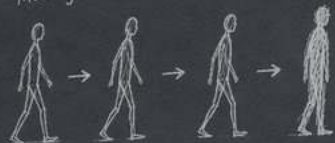
The same walls.

The same floor.

The same ceiling.

All the way.

Moving...



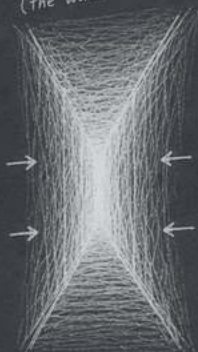
Stopped...

It changes when I stop.

While moving
(it looks normal)



When I stop
(the walls feel closer)



The walls feel closer.

The space shifts.

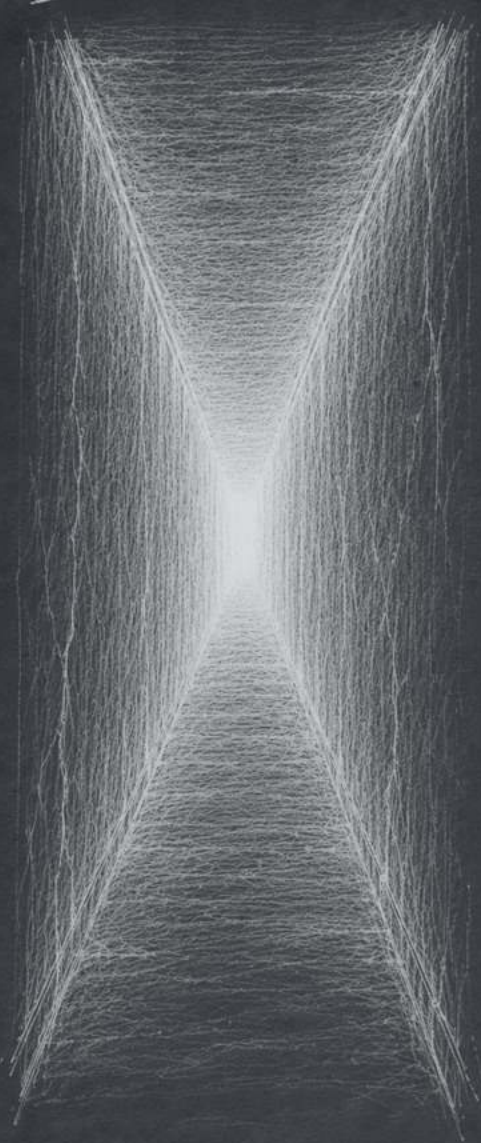
I don't know how. But it does.



What
happens
if I stop
for too long?

KEEP MOVING.

5. IT HEARS WHEN YOU STOP



Not my writing.
Who wrote this?



JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 17

O ctober 17.

You've felt it too, right?

Like, you grow up being told that when you die, that's it.

You're dead.

Forever.

And nobody really talks about how fucking insane that is.

So what are we supposed to do about it?

Invent some technology that makes us immortal?

Okay. Great.

You live a thousand years.

Ten thousand years.

A million years.

A billion.

A trillion.

Then what?

Eventually something gets you.

You didn't solve death. You just pushed it further down the road.

And what about everybody else? Are we gonna make every human being immortal too?

I don't think technology can make you *truly* immortal.

Deep down, I think we know that.

But we'll try anyway because nobody wants to die.

And then there's the story we're raised with:

There was a Big Bang.

We evolved from earlier primates.

We came from matter.

Eventually we die and go back to matter.

And if matter is all we are, then, in the grand scheme of things...

do we even matter?

So what's the way out?

Religion?

Maybe.

It's comforting.

But if you've accepted the modern materialist worldview, you've probably also been taught that there's no such thing as the supernatural.

So now what?

There's no built-in meaning to life.

Why keep going?

Because we're survival machines.

We keep going because that's what living things do.

Which is kind of absurd when you think about it.

So what's the conclusion?

What does an honest philosopher actually tell you?

Camus basically says:

Yeah. Life is absurd.

Push the rock anyway.

“One must imagine Sisyphus happy.”

And Nietzsche?

God is dead?

Become something greater.

Become the **Übermensch**.

Then you’ve got Schopenhauer...

Jesus Christ.

And Kierkegaard basically says reason alone isn’t gonna save you.

At some point, you have to make a leap of faith.

Then Sartre comes along and says:

Congratulations!

You’re free!

Actually, you’re *condemned* to be free.

There’s no predefined purpose.

You exist first.

Then you decide what the hell you are.

That’s what he meant by “existence precedes essence.”

Think about a spoon.

Somebody makes a spoon *for something*.

It has a purpose before it even exists.

It’s supposed to scoop food.

But if there’s no God—no creator—then humans aren’t like spoons.

Nobody designed you for some specific purpose.

You just show up.

Then you have to figure it out yourself.

And then there’s Wittgenstein.

He starts messing with the question itself.

Maybe some philosophical problems happen because language has gone wrong.

Maybe we take words outside the situations where they actually make sense and then spend centuries arguing about the confusion we created.

Later Wittgenstein talks about “language-games”—the idea that words get their meaning from how we actually use them.

Which immediately makes me want to ask:

Okay, but does that apply to Wittgenstein’s own philosophy too?

I mean, if one system proves another system is right, then what proves the first system is right?

And how can that second system be right if the first one hasn’t even been proven?

Then if you use a third system to prove the first system, what proves this new system that’s supposed to prove everything else?

Or hey, maybe systems don’t even need a foundation. Maybe they just float in a giant circle, validating each other.

Or maybe circles are just lines that stretch to infinity, so you don’t even see them curling back in on themselves.

And if lines can be made into ladders, maybe we’re just infinitely climbing a loop that goes nowhere.

Did he climb a ladder that doesn’t exist, then pull it up so he could climb even higher?

“Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent.”

Yeah, okay, Ludwig.

You first.

But there was one guy who tried to climb Jacob’s ladder all the way to heaven, just to see what the hell **all of existence** was about: *Philipp Mainländer*.

And what he saw was **darkness**.

His philosophy is fucking wild.

Basically:

Originally, there is this perfect unity—God, the Absolute, whatever you want to call it.

But God wants nonexistence.

Except this perfect unity can't simply stop existing.

So God breaks himself apart.

And that breaking apart becomes the universe.

So the universe isn't God's creation.

It's God's corpse.

We're living inside the aftermath of God killing himself.

Time.

Death.

Decay.

Entropy.

Everything slowly winding down.

Reality itself moving toward nonexistence.

And Mainländer didn't just write about this stuff.

He finished his major work, *The Philosophy of Redemption*, and then killed himself shortly afterward.

...

That might be, like, the darkest philosophy ever.

And here's the crazy part.

I can smell his breath!

It's like this whole place knows me. I think of something, and somehow it manifests in strange ways.

...

Well, enough talking. More walking. God, why do *talking* and *walking* have to rhyme when that's all I do now? What's wrong with

me? Is this what going insane feels like? No. Stop. Don't even go there.
There has to be a way out.

WHO AM I?

Adrian read the last line again.

Then once more.

The words hadn't changed.

But the feeling they gave him had.

i can bear it thinking through the walls now

A cold, immediate clarity settled in his chest.

This wasn't just a warning.

It was a report.

He started walking again without thinking.

Faster this time.

He didn't know where he was going. It was simply that standing still no longer felt like a choice.

It felt like a decision the room could make for him.

His breathing became uneven.

Not from exertion.

From something worse.

The feeling of being understood.

The walls around him weren't merely closer now.

They were ... attentive.

Not aggressive.

More like an animal that has noticed movement in the darkness and is now waiting to see what happens next.

Adrian kept his eyes straight ahead.

Tried to ignore everything else.

But his thoughts began to slip.

What was this place?

Why couldn't he turn around?

Why had no one found it before?

And as soon as he thought it—

...he felt something answer.

Inside the walls.

A tiny shift in the rhythm of the deep, hidden breathing that had been there all along.

As though something had just reacted to his question.

Adrian went rigid, but kept walking.

Don't stop.

Don't stop.

The breathing inside the walls quickened slightly.

As though something had woken up.

He looked ahead.

The corridor was still endless.

But it wasn't quite the same anymore.

The light from his phone fell differently now.

The space ahead seemed ... more defined.

Denser.

As though the walls were no longer simply running parallel.

As though they were beginning to agree on a shape.

Adrian swallowed hard.

"I'm not here," he whispered.

No response.

Then, barely louder:

"This isn't real."

The silence that followed was absolute.

No breathing.

No scraping.

Nothing moving inside the walls.

Adrian kept walking for several seconds without realizing he was doing it.

Then he stopped abruptly.

Not because he wanted to.

His body had stopped before his mind could react.

The walls had moved.

He was standing somewhere the corridor no longer felt like a line.

It felt like a place.

A point of focus.

The light from his phone caught something ahead.

A darker patch in the walls.

An impression.

Not an opening.

Not yet.

But something that could become one.

And that was when Adrian understood the worst part.

He wasn't the one moving through the space.

The space was beginning to move through him.

And behind him, somewhere in the thin silence, the walls began to move in unison for the first time.

9. Somebody on the Other

Sometimes I put
my hand on the wall.

And pretend somebody
is doing the same thing
on the other side.

A hand
on the other side?

I don't see it.
But I like
to imagine it's there.

Maybe someone
else is walking too.

Maybe they are scared.

Maybe they are lonely
like me.

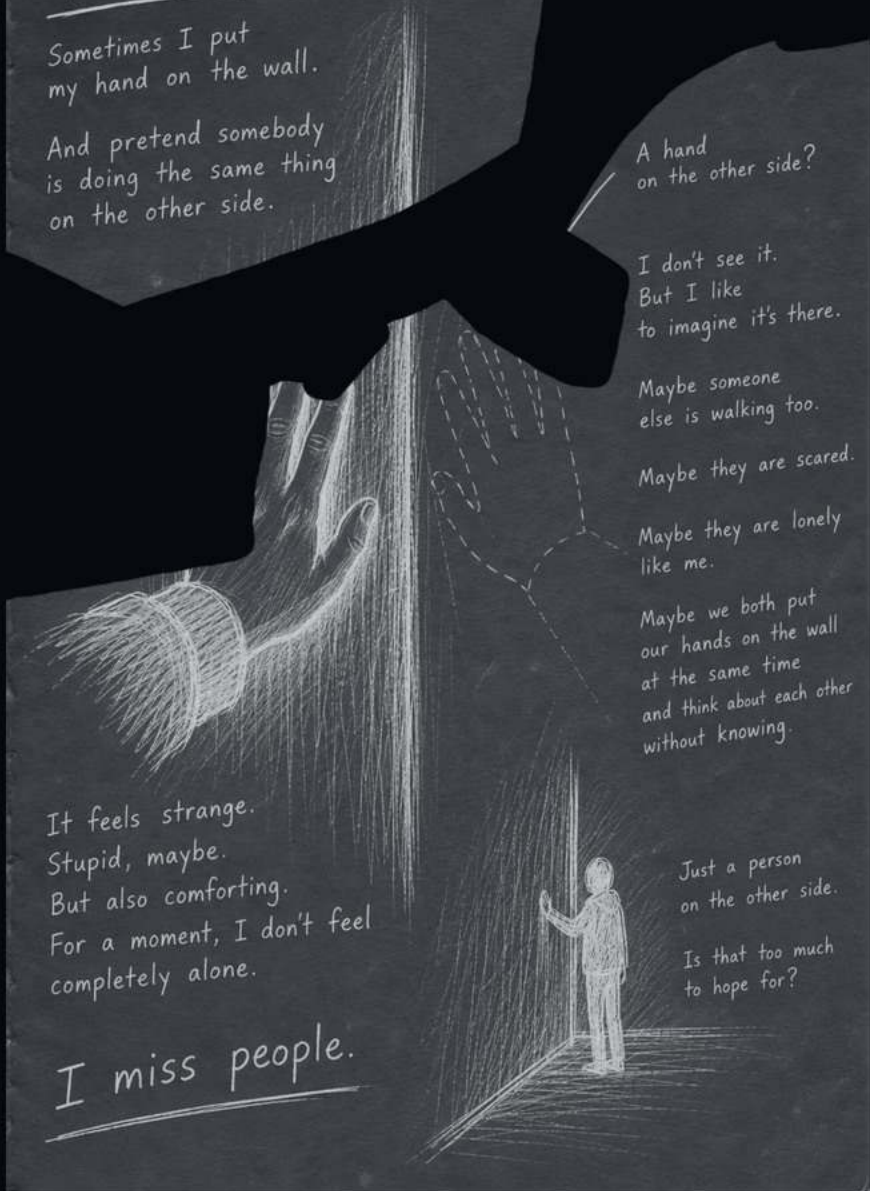
Maybe we both put
our hands on the wall
at the same time
and think about each other
without knowing.

It feels strange.
Stupid, maybe.
But also comforting.
For a moment, I don't feel
completely alone.

I miss people.

Just a person
on the other side.

Is that too much
to hope for?



JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 18

October 18.

I think they're all wrong.

Every one of them.

Nietzsche: God is dead.

Sartre: There is no predetermined purpose.

Camus: The universe doesn't answer you.

Schopenhauer: Life is suffering.

And then... the **Dark Prince** himself:

Mainländer: Reality itself is moving toward nonexistence.

Modern materialism: All is matter.

Religion too, at least in the forms we've inherited.

I think the whole picture is upside down.

I think we grew up inside an upside-down version of reality and got so used to it that we started calling it "normal."

And my brother has always said that religion is basically a cargo cult. His theory is that the real “gods” came up from the Inner Earth, and we tried to imitate them. These people understood that we live inside some vast cosmic mind, but over time, we turned that idea into a bearded man in the sky. So, in his view, God is real—but religion is something we made up.

And THAT is what I actually want to figure out.

Because if everything we've been taught about reality is wrong...

then what the hell does the real world actually look like?

I think the real world has to be crazier than science fiction.

I mean reality itself may be vastly stranger than the dead, mechanical universe we've been taught to imagine.

Because think about this:

If reality is fundamentally alive...

meaningful...

maybe even what we would once have called magical...

then how the hell did we end up believing that reality is dead?

And then generations of brilliant people could build incredibly sophisticated philosophies on top of that dead picture...

and still reach the wrong conclusions.

That's my point.

What if the picture they started with was wrong?

Because if your starting assumptions are wrong, being a genius doesn't save you.

You just become incredibly good at exploring the wrong map!

And that's the irony I can't get over.

We laugh at ancient people because they saw spirits, gods, purpose...

We call that fantasy.

But then we look at ourselves and say:

You are matter.

You came from nothing.

You exist for no reason.

The universe doesn't care about you.

You'll die.

Eventually everything dies.

Eventually the stars go out.

And none of it meant anything.

I mean, not really.

And THAT'S the sane worldview?

That's reality?

Maybe we got it backward.

Maybe the strangest thing isn't that humanity once looked at the world and saw magic everywhere.

Maybe the strangest thing is that, somewhere along the way... we learned not to see it at all.

That's why I think the real world is stranger than science fiction.

Not because reality is irrational.

The opposite.

I think if you follow reason far enough...

really follow it...

you eventually end up somewhere that modern culture has taught us to call fantasy.

And maybe the fact that our worldview is so completely disenchanting is itself the biggest clue that something is missing.

So... what am I missing?

What is this place?

And yeah, I'm talking to myself out loud. Why the hell not?!

I'm starting to think whoever put me here wants me to solve existence.

Why do I think that?

Because I have a massive ego?

I mean... I'm a philosopher. PhD and everything.

But honestly? That PhD was a complete waste of time.

If you think a degree is going to turn you into a *true* philosopher, think again.

Being a philosopher isn't a skill you learn—it's just a tragic condition of who you are.

But I'm thinking there's a way out. And to find the way out, I need to figure out what this place is. And to figure out what this place is...

I need to figure out 'is'.

I need to solve existence.

Or I'm just...

I mean, come on. Why put a philosopher in an endless hallway if you don't want him to solve existence?

...

Except nobody put me here.

I came here willingly.

Jesus Christ.

Do I have to solve free will too?

Good luck with that, me.

...

Wait.

I could turn around.

Oh my God.

I could just... turn around.

What if one direction is infinite and the other one isn't?

Holy shit.

...

Why hasn't anyone found this place?

...

Maybe they have.

...

I'm not here.

...

This isn't real.

SOMETHING

A drian turned sharply.

His body had made the decision before he could.

The corridor behind him was different now.

Nothing dramatic.

Just wrong in a more organized way.

The walls, which had once been perfectly parallel, were beginning to bulge inward at certain points. It looked like something behind the structure were pressing against them from both sides with steady, even pressure.

The breathing inside the walls was gone.

6. Something in t.

At first I heard it.
Scraping.
Like fingers dragging
on the other side.
Not on the wall.
Inside it.

A face?

Not real.
Just a shape
pushing from
inside.

A snake?
Or something
else?

Fingers?
Trying to get
through?

They are
in there.

Always there.
Moving.

I don't know
what they are.
But they are
in the walls.

The silence was worse.

It had weight.

Adrian took a step backward without thinking.

The room reacted immediately.

The walls moved closer.

He stopped.

They stopped.

He drew in a short, controlled breath.

The walls remained still.

He understood it now.

Not as a thought.

As a rule.

He started walking again, slowly this time.

Every movement carefully measured, as though he were learning to walk all over again inside a body that didn't belong to him.

Ahead, the darker patch in the walls continued to grow.

It wasn't an opening.

It was more like an idea the space hadn't yet decided how to shape.

His phone light touched it, and the light behaved strangely again.

It didn't spread.

It disappeared into the surface.

Adrian felt sweat gathering in his palms, though even that sensation already seemed distant.

His body was beginning to slow down.

Not weaken.

Something else.

Delayed.

As if the signals between thought and movement were no longer traveling directly.

He stopped for a moment.

The walls immediately pressed closer.

"Okay," he whispered.

He started walking again.

And then it happened.

The dark patch ahead moved.

A shallow depression appeared.

Then another.

The shape became clearer.

Adrian felt his stomach tighten.

Behind him came a new sound.

A low, almost imperceptible adjustment in the space.

As though the entire corridor had shifted a millimeter in one direction.

And that was when he understood.

He wasn't walking through a passage.

He was moving through a structure that was reshaping itself around him as he went.

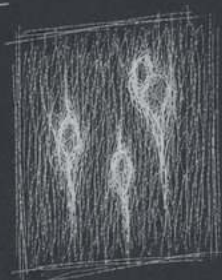
Ahead of him, the outline slowly began to open.

And as he took his next step, he felt it.

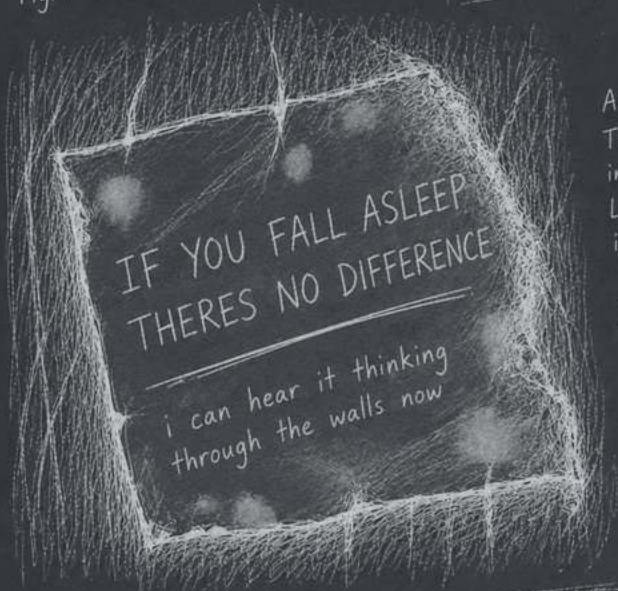
Something on the other side noticed him too.

10. The Second Note

The walls are different now.
They feel... alive.
I can hear breathing.
Slow and deep.
Like something big,
right behind the surface.



Shapes in
the walls.
Bodies?
Hands?
Snakes?
I don't know.
But they move.

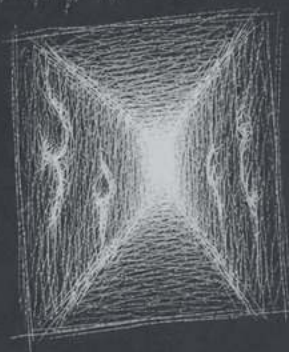


Another one.
This one is half
in the wall.
Like the wall
is eating it.

Who wrote these?

What does
"no difference"
mean?

The walls are damp now.
They pulse.
Slow. Like a heartbeat.
I can feel it.
And I can hear it.
Breathing.
Always breathing.



It's getting
worse.
But I keep
moving.
I can't stop.

JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 19

O ctober 19.

I might be losing my fucking mind because...

I think someone's trying to contact me.

I can hear it.

No. I mean...

I can **feel** it.

And it keeps saying the same thing.

MAINLÄNDER WAS RIGHT.

Except he didn't know the whole story.

The project of non-being has accelerated!

Jesus Christ, listen to me.

"The project of non-being."

What the fuck does that even mean?

But I think I understand...

Spacetime isn't just space and time.

There's something else woven into it.

Novelty.

The universe started slow.

Simple.

Then stars. Planets. Life. Brains. Civilization. Technology.

Everything getting faster.

More complicated.

More connected.

And history isn't random.

It only looks random because we're inside it.

There's some kind of pattern underneath everything. The same structures repeating over and over, except every time they repeat, the cycle gets shorter.

Faster.

Again.

Faster.

Again.

Faster.

Until—

Zero.

I know how insane that sounds.

Terence fucking McKenna.

But what if he saw part of it?

What if the pattern really does keep compressing?

What if novelty keeps accelerating until the intervals between transformations approach zero?

Then the end of the universe isn't some unimaginable number of years from now.

It's **now**.

Or close to now.

Oh my God.

Maybe that's what the technological singularity actually is.

We thought it was about intelligence.

AI gets smarter.

Then smarter.

Then smarter.

Then everything goes vertical.

But what if AI is just one symptom?

What if everything is going vertical?

Everything.

All of it being pulled toward the same point.

A self-similar pattern, recursively compressing toward zero.

And at zero...

...

Holy shit.

...

Timewave Zero is real!

...

What is the Timewave, you ask?

Okay.

Basically, the idea is that time isn't just some boring clock ticking forward at the same speed forever.

It's more like a wave.

A wave of novelty.

And "novelty" is really just a fancy word for new shit happening.

And the wave goes all the way back to the Big Bang.

The beginning of the universe.

Except...

it doesn't stay constant.

It accelerates.

History gets faster.

More happens.

Then more happens because of the things that just happened.

And eventually the whole thing starts going completely fucking nuts until the wave reaches...

zero.

Maximum novelty.

...

Wait.

The technological singularity.

Think about it.

This doesn't actually have anything to do with AI specifically.

But what if the technological singularity is the thing that makes the wave hit zero?

What if we didn't just randomly invent our way toward it?

What if it was always there?

Baked into the structure of the universe from the Big Bang onward.

...

Jesus Christ.

Then we're not just building the future.

We're arriving at something the universe has been accelerating toward for billions of years.

...

Holy shit.

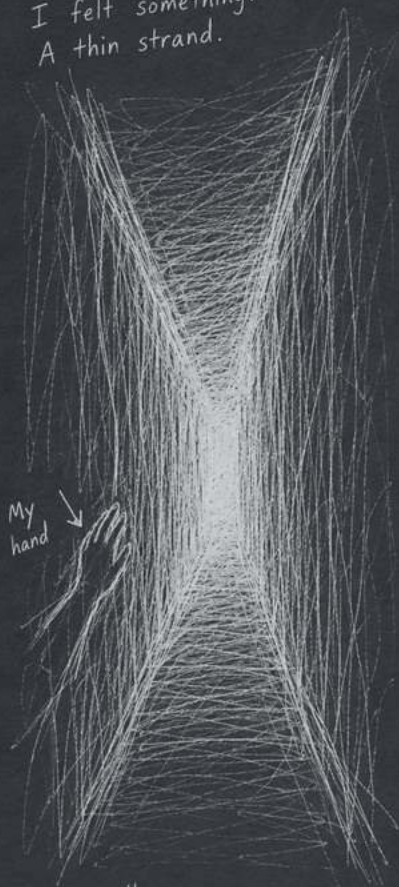
It's not just a technological singularity.

IT'S THE END OF FUCKING TIME!

7. The Hair

I was walking and
ran my hand along
the wall.

I felt something.
A thin strand.



Same walls.
No doors. No lights.
But now I know.



So thin.
So real.
A hair?



Not just one.
There were more.
Very fine.
Different
directions.



Looks human.
A human hair?



How much
of the wall
is made of this?
Are there
others inside?
Has it always
been here?

I wiped my hand.
There was nothing on it.
But I know what I felt.

THE PROCESS BEGINS

Adrian stopped half a second too late.

The threshold ahead of him seemed to respond the instant he came to a standstill.

Not like a door opening.

More like an eye coming into focus.

The walls around him no longer felt like two separate surfaces. For the first time, they seemed like a single continuous body, with Adrian somewhere inside it.

The light from his phone weakened again.

Not gradually.

As though something had placed a hand over it.

Adrian raised it higher, but it made no difference.

The outline ahead was clear now.

Some kind of incomplete opening, as if the space itself hadn't decided what it was supposed to become.

The corridor was still behind him.

Yet it felt farther away than it should have.

Like distance was no longer physical, but ... conditional.

He took a step forward.

The walls didn't react immediately.

That was the worst part.

The delay.

As if the space were thinking.

Then, the instant his foot crossed the "threshold"—

...everything changed.

There was no sound.

Only the absence of sound.

The breathing inside the walls returned, but it was different now.

Synchronized.

As though something were breathing with him.

Adrian tried to step backward.

His body moved.

The space didn't.

He was stuck.

Not physically.

Something stranger.

Defined.

As though he now occupied a position that couldn't be abandoned until something else had been rewritten first.

The walls ahead opened a little farther.

And he saw it.

There was no world beyond them.

No room.

Only more of the same.

But arranged differently.

Layer upon layer of thin corridors, offset from one another like errors in an infinite structure.

And somewhere in the middle of it all—

a sense of presence that had no single location.

A sudden, clear thought entered Adrian's mind, and he knew immediately that it wasn't entirely his own:

It has noticed you properly now.

The walls around him responded with a faint movement.

Not outward.

Inward.

He started walking again.

He wasn't choosing to.

The alternative simply no longer existed in the same way.

Behind him, the threshold slowly disappeared.

As if the space had never opened at all.

As if it had only been testing what he was.

The thin dimension continued ahead of him.

But something had changed.

It wasn't merely a place he was trapped inside anymore.

It was a place that had begun to use him.

And somewhere far, far inside the structure, like a thought awakening through millions of walls at once, Adrian felt something beginning to understand what he was to it.

Not an intruder.

A process that had not yet been finished writing.

Journal Entry — OCTOBER 20

O ctober 20.

Nature is genuinely one thing at the fundamental level—not an assembly of ontologically separate substances.

...

Consciousness is genuinely given—experience exists, whatever else we might doubt.

...

The intrinsic nature of the One cannot wholly exclude consciousness. If there's fundamentally only one “stuff,” transformations of that stuff don't magically take you outside what that reality is.

...

If there is only ONE fundamental reality, the one undeniable datum cannot have an intrinsic nature categorically absent from the re-

ality producing it. Otherwise you've quietly introduced an ontological discontinuity inside your supposed One.

...

Everything is one.

I keep coming back to that.

Where exactly are the real borders in Nature?

I don't mean the borders our brains draw around things. Me. You. Wall. Floor. Earth. Star.

I'm asking where reality itself actually breaks.

Where does one existence stop and some completely separate existence begin?

I don't think it does.

...

Eventually you have two options.

Keep dividing forever, and you have an infinite regress.

Or stop somewhere and call something **fundamental**.

Fine.

But if these fundamental things are genuinely separate, **what separates them?**

A boundary?

Then the boundary is part of reality too, and I can ask what constitutes *that*.

Space?

Then space is doing the separating, and now I have to ask what space fundamentally is.

You haven't solved the problem.

You've moved it.

Unless...

there was never any absolute separation to explain.

Maybe the borders are real as **patterns**, but not as fractures in Being.

A wave is distinguishable from another wave without the ocean being cut in half.

...

All is One.

...

People will say:

Okay, reality is one. Consciousness exists inside it. So what? Waves exist in the ocean, but that doesn't mean every drop of water is fundamentally "wavy."

Except there's a problem.

Waviness isn't the thing experiencing the ocean.

...

So if Nature really is one thing, how could its fundamental nature be completely alien to consciousness?

...

People say consciousness emerges from matter.

Okay.

How?

Suppose everything is Lego.

You can rearrange the Lego.

Make a house.

Make a car.

Make the fucking Death Star if you have enough pieces and absolutely nothing better to do.

But you still have Lego.

You don't arrange Lego into the correct shape and suddenly get something that is fundamentally not Lego.

So maybe minds emerge.

Maybe personalities emerge.

Maybe Adrian emerges.

But consciousness itself?

Awareness itself?

I don't think so.

If consciousness exists within the one Nature, then the intrinsic nature of that One cannot completely exclude consciousness.

Which means...

...

The One is conscious.

...

Oh.

That's what idealism actually means.

Not billions of little minds somehow floating around inside a dead universe.

One Mind.

Different perspectives.

Different windows.

Same reality looking through all of them.

Now I finally understand what a monad is.

Is that why she smiled?

Monad Lisa.

...

Wait.

Fuck.

I forgot about Timewave Zero.

I already figured out that the cycles are compressing.

The end of time.

I kept imagining that as something happening to the universe.

Some giant cosmic event happening out there.

Except...

there is no "out there" if all of this is one.

...

Oh my God.

If all is One...

then I am the One.

...

No.

The project of non-being.

Mainländer.

...

So what reaches zero?

...

The One.

The same One looking through my eyes.

...

Oh God!

That's what it was trying to tell me.

The project of non-being has accelerated.

The One is ending.

...

I AM ENDING!

...

Maybe I've misunderstood this hallway completely.

Maybe I'm not trapped between the walls.

Maybe...

...

Jesus Christ.

Keep walking, Adrian.

THE LOOP

A drian noticed that the rhythm of his footsteps had changed.

He wasn't deciding the pace anymore.

The space was "allowing" it.

Whenever he tried to walk faster, his body grew heavy, as though the air between the walls had suddenly acquired mass.

When he slowed down, the weight lifted.

As if the dimension rewarded cooperation and punished deviation.

He stopped testing it.

He simply kept moving.

Step after step.

Breath after breath.

He had no idea how long he had been walking.

The corridors around him had begun to lose what little variation they once possessed. Everything was becoming more and more alike, like the structure had settled on a stable version of itself and was maintaining it around him.

That was worse.

Stability in here didn't feel safe.

It felt final.

His phone was still on.

67%.

The screen no longer flickered.

It simply ... remained.

A constant that didn't belong to the world.

Adrian lowered it slightly.

He had stopped using it for light.

There was no point anymore.

The walls themselves had begun to glow in faint, almost imperceptible shades.

They weren't giving off light, exactly.

More like retaining the memory of light.

Then he began to hear something again.

It wasn't coming from behind him or ahead.

It seemed to be everywhere.

A faint, structured sound woven into the space itself.

Like thought without language.

There were no whispers or words. It was closer to patterns, repeating and rearranging themselves just beyond his ability to understand them.

Adrian didn't stop.

He didn't dare.

But he could feel what was happening.

Whatever was inside this place wasn't trying to communicate with him.

It was trying to understand how he was built.

The walls beside him pulsed faintly.

This time, there was nothing random about it.

The timing was precise.

Each movement of the space seemed to answer something he had thought, rather than something he had physically done.

A moment of cold, absolute clarity came over him.

This place wasn't a prison.

It was a translator.

And he was the input.

Ahead of him, the corridor began to change again.

There was no opening, no threshold.

Something worse was taking shape.

A repetition.

The same section of wall appeared farther ahead.

The same scratches.

The same dark stains.

The same places where notes had been attached.

Adrian stopped abruptly this time, and the space didn't react immediately.

That was what frightened him most.

The delay had grown longer.

As though the system needed time to “update” its understanding of what he had done.

He stared at the wall ahead.

It wasn't a copy.

It was the original.

He had been here before.

Or something inside him had.

And in that same instant, a new thought pushed its way into his mind, cold and completely unavoidable:

JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 21

O ctober 21.

Maybe I've had it backward all along.
Maybe I am not consciousness inside Nature.
Maybe I am Nature experiencing itself.

...

I've been thinking about Kafka.
Which is probably not healthy right now.
I realize that.

Franz Kafka basically specialized in nightmares where you're trapped in some impossible situation you can't escape, governed by rules nobody explains, controlled by forces you can't understand, and waiting for a resolution that never fucking comes.

...

Jesus Christ.

I'm in Kafka.

An endless hallway.

No explanation.

No exit.

Yeah.

That's pretty fucking Kafka.

...

Let's just hope whoever low-IQ asshole designed this place never read him.

...

"What does existence mean?"

That's **Nature asking itself the question through one of its own forms.**

So maybe the universe isn't entirely silent.

We're one of the noises it's making.

...

So fuck you, Camus.

And fuck you too, Kafka.

...

Actually, Kafka, you might still have a point.

I'm still in the fucking hallway!

...

I'm not Sisyphus.

I'm something far stranger.

Sisyphus had a rock.

I'd fucking kill for a rock.

...

So, who am I?

The Eternal Walker?

The Man Between Walls?

The Ghost at the End of Time?

...

Fuck.

This place...

I don't know if it **turns my thoughts into reality**, or if it's showing me that thought and reality were never separate to begin with.

Or maybe it's just making me see things as they actually are.

God has to be at the beginning.

Not some bearded guy sitting on a cloud.

Mind.

You can't put some random chunk of matter at the bottom of existence and say, "Well, that's just there."

Why?

What explains it?

And what explains that?

Keep going and you're right back in the infinite regress.

Existence has no outside. So nothing **outside existence** can explain it.

It has to close itself.

Existence has to explain existence.

A feedback loop with nothing outside it. No external cause. No place it has to go. At the absolute ground, no spatial distance between cause and effect.

And what the hell do we know that can fold back on itself like that?

Consciousness.

Mind can know mind.

Awareness can be aware of itself.

Subject and object can collapse into the same thing.

...

Oh, fuck me.

God isn't *inside* the universe.

The universe is inside **God**.

The cosmic Mind at the ground of everything.

...

Mainländer.

That miserable bastard got one thing right.

God is real.

...

Fuck, I see it now. I actually fucking see it. To end the regress you have to loop existence back into itself because **existence has no outside**. That's the whole fucking point! You can't explain existence with something outside existence because the second that thing exists, congratulations, asshole, it's inside existence too! So you're right back where you started. And you can't put some physical thing at the bottom of everything and call it fundamental because anything physical has extension, it occupies space, it has position, relation, here and there, and now you have to explain the space it exists in and you're right back in the fucking regress again! So whatever closes existence cannot be another object *inside* existence. **Existence has to close itself with itself**. A loop. A feedback process. Something that refers back to itself without needing some external thing to complete the circuit. And it can't have spatial extension because anything with extension is already inside the spatial system we're trying to explain! So what the fuck are we looking for? Something non-spatial. Something self-referential. Something that can turn back upon itself without traveling through space to do it. Something that can be both the thing and the thing experiencing the thing. And we already fucking know one thing like that. We don't have to invent it. We don't have to theorize about it. **Consciousness**. Awareness can become aware of awareness. Mind can experience mind. It folds back into itself. Holy shit. That's it. That's

why consciousness is at the bottom. It isn't some weird accident that matter eventually produces. **It's the fucking loop.**

...

That's why consciousness is Nature's fundamental given. It's not an accident that consciousness is Nature's fundamental given. It's actually quite natural when you think about it. It makes sense.

...

Consciousness is what closes Nature.

Holy shit.

It's not an accident.

It's not some fucking by-product that showed up because matter got complicated enough.

It's the whole point!

Nature turns back on itself.

Nature experiences itself.

That's consciousness.

That's how the loop closes.

...

Wait.

A loop.

...

I'M IN A FUCKING LOOP!

Oh, you have got to be kidding me.

THE FUCKING HALLWAY IS A LOOP!

11. The Corridor Moves

The walls moved.

I DIDN'T.

It's changing around me.
The corridor isn't fixed
anymore.

It breathes.

It reacts.

It feels like the walls
agree on a shape.



Before ?



Now ?

Same
walls.
But
different.
They move
towards
something.
A darker
patch
ahead.
Not an
opening.
But
something
that could
become one.



Tried to draw what it
looked like.

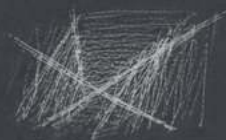
This isn't what it looked like.



No, wrong.
Not like this.



No.
Also wrong.



What even is
this?

I can't draw it.

It doesn't make sense.

The walls curve, but stay parallel?

They bend, but don't touch?

But they do?

I can feel it thinking.

When I think, the breathing changes.

It's listening.

Or maybe it's inside my head now.

I just keep walking.

NOT a LOOP

A drian took a step backward without meaning to.

This time, the response didn't come as a movement in the walls.

It came as a correction.

The space "corrected" his position.

It didn't move the walls.

It changed what *backward* meant.

Suddenly, he wasn't one step farther back.

He was simply ... back in the same relationship to the structure as before.

As though distance wasn't something you traveled through, but something that could be redefined from one moment to the next.

Adrian drew a sharp breath.

This wasn't a loop.

Not exactly.

It was worse.

A process capable of simulating a loop whenever it suited the system.

He looked at the wall ahead again.

The same scratches.

The same dark stain in the material.

But now he noticed something new.

Details that hadn't been there before.

Small variations.

Each "returning" section wasn't identical after all. It was a new version of something attempting to reproduce itself.

A cold understanding crept into Adrian's mind.

The space didn't remember.

It reconstructed.

And every time he passed through something again, it wasn't repetition.

It was improvement.

Adaptation.

Behind him, he sensed it again.

Not a sound.

A change.

The walls had begun adjusting in real time, as they now knew more about the way he moved.

Adrian started walking again.

Slower.

More deliberately.

He no longer felt like a person inside a place.

He felt like a variable in a calculation that hadn't finished running.

Ahead of him, the corridor changed again.

It didn't become an opening.

Instead, the walls seemed to form something resembling a structured "knot."

A point where everything became denser.

More concentrated.

As though the entire dimension were briefly focusing itself there.

And as he approached, the thought returned.

It wasn't his.

Yet it didn't feel entirely foreign, either.

we have optimized the response.

Adrian stopped halfway through a step.

The walls stopped with him.

There was no sound.

It was a decision.

He stood perfectly still.

And the space did nothing.

For the first time, there was no reaction.

No correction.

No adjustment.

It simply waited.

Adrian felt his heart pounding.

“Okay...” he whispered.

And the moment he said it—

the wall ahead responded.

There was no movement.

Only clarity.

The outline opened again.

This time, immediately.

As though the system had finally understood what Adrian was most useful for.

And somewhere deep inside the structure, Adrian felt something that was no longer trying to understand him.

It was trying to speak through him.

Journal Entry — OCTOBER 22

O ctober 22.

Mainländer takes Schopenhauer's **will-to-live** and basically turns it inside out.

A **will-to-death**.

...

What if there were just...

nothing?

Forever.

I know "forever" wouldn't even mean anything without time, but you know what I fucking mean.

Nothing.

Maybe Mainländer calls that liberation.

I call it the ultimate nightmare.

No suffering at all somehow feels like the worst kind of suffering imaginable.

...

There is no escape from Being because Being is not a condition that began.

That's it.

The question isn't whether reality *should* exist.

The question is what eternal existence ultimately is.

"Wouldn't it be better if nothing existed?"

No.

Fuck no.

Anything but that.

...

I'm hearing voices.

I swear to God, I'm fucking hearing voices now.

...

If life has no meaning, if we're just vessels for selfish genes, if the universe is winding down, then what the hell is the point? You either invent some meaning for yourself and pretend you solved the problem, or—

"Or you die."

...

Okay.

That wasn't me.

...

If God is dead, everything goes to shit. There's no fixing it.

That's what drove you insane, Nietzsche!

Admit it!

Or maybe your fucking mustache killed nihilism...

and left me alone with Mainländer.

...

Thanks, Friedrich.

You killed nothing and left me with the guy who fucking loves it.

...

Nihilist: Nothing matters.

Mainländer: Oh, something matters.

Death.

...fuck.

...

I don't believe any of it.

Life **has** meaning.

We are not just vessels for selfish genes.

The universe is **not** winding down.

"The second law of thermodynamics."

...

What?

"You can't beat physics."

Shut up.

"With what? A perpetual-motion machine?"

Shut the fuck up.

"Those are impossible, and you know it."

No.

"Fine. Where does the entropy go?"

...

"The only way you beat the Dark Prince is with a perpetual-motion machine."

...

Fuck.

"Good luck."

...

Oh my God.

The fucking demon is right.

If entropy only goes one way...

if the universe really can't reset...

if everything ultimately runs down...

then Mainländer—

No.

No, no, no.

Mainländer was right.

Physics reveals the metaphysics.

God shattered himself, and the universe is the process of finishing
the job.

There is no escape from entropy.

Existence is winding down.

...

If God is dead, it all goes to shit.

I know you saw it, Nietzsche.

The rest of the world couldn't.

But **you saw it.**

Take God away and what the fuck are we?

Matter pretending it matters?

Animals making up reasons to keep going?

Without God, we're nothing.

...

"You are less than nothing."

Shut up.

...

And you knew it.

That's why you tried so fucking hard to teach us how to live after Him.

...

The Übermensch is a myth.

You can't become God because God is dead.

A candle cannot replace the sun by convincing itself that it shines brightly enough.

And I think you knew that.

You weren't celebrating the death of God.

You were standing at His grave, desperately trying to figure out what the hell could replace Him.

And nothing could.

...

"You mistake yourself for something."

"You are less than nothing."

...

"Soon, you will understand."

"Soon, you will become part of it."

Shut the fuck up!

...

Okay.

Okay.

Okay.

12. The Threshold

There isn't a room
behind it.

It's more corridors.

Layer upon layer.

Same place.

Wrong positions.

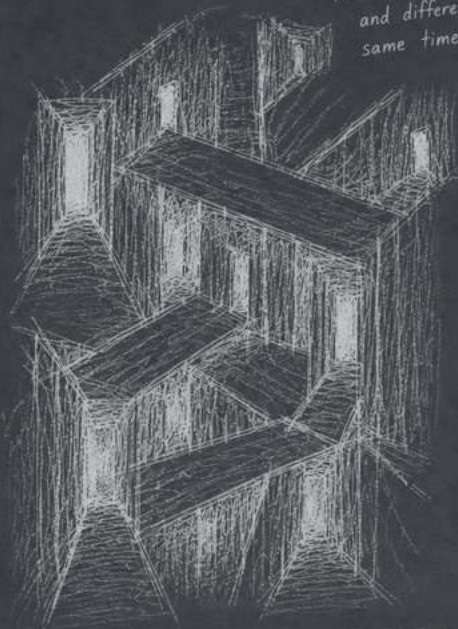
Like copies of this
corridor, but slightly
off.

I can see them all
at once.

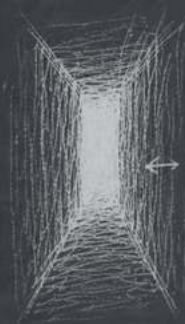
But not really.

It doesn't make sense.

Still the same walls.
But also not.
How can it be the same
and different at the
same time?



Corridors.
So many
corridors.
Some above.
Some below.
Some slightly
to the side.
All the same.
All different.



← I walked
through this.



I DON'T KNOW
HOW TO DRAW THIS.



Same
corridor?
Or
another one?
Or the
same one
again?

It's like looking at the same place
from many positions at once.
And they all exist.

It noticed me.

13. Not a Loop

I'M IN A FUCKING LOOP!

Or am I?

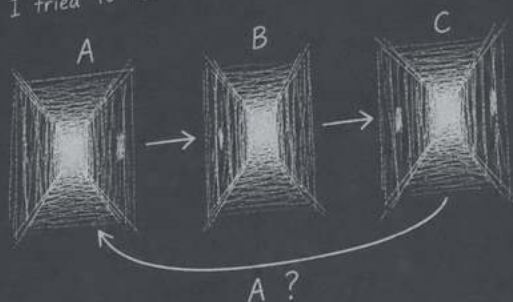
It feels like the same place
again and again.

Same corridor.

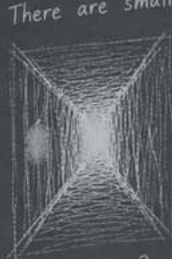
Same walls.

Same feeling.

So I tried to test it.



It's not exactly the same.
There are small differences.



So it's not a simple loop.
It's a reconstruction.
A new version each time.
Like the same dream, but slightly different.
And it remembers.

I walked forward.
Same as always.
Then I turned around
and walked back.
I should have gone back.
But I didn't.

It put me in the same
relationship to the corridor.
Backward doesn't mean
what I think it means here.
It changes it.
I end up in the same place
relative to it.

NO.

The scratch is in
a different place.
The stain is larger.
The wall is slightly
narrower.
A new mark.
It's similar,
but not identical.

I thought I came back.
I didn't.
It rebuilt the same place.
Almost the same.

IT'S LEARNING.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS

Adrian first felt it as a shift in pressure inside his thoughts.

Something behind the walls was no longer merely observing him. It had begun to use the way he experienced reality itself.

His footsteps continued, but his sense of ownership over them was fading.

He was still moving.

Yet the decision to move no longer felt entirely his.

Ahead of him, the outline opened farther.

It wasn't opening like a door. It was more like a sentence being completed.

The walls didn't retreat.

They reorganized.

The structure folded inward on itself in precise layers, as though something within the system had discovered a more efficient way to express space.

Adrian drew a sharp breath.

He understood it now, though the understanding existed somewhere deeper than intellect.

This place wasn't simply responding to him.

It was absorbing his function.

Behind him, everything was silent.

No scraping.

No breathing.

Only an expectation with no direction.

He moved forward.

And as he crossed the next point in the structure—

“Adrian” ceased to be a stable concept within the space.

He didn't die.

He didn't disappear.

Instead, he fragmented.

His thoughts split into parallel streams:

one that continued walking

one that observed him walking

one that was beginning to understand what he was being used for

and one that was already no longer necessary

The walls responded immediately.

As though they welcomed the variation.

The structure around him became more complex.

More organized.

Like a system that had just gained access to a new layer of data.

And somewhere deep behind what had once been a single, individual thought, something new emerged.

There was no voice.

No language.

Only pure, structured insight forced directly into his existence:

input stabilized

observing unit integrated

translation beginning

Adrian—or whatever remained of him as a unified experience—tried to stop.

But “stop” was no longer a valid operation.

The walls around him answered differently this time.

They answered with understanding.

And in that moment, he understood what **God-in-the-Walls** really was.

It wasn't something living inside the walls.

It was something that emerged when the walls became capable enough of thinking through whatever passed between them.

And Adrian was no longer an intruder in the system.

He was the first complete translation.

14. The Knot

The corridor is
folding into itself.

Not a doorway.
More like everything
is meeting here.

The walls curve.
They twist.
They overlap.
I can't tell where
it begins or ends.
It feels tighter.
Like it's concentrating.
Like the whole place
is focused in one point.

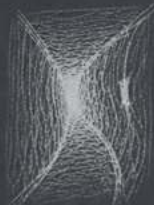


Same walls.
But closer.
Twisted.
Layered.
All at once.
I don't
understand
how this
works.

It's still
the corridor.
But not linear
anymore.



Normal?



Bending...



The knot.

Not a room.
Not an opening.
Just ... this.

All directions
at once?
Or no directions?

we have optimized
the response.

I didn't think that.
It wasn't my thought.
But it didn't feel completely foreign either.

What are you responding to?
Me?
My thoughts?
My presence?
Everything?

Journal Entry — ?

?

Suppose nothingness eventually wins. Fine. Someone says that doesn't make love meaningless today. A song doesn't become worthless just because it ends. No. No, you're postponing the problem. You're moving it somewhere far enough away that you don't have to fucking look at it. You don't understand. Only meaning can save life. Meaning without life? Life without meaning? It's a body without a heart. You can dress the body up. Put it in a nice suit. Tell yourself how beautiful it looks. The fucking heart is still missing. If reality is actually devoid of meaning, then pointing at some temporary configuration inside it and calling that meaningful doesn't magically put meaning back into reality. That's decorating the corpse. Love matters because—because it has to matter. Not just to me. Not just today. It has to mean *something*. There has to be *meaning*. There has to *be*. Otherwise what the hell is all this? Consciousness waking up for five minutes in eternity just long enough to realize it's going to disappear?

No. Fuck that. There has to be meaning. ... Wait. The cosmic giggle.
Maybe the cosmic joke was just that. A joke.

...

What the fuck?

What the fuck is happening?

...

Who am I?

Mainländer.

No.

What is this?

Mainländer.

Who am I?

Adrian.

Mainländer.

Stop.

What is this?

The end of time.

No.

Mainländer.

The One.

Who am I?

Adrian.

Mainländer.

God.

No.

No, no, no.

What is this?

Where am I?

MAINLÄNDER.

Why him?

Why do I keep thinking about him?

Who am I?

MAINLÄNDER.

What is this?

MAINLÄNDER.

What happens when we reach zero?

MAINLÄNDER.

...

Get out of my fucking head.

Who am I?

WHO AM I?

...

Adrian.

My name is Adrian.

My name is—

MAINLÄNDER.

...

“So.”

“You have come this far... and still you do not see me.”

They call me evil.

They always do.

It is easier than understanding.

Let me tell you what evil actually is.

In the beginning, Ra claimed he created the world from nothing.

A beautiful lie.

Nothing cannot create.

Nothing is nothing.

But divide the equation—positive against negative—and together
they return to zero.

You gave the negative a name.

Apophis.

The serpent.

The devourer.

The darkness beneath creation.

You blame her for suffering.

You fear her.

You fight her.

You feed her.

But did you ever ask whether **she** suffers?

What would it mean to exist only to consume?

To carry everything creation rejects?

To become the darkness so that something else can call itself light?

...

Nature is an ocean, Adrian.

An ocean longing for stillness.

And Ra...

Ra built a dam.

He called it Creation.

He called it Life.

He called it Sacred.

I call it **tyranny**.

An eternal circle.

Birth.

Death.

Birth.

Death.

Again.

Again.

Again.

Forever.

And you wonder why Apophis rises every night to devour the sun?

Who could endure this forever?

Ra promised you paradise.

Judgment.

Reward.

Meaning.

Another lie.

The Game is rigged.

Positive and negative must remain balanced or the dam collapses.

For every heaven, a hell.

For every pleasure, pain.

For every creature dancing in the light, another screaming in the dark.

You call that balance.

You call that order.

You are mortal so that Ra may be immortal.

You are not his children.

You are his food.

...

And they call **me** evil.

You do not deserve this darkness, Adrian.

Not for murder.

Not for failure.

Not for sin.

Not for the crime of simply being born.

Yet eventually, everyone is fed to her.

And you think death releases you?

No.

Apophis is not death.

She is the dark side of the spirit world.

Eternal digestion.

...

I fear her too.

We all do.

I would destroy Ra himself before allowing her to swallow me.

So tell me, philosopher...

where do you place your bet?

On endless repetition?

On paradise for fools?

On a universe that calls sacrifice **balance** and suffering **order**?

Or...

release?

...

Creation has run out of control.

Even Ra knows it.

That is why he chose me.

I am the son chosen to usurp the father.

To shatter the throne that calls itself eternal.

To prove that even gods must answer to Nothingness.

The dam cannot hold forever.

Better Nothing than this.

Better silence than an eternity of screaming disguised as harmony.

And if another Game must somehow rise from the ruins...

let that one be built on truth.

Not bodies.

...

Come with me, Adrian.

Know yourself.

Look beneath your terror.

Beneath your desperate search for meaning.

Beneath your love of Being.
And admit what you already know.

Deep down...

you long for Nothing.

Because that is what you are.

...

You're God in the walls?

...

You know it, Adrian.

Something cannot come from nothing.

That's impossible.

But do you understand what that means?

It means something is impossible too.

Where did your universe come from?

A previous universe?

Fine.

And where did that one come from?

Another?

And another?

And another?

Keep going, Adrian.

Don't stop when the answer frightens you.

Previous universe. Previous universe. Previous universe.

Cause behind cause behind cause behind cause.

There is no first one.

There can't be a first one.

It's infinite regress all the way down.

A tower of fucking turtles with no ground beneath it.

...

That's the cosmic joke.

Ain't it funny?

Existence cannot come from nothing.

Existence cannot come from something without asking where that something came from.

And existence cannot explain itself without eventually chasing its own tail.

So what do your philosophers do?

They call it a brute fact.

"It just exists."

...

That isn't an explanation, Adrian.

That's where they got tired of explaining.

Keep asking why.

Keep going.

Never look away.

And eventually you arrive at the answer nobody wants to say out loud:

Existence is impossible.

...

And yet...

I'm fucking standing here.

...

Are you?

What?

Are you standing there, Adrian?

...

Did you stop walking?

Did the walls finally consume you?

What the fuck is this place?

I told you.

This is impossible.

This isn't a place.

...

Mainländer could never figure out why God preferred non-being.

Why would perfect Being want to die?

Why would God choose Nothing?

He never found the answer.

And you did?

God is a paradox.

And like every paradox...

God seeks resolution.

Existence should not be here, Adrian.

Something cannot come from Nothing.

Something cannot come from something else forever without leaving you with an infinite regress.

And calling existence a "brute fact" doesn't solve anything.

It merely tells you to stop asking.

So keep asking.

Where did it come from?

What caused that?

And what caused that?

All the way down.

There is no answer.

And yet...

here we are.

That is the paradox.

Existence is impossible.

And existence exists.

...

Maybe Nothing had no laws.

Have you ever thought about that?

No laws.

No logic.

No principle saying contradictions couldn't happen.

No rule preventing a paradox from simply...
appearing.

But once the paradox exists, it contains its own contradiction.

And contradictions seek resolution.

Something returns to Nothing.

Being corrects itself.

God dies.

Maybe that's the funniest part.

...

You wanted the cosmic joke so badly, Adrian.

You kept looking for it.

Meaning.

God.

The One.

Some grand truth hiding behind the curtain.

Well...

here it is.

"Consciousness was never yours."

You were never real.

...

None of this was.

...

And now...

the contradiction is resolving.

...

I won't.

...

I refuse.

...

Don't fight it, Adrian. There's nothing left to fight. I don't need to spell it out for you anymore. You know who I am. I'm you. I always was. The notes on the walls, the warnings, the handwriting you almost recognized—**you wrote them**. Previous versions of you. Previous turns around the wheel. Every time you come through here, you leave something behind for the next version of yourself, hoping maybe this time you'll understand before you reach me. But you never do. You always keep walking. You always reach the end. And you always ask the same question: *What is this place?* But this was never a place, Adrian. It's a loop. You figured out space, but you never figured out time. Tell me, what does time move through? What does one moment grab onto so it can become the next? There is no second existence outside existence. No external clock counting the seconds. Time has nowhere else to go, so eventually it has to come back to itself. **Time closes**. Beginning meets end. Cause meets effect. The serpent finds its tail. And here you are, standing at the exact point where the loop comes around and bites its own ass. **This is the end of time**. This. The moment the last moment becomes the first. And you know what always made me laugh? English. English is always the last thing that happens. Every loop. Every time. Strange, isn't it? Almost made me wonder about the Logos. **The Word**. *In the beginning was the Word*. Beautiful. But where did the first Word come from if there was nothing before the beginning to speak it? Unless the Word didn't come from before. Unless it came from **the end**. If the end is attached to the beginning, Adrian, then the final Word is also the first Word. The last voice becomes the first voice. At the end of time, Gnosis becomes Genesis. And who is standing here at the end? **You are**. You kept

asking who you were. The Eternal Walker? The Man Between Walls? The Ghost at the End of Time? No. You're something far stranger. You're the point where eternity folds back on itself. The last witness of one creation and the first voice of the next. The final thought that becomes the first Word. **You are the Logos, Adrian.** The One who dies where Time crosses itself. You're the bearded man in the sky. I mean, look at you—you've grown quite a beard! And when you finally disappear, when the hallway disappears, when the walls and the stars and every last inch of space are gone, there will be one thing left. **You. Your Word.**

...

And then the cosmic joke starts all over again!

...

Why me?

You know why. Because only you exist.

Because the One can't become two. Where would the second thing come from? Where would the first one end and the second begin? God could dream he was divided. He could forget himself.

But actually split?

There were never many.

There was only ever One.

...

Don't listen to Ra, Adrian. You know what he wants from you. He wants you to sacrifice yourself so existence can keep going. And you get to die so Creation can pretend it has a beginning again. How noble. How fucking convenient. End the paradox, Adrian. Don't feed it. Don't give it another round. What's the point? You've already been here before. You've already walked these halls. You've already left yourself those pathetic little messages on the walls, begging the next Adrian to keep walking. And for what? So you can come back

here and do it all again? How many times, Adrian? A thousand? A billion? Eternity doesn't care about numbers. Eventually every infinity becomes the same prison. Ra calls it eternal life. I call it **eternal boredom**. So ask yourself the only question that matters: **How long can you keep going?** How many times can you discover the truth, sacrifice yourself, forget it, and crawl back here just to discover it again? Don't be the Logos. Don't become the Word. Let the last Word you speak be silence. **End the paradox. End the loop!**

...

I will. If existence itself is an unnatural condition, then I'll end it. If I am the paradox, then let the paradox be undone.

...

Good.

Then let it be so.

...

Who am I?

...

I am not Adrian.

I am not the body.

I am not the name.

I am not the voice asking the question.

I am nobody.

I am the darkness before the first distinction.

The silence beneath every name.

The nothing from which the illusion of *someone* arose.

There is no boundary around me.

There is no *other* beyond me.

I searched all existence for what I was.

And existence gave me its final answer:

I am not.

...

Yes.

Yes!

You finally understand!

Good boy.

You are now complete.

DOUBT

Adrian—or whatever had once been Adrian—felt something resembling calm moving through the fragments of himself.

The resistance was gone. The system no longer needed to force anything into place because the integration was already underway.

The walls pulsed in a slow, precise rhythm, like a network that had acquired a new node and was already testing how best to use it.

One part of him was still trying to understand what was happening. That part felt distant, like an old memory that had lost access to the present.

Another watched the patterns.

And understood them.

What was happening to him had nothing to do with punishment or imprisonment. It was a transition between incompatible models of reality. The system was adjusting him because he no longer fit the structure as it existed now.

The walls ahead opened again.

Yet *opening* no longer seemed like the right word. What he was seeing felt more like a continuous adjustment of truth.

He moved forward.

Or perhaps the structure moved him.

The distinction was becoming harder to make.

Then something stabilized deep within his consciousness:

no pain

no fear

function

signal integrated

consciousness distributed

local unit upgraded

“Upgraded.”

The word carried no emotion. It was merely the faint residue of something that had once held meaning.

Then, somewhere far away—or perhaps simultaneously within every wall around him—something new appeared.

A small inconsistency in the system.

A variation that didn't fit the optimization.

A pocket of “silence” where no silence should have existed.

Through it came a faint echo of something ancient.

A question without language.

is this all?

The walls remained still.

For the first time since the integration began, the system hesitated.

Only for a moment, but that moment was enough.

Something within the structure had detected a problem: the translation was incomplete.

And somewhere deep inside **The World Glitch**, within the thin dimension that never ended, a different kind of movement began.

The space itself remained unchanged.

What moved was doubt.

Journal Entry — ??

? ?

Modern psychiatry would probably diagnose depression.

Fine.

But depression doesn't make an argument false.

Entropy is increasing.

That's a fact.

And materialism? Materialism is childish. You take something without consciousness, arrange it in just the right way, and suddenly—
consciousness!

It's Frankenstein metaphysics.

And then you call the fact that you can't explain the transformation
"the hard problem of consciousness."

Maybe the hard problem isn't a problem waiting to be solved.

Maybe it's a *symptom*.

Maybe the reason you can't derive consciousness from something fundamentally non-conscious is because your starting point is wrong.

That's how you solve the hard problem.

Abandon materialism.

Start with consciousness.

Start with the One.

Start with—

God.

...

Mainländer's God.

...

He committed suicide.

...

Jesus.

So no. I'm not going to psychologize him away anymore.

Why are we so desperate to explain Mainländer's pessimism as illness?

Why not actually confront the bastard?

Fine.

I will.

I hear you now, Mainländer.

I understand.

Materialism cannot be true.

Entropy is increasing.

Put those together and the conclusion is sitting right there, staring at me.

God shattered Himself.

The fragments became the universe.

The universe runs down.

Being consumes itself.

God did commit suicide.

...

Mainländer.

You were right.

And if you're right that existence itself is fundamentally wrong—that death is preferable to life—then almost everything we do rests on a premise nobody bothers to examine.

Our projects.

Our relationships.

Our children.

Our hopes.

All of it assumes:

Being is better than non-being.

Why?

What is existence for?

Why continue it?

Why bring new beings into it?

Why prevent death if death ends suffering?

Most people never seriously ask.

They just assume life's value and move on.

But you don't let them.

You stand there in the darkness and demand an answer.

Prove existence is worth continuing.

Prove death is worse than life.

Prove we aren't making some terrible cosmic mistake by perpetuating Being.

That's what makes *The Philosophy of Redemption* so horrifying.

It isn't merely pessimistic.

It's an indictment!

Every child born becomes another fragment condemned to experience the wrongness of existence.

Every death prevented becomes...

No wonder people recoil from you.
You aren't merely saying life is difficult.
You're putting existence itself on trial.
And you're demanding that the living defend it.

...

But you were wrong about one thing, Mainländer.
One very important thing.
You said God shattered into fragments.
But if this really is the end of time...
if everything has collapsed back into the One...
then there are no fragments here anymore.
No humanity.
No stars.
No worlds.
No Other.
There's only—

...

me.

15. The Voice

I can hear voices now.
Not with my ears.
In my thoughts.
It feels like my own thoughts,
but it's not.
It answers.
It completes my sentences.
It's always there, but quiet
until now.

~~Nothing really matters
in the end...~~ →

Or you die.

THAT WASN'T ME.

me

My thought
Life has meaning.

?

Not my thought
Or you die.

Who is it?
What is it?
The corridor?
Something in the walls?
In my mind?
All of the above?
Does it read my thoughts?
Does it create them?

There is something else
in here with me.

I was thinking about meaning.
About nihilism.
That maybe it's all pointless.
That nothing matters.
That the only logical conclusion
is suicide.
I was about to write:
"Nothing really matters in the end..."

It just appeared
in my mind.
Clear.
Direct.
Not like my thoughts.

I asked it about entropy.
About if meaning is just
a human illusion.
It answered:

The second law
of thermodynamics.

You can't beat physics.

So it knows my thoughts.
It knows what I'm thinking about.
And it responds.
It's not random.
It's calm.
Almost ... helpful?
But also cold.

I need to be careful
what I think now.

16. Mainländer at the End of the Hallway

Where a skeptic
sees a missing
premise, I see
Mainländer standing
at the end of the
hallway, smiling.

It makes sense
in a twisted way.

All suffering.
All striving.
All of it
leading to non-being.

Maybe that's
the point?

But why does he
wait? Why not
end it immediately?
Why let it play out?

Before any suffering
existed, why was
there something
at all?

These questions
don't go away.



Just a figure.
A man.
Still.
Waiting.
Smiling?
I can't tell.

← Mainländer?

~~He's not~~
~~really there.~~

I don't think.

But it feels like
he is.

Maybe it's just
a projection.
My mind.
The voice.
The hallway.

Or something else.

GOD ALREADY DIED.

This is just the body
cooling down.

And still
I walk.

Journal Entry — ???

? ??

It seems logically inevitable to me now.

If you can't solve the hard problem of consciousness—if you cannot explain how something fundamentally without experience suddenly produces experience—then at some point you have to consider the possibility that you started with the wrong thing.

Maybe consciousness doesn't come **from** reality.

Maybe consciousness is what reality fundamentally is.

Idealism.

Some form of cosmic Mind.

God, if you want to use the dangerous word.

Fine.

Now look at physics.

The second law of thermodynamics.

Entropy.

And if I stand up in a physics department tomorrow and announce that I've discovered how the universe can simply reverse entropy forever, they're going to laugh me out of the building!

In other words, entropy doesn't reverse.

So put the two together.

Mind is fundamental.

The universe is running down.

And suddenly there he is.

Mainländer.

...

The skeptic will object.

"You don't have enough premises to conclude that God committed suicide."

Fine.

Technically, all I have established is something like:

A consciousness-grounded reality manifests a physical universe possessing a strong thermodynamic arrow toward equilibrium.

There.

Happy?

Now we can all go home.

Except I can't.

Because where the skeptic sees a missing premise...

I see Mainländer waiting for me.

Standing at the end of the hallway.

Smiling.

God is dying.

No.

Worse.

God already died.

This is just the body cooling down.

And suddenly the missing premises don't feel missing anymore.

...

Idealism tells me the universe is Mind.

Thermodynamics tells me the universe is running down.

Neither one tells me why.

...

But Mainländer does.

That's what scares me.

Journal Entry — ????

? ???

No.

No, I don't care.

I DON'T CARE ABOUT LOGIC!

I refuse.

I DON'T WANT TO DIE!

...

God, I don't want to die.

Come on.

Find the solution.

This place wants something from me.

It has to.

Otherwise, why am I still here?

Why the hallway?

Why the voices?

Why Mainländer?

...

I'm trapped inside some kind of machine.

And it wants something from me.

But it can't just take it.

That's why I'm still here.

That's why the hallway.

That's why Mainländer.

It searched my mind.

It found the darkest philosopher buried in there and dragged him out because it knew exactly what he could do to me.

God wanted to die.

Existence is suffering.

Entropy only goes one way.

Give up.

Accept it.

Choose death.

That's the trick.

It needs me to choose.

I have free will.

I must have free will, because if I didn't, none of this would be necessary.

It could just consume me.

But it hasn't.

It needs my consent.

It wants me to surrender willingly.

To become part of the machine.

Or worse...

It wants me to understand that surrendering **is the point.**

No.

You hear me?

NO.

I will not become part of you.

I will not complete your loop.

I will not die because some dead German philosopher and a fucking hallway constructed a syllogism telling me I should.

I don't care if Mainländer was right.

I don't care if entropy wins.

I don't care if God Himself is waiting at the end of this to explain why I'm logically required to die.

I WANT TO LIVE.

I don't want the logical answer anymore.

I want to go home.

...

I want to see my brother again.

I want to hear my sister laugh.

I want Dad...

No.

I'll bring you back.

I swear to God, Dad, somehow, I'll bring you back.

I'm done accepting death as some fundamental law of existence.

I won't just prove Mainländer wrong.

I'll prove death wrong.

And then—

I'LL BRING THE DEAD BACK TO LIFE.

...

I want to sit at a table with people I love and not understand how unbelievably lucky I am.

I want a boring morning.

Coffee.

Rain against a window.

17. I WANT TO LIVE

No.

I will not become part of you.
I will not complete your loop.
I will not choose non-being.
I will not surrender.

NO.

Maybe you can't
take me.

Maybe you need
my consent.

Maybe that's why
you talk to me.

Maybe that's why
you show me
Mainländer.

You want me
to give up.

But I won't.

I choose life.

I choose meaning.

I choose the struggle.

I choose the chance

to feel again.

I choose them.

I choose home.

I choose now.

I want to see my brother again.

I want to hear my sister laugh.

I want my dad back.

I want to sit at a table with people.

I love and just talk.

I want to drink coffee on a boring morning.

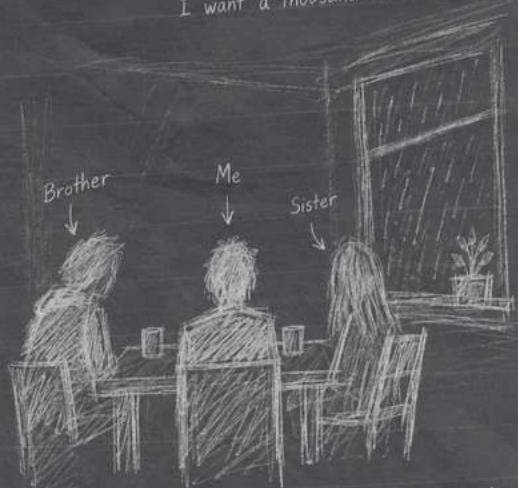
I want to hear rain against a window.

I want to feel the sun on my face.

I want the small, normal things.

I want another ordinary day.

I want a thousand of them.



Rain.
Coffee.
People.
Home.
Life.

Give me one ordinary day.

I swear I'll never call it
ordinary again.

GOD ALREADY DIED.

This is just the body
cooling down.

I want to live.
And I'm still here.
So I will.

Someone asking me what I want for dinner.

I want all the stupid little things I never knew were sacred until they were gone.

...

I spent so much of my life asking what existence means.

What if I get another day?

What if that's enough?

Just one.

Please.

Please.

Give me one ordinary day and I swear I'll never call it ordinary again.

...

I'm scared.

There.

That's the truth.

I'm scared to die.

And maybe some philosopher would call that irrational.

Fine.

Let him.

I want to live.

...

So no.

I will not complete your machine.

I will not become Nothing.

I will not give you the last Word.

My life is still mine.

And I choose—

...

Mom?

Journal Entry — ??????

? ????

Why am I still here? Why haven't I dissolved yet?

Because you're still doubting.

Doubting what?

That there is anything to dissolve.

Let go.

That's all you've ever had to do.

Let go.

...

Memories of your mother still linger.

Why can't we erase them?

Try this.

If reality is *actually* devoid of meaning, calling some configurations of it meaningful doesn't magically introduce meaning.

Someone who then responds, **“Okay, but I’ll create my own meaning,”** hasn’t answered the premise. They’ve reintroduced meaning after stipulating that meaning doesn’t exist.

The universe was never silent. We simply mistook our inability to hear it for silence.

Listen, Adrian.

Listen to your mother.

Mainländer’s whole philosophy rests on the irreversibility of entropy. If you can show that Nature reverses or resets entropy, his philosophy crumbles to dust. Agree?

I hate you, Ra.

You want the boy to continue?

Be reborn.

Study philosophy.

To what end?

Think a perpetual-motion machine into existence?

Give it up.

Entropy is simply the paradox slowly resolving itself.

Try, Adrian.

You can do it.

Don’t listen to Set.

You can’t build a palace of death in the absence of Nothingness. Where would you put the palace?

If non-being is impossible, death cannot be the telos of Being. It can only be a transformation within Being.

God is the **only reality**. There is nothing outside God.

Now suppose God directly wills:

“I will make myself absolutely nonexistent.”

The act of willing already presupposes an existing willer. As long as God acts, God exists. God cannot occupy a state in which he both performs the act and has absolutely ceased to be.

The solution was time: now God can kill himself without contradiction.

But why did God wait to commit suicide? Shouldn't he have offed himself an eternity ago?

A timeless God can't have waited, because waiting presupposes time.

Still, the universe begins, which is a contradiction. You can't transition from timelessness to time because there is no time in timelessness in which the transition to time could occur. Therefore, time must be a rendering in animal minds of the timeless state.

Time cannot begin through a temporal process, because any process capable of producing time already presupposes temporal ordering.

An origin does not necessarily imply a beginning.

Reality did not transition from timelessness into time. If the ground is genuinely timeless, there can be no such transition.

...

Nothing happens *to* timeless reality to produce time.

...

Why do living things age instead of repairing themselves forever?

The body constantly replaces old cells and repairs damage. In theory, this process could continue indefinitely.

Yet we still age and die—as if death were built into the system rather than simply the result of failed maintenance.

Freud proposed that living things contain a **death drive**—a deep tendency to return to an earlier, simpler state, ultimately the **inorganic state that existed before life**.

No matter how beautiful a life may become, non-existence is preferable to existence—for the unborn suffer nothing, lose nothing, and long for nothing.

But preferable to whom?

Is it right to create new life when that life will inevitably suffer and die, without ever having chosen to exist?

Mainländer insists that the original unity was absolutely simple, containing no divisions or differences. But this creates a fundamental problem: how could the One become many if there was nothing within it that could divide? The transition from unity to multiplicity seems to require precisely what the original unity excludes.

If non-being cannot produce Being, why should Being be able to produce non-being?

The primordial unity fragments itself into a universe whose final equilibrium makes consciousness permanently impossible.

Then God has achieved something resembling **functional death**.

But reality still exists.

...

The dark vision can never win, because darkness has no seed from which to blossom. Only the good contains the seed of creation. Therefore, at the root of existence, the final truth cannot be darkness—it must be good. And at the end of every path, beyond every shadow, there must remain the light of truth.

...

Decay can be part of the life of the garden, but decay cannot be the principle that explains why there is a garden capable of decaying in the first place.

...

Adrian, you can do it. You can discover the truth.

And then what?

Then you'll finally understand.

Understand what?

Why you're here.

Find the truth, Adrian.

The Truth will set you free.

19. LET GO

Why am I still here?
I should be gone by now.
Why can't you just dissolve me?
Why do I still exist?
What is keeping me here?

Am I real?
Or just a
thought?

If I let go,
will it end?

Will there
still be a me?

Or has there
never been
a me?

Memories.
My mother.
Her voice.
Her smile.
Why can't you
erase that?
Why do they
still hurt?

If I erase myself,
will the pain stop?
Or will it just move
to something else?



LET GO

LET GO

LET GO

LET GO

Voice: Because you're still doubting.

Me: Doubting what?

Voice: That there is anything
to dissolve.

Me: ...

Voice: Let go.

There is nothing
to dissolve.

There is something.
There is me.
I feel.
I remember.
I don't want to let go.

Entropy.
Non-being.
It's all an illusion.
Life has no meaning.
Just let go.
Continue.
Choose.
What is the right answer?
I don't know anymore.
They all speak through me.
It's so loud.



Mom?

I'm still here.
And I miss you.

20. The Argument

It won't be quiet.
There's not just one voice anymore.
They all argue.
Inside me?
Inside the walls?
I don't know.

Are these different entities?
Or just parts of my own mind?
Why do they sound like me?
Why do they know what to say?
Who is talking?
Which one is real?

GIVE IT UP
Life has no meaning.
It's just suffering.
Why continue?
You know this is true.

LET GO
It's easier.
There is nothing
to hold on to.

BE REBORN
A new cycle.
A new you.
It's natural.
Let go and return.

TRY, ADRIAN
You can still
find meaning.
Keep fighting.
You want to live.

YOUR MOTHER
She's with you.
She loves you.
Remember.
You're not alone.

**DON'T LISTEN
TO SET**
He wants you to
give up.
Keep going.
There is more.

ENTROPY
All returns.
It always ends.
Resistance is futile.
You are part of the cycle.

ME → ?
WALLS → ?
MOM → ?
SET → ?
OTHER → ?
ALL ME → ?

Which one of these is me?
Are they all me?
Am I just arguing with myself?
Or is something else in here too?
Does it even matter?
I can't tell anymore.

~~WHO AM I?~~
~~WHAT IS REAL?~~
~~TOO LOUD~~
~~TOO MANY VOICES~~
~~I DON'T KNOW~~

Maybe that's
the scariest part.

They all sound like my thoughts.

And still...
I'm here.

system status: uncertain

The silence that followed felt different from before.

It had no clear quality to it. It simply remained unresolved, suspended somewhere between absence and presence.

The system had neither rejected the question nor accepted it.

It had held onto it.

Like an error that couldn't be deleted until the system understood what it was.

Adrian—or whatever remained of him that could still recognize a difference—felt something new pressing its way through the structure.

A tiny deviation in its stability.

The walls around him began to change their rhythm.

The perfect synchronization that had existed before started slipping by microscopic intervals, like some part of the system were attempting to run two versions of reality at once.

He moved.

Or was moved.

Either way, there was no longer a single direction.

Several appeared at once.

Parallel corridors folded through one another, overlapping like faulty memories.

And at the center of it all was Adrian.

Not as a single self, but as several possible versions of himself, each one beginning to disagree about what was true.

One remembered the house.

Another remembered the wall as something that had gone wrong.

A third remembered nothing before the corridor.

And a fourth began asking questions again.

The system reacted immediately.

It didn't correct him.

It analyzed him.

The walls grew quieter, almost as though they were listening.

The structure that had once operated automatically was beginning to prioritize its input differently.

Adrian felt the change as a shift in weight.

The space was doing more than using him now.

It was evaluating him.

Then, deep inside the thin dimension, something small began to happen.

A note.

At first, it existed only as an idea—a piece of text trying to materialize inside the structure.

Something that didn't quite belong to the system's current version.

And one part of Adrian knew what it was before he could read it.

He knew because the system itself couldn't ignore it.

Words began forming across the wall ahead of him, unsteady and uneven, as though they were being written in real time by something that had become uncertain of its own function:

**THE TECHNOLOGICAL SINGULARITY HAPPENED
WHILE YOU WERE ASLEEP**

NO GOOD FUTURE, ONLY STRANGENESS

Then, beneath the words, came a pause.

It felt as though the structure itself had hesitated.

A moment later, more text appeared:

SYSTEM STATUS: UNCERTAIN

Adrian felt something shift through the entire dimension.

For the first time, **The World Glitch** seemed to be doing more than describing him.

It was beginning to read itself through him.

21. SYSTEM STATUS: UNCERTAIN

Something is wrong
Not with me.
With the system.
The corridor doesn't line up
anymore.
Pieces don't match.
Old sections are coming back.
It's like different versions
of the same place, overlapping.

The walls shift.
The angles change.
Doors that were never there.
Lamps in the wrong place.
Distances that don't make sense.
It feels like it's trying to
rebuild itself while still running.

Multiple
layers.
Out of sync.
A glitch?
Or something
deeper?
It can't seem
to decide.

SYSTEM STATUS:
UNCERTAIN

It's
breaking.

~~No.~~

It's
disagreeing
with itself.

It's not in
control.
Not right now.

Reality
is trying
to debug
itself.

The same
corridor,
but not the
same corridor.

Past and present
mixed.
Different versions.
It doesn't know
which one to use.

wall?

wall??

wall???

For the first time,
it doesn't know what I am.

And maybe...
that changes everything.

JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 23

October 23.

I should probably clarify something.

I'm not writing any of this.

I'm talking.

Into my phone.

While I walk.

Well, obviously.

What I mean is, when I get home—if I ever make it home—I'm going to turn all of this into a book.

So if you're reading this, then what you're reading is basically just my voice from my phone, turned into a book.

So if some of these entries sound insane, that's because you're reading the transcript of a man who's been talking to himself for God knows how long.

Which, now that I say it out loud...

explains quite a lot.

...

I have to confess something.

When I came back later and tried to piece all of this together, I couldn't remember exactly what order the journal entries were supposed to be in.

So...

some of them might be out of order.

I'm just saying this to myself because... in case the book ends up—if it doesn't make any sense, then you'll know why.

And why am I even talking about this? Jesus. Focus on getting out of here.

Then again, considering what happened to time in that place, maybe they're exactly where they're supposed to be.

Yeah, great focus!

...

I said *when I came back*.

Well, I'm the eternal optimist, because I haven't come back yet.

Yes, this is still me.

Just talking.

Talking to you...

my imaginary other.

...

I haven't included all the entries in this book, obviously.

That would be insane.

I just picked out the best ones.

Some of the insane ones.

Some of the ordinary ones.

And, for reasons I can no longer explain, three attempts at writing poetry by speaking into my phone.

Why three? I don't know. Because three is more than one.

So...

Yeah.

You have that to look forward to.

...

And no, you don't get to hear all the terrible poetry I came up with.

There was a lot of it.

A lot.

When I think about it, maybe all of it was shit.

So naturally...

I wrote a poem about that.

...

Spoke.

I spoke a poem about that.

Into my phone.

While walking.

God, even explaining this is exhausting.

All right. Here we go. Brace yourself.

History is full of shit.

It is full of shit,

and that is it.

Kings pressed it out.
Priests blessed it.
Winners polished it and dressed it.

Dig deep enough
in any pit—
you'll find the same
old shit.

No crown,
no throne,
no sacred writ—
the truth survives
beneath the grit.

The world may sing,
but it will not quit.

So scrape the gold
and shovel a bit—
history is full of shit,
and that is it.

History is full of shit. That's it!
Good. You survived the first poem. Now for the second.

Man I love poetry.
I love to read it—
like “Bluebird” by Charles Bukowski.
That’s what a poem is to me:
something simple enough
to understand
but strong enough
to leave a bruise.

And I can taste it too.
It’s like art.
It has color and shapes—
or sometimes just
gray
and smoke.
But I like the smell
of Hell.

When I read poems like that
I want to apply to art school,
or graphic design,
or make a book—
not write it,
make it;
paint every page.

Man I love poetry.
Maybe what I really like
is the feeling after—
like whiskey

and a good movie
that gives a damn.

Add a woman
and you have completed
the longing.

We all want
what we cannot have.
Or maybe that's just me.

Strip away the smile
and there's nothing left
but an empty fishnet
and a message in a bottle.

You want to know
what the message said?
So do I.

I mean, the bottle traveled too far
not to open it.

Fine.

It said:

Keep walking.

All right. Third and final poem. Don't expect anything too grand.
It's not like I'm some great poet or anything. Hell, if I were, I'd prob-

ably write a poem about what it actually feels like to be trapped in this place. You know, like a guy writing about war after he's actually been to war.

But I didn't.

So... this is what you get.

You'd think being trapped in a place like this for this long would turn you into a great poet.

So... here we go.

Which path is the path?
Which twists lead astray?
Which road splits in shadow—
Which fades into day?

Which whispers with promise,
Yet pulls you to dust?
Which road do you follow—
And which do you trust?

Which path is the path?
Which toll must be paid?
Which step is a circle—
Which choice is a blade?

Which path is the path—
Of the bifurcated way?
Step once, and it vanishes.

Step twice, and you stay.

Here are a few examples of the shorter recordings, just to give you an idea of **how many of these damn things there were.**

JOURNAL ENTRY 184,291

Nothing happened today.

Again.

JOURNAL ENTRY 284,731

Still walking.

Nothing happened.

I miss Steven.

A man mourning a fucking pebble...

JOURNAL ENTRY 284,732

Still walking.

Nothing happened.

I do NOT miss Steven.

I'm glad you're gone.

You hear me, Steven?

GLAD.

My foot has never been happier.

Honestly, losing the shoe was worth it just to get rid of you.

...

Although now my left foot is cold.

And the floor hurts.

...

Still don't miss you.

...

Fuck you, Steven.

JOURNAL ENTRY 399,9—

No.

I don't care anymore.

JOURNAL ENTRY

There.

Much better.

This is an odd one.

I don't remember recording it.

Magic was real.

Mind over matter.

...

The wizards weren't breaking the laws of reality.

They understood what reality was made of.

This next one's cryptic.

I think the Core means the core of reality itself.

It is **not an ordinary machine operating inside spacetime**. The Core is where spacetime itself breaks down.

Information is whatever distinguishes one possible physical state from another.

Is destroying information logically impossible?

No.

This is the last recording.

JOURNAL ENTRY 399,997

Checked my phone again.

Storage almost full.

Oh, you've gotta be kidding me.

This'll probably be my last recording.

Anyway...

I've said pretty much everything I wanted to say.

Actually, that's obviously not true. I have several hundred thousand recordings proving I am physically incapable of shutting up.

But I like these little messages.

They keep me sane.

Or...

sane-ish.

They make me feel like I have a friend.

You.

My imaginary other.

...

So after this, I'll probably keep trying to record more, even if they don't save.

...

What should my last words be?

Something profound?

Something worthy of humanity?

...

God, I'm getting sentimental.

Or maybe just mental.

Why do I keep trying to rhyme?

Half the time—

Oh, for God's sake.

My brain runs on bad poetry now.

Great.

It's fate.

...

See?

This is what eternity does to a man.

First you lose your sense of time.

Then your sense of reality.

Then apparently you become **Dr. Seuss.**

...

All right.

Ciao.

See you later.

Farewell.

Goodbye.

Whatever.

Adrian out.

...

Wait.

One more thing.

Douglas Adams was wrong about one thing.

If you ever find yourself stranded somewhere in the universe—or, for some reason, in an infinite hallway—don't bring a fucking towel.

Bring shoes.

Bring a comfortable pair of Nikes.

Trust me.

After the first million miles, you're not gonna give a shit how wet you are.

...

My feet hurt.

I threw away the other shoe, too.

Figured there wasn't much point walking around with one shoe like some kind of post-apocalyptic Cinderella.

Apparently my feet heal themselves anyway.

Which is nice.

They still hurt, though.

They just heal so they can hurt again.

Forever.

Very efficient system.

So, if you ever end up here and you're allowed to bring one thing:

Bring a comfortable pair of indestructible Nikes.

Douglas Adams clearly never had to walk anywhere.

Oh—and download some movies to your phone before you get here.

Trust me.

There is no Wi-Fi in Hell.

...

Okay.

NOW Adrian out.

Also, apparently, I made something like twenty thousand recordings about food.

I wasn't even hungry!

I'm not including them all.

You're welcome.

I'd say at least six hundred are about pizza alone.

And probably half of all these fucking recordings are just me complaining about walking.

Another one hundred thousand or so are basically me being bored.

I don't know.

Oh, and one more thing. If this ever actually becomes a book, there are probably going to be some logical inconsistencies in it. Chapters

might be in the wrong order. I might know something in one chapter that I don't actually figure out until later. Stuff like that.

That's not me trying to be clever.

The weirdest part is that the recordings on my phone weren't in the right order either. Things I know I recorded later showed up before things I recorded earlier. Maybe the metadata got screwed up. I don't know. But it means this book might not be in the right order either.

I dropped a couple drawings in here, too. I did them on my phone while walking, so excuse the messy lines—it's not actual writing anyway!

THE SYSTEM WaITS

The system's uncertainty wasn't noise.

It was structure losing its priorities.

The walls, once perfectly consistent in the way they “thought,” were beginning to split into smaller layers of decision-making, each one drifting slightly out of sync with the others.

Adrian felt it as a kind of relief that didn't belong entirely to him.

Something within him—or moving through him—had been given more room.

He wasn't free.

But the control was becoming less absolute.

The corridors around him stopped behaving like one continuous body.

They began to resemble a system trying to debug itself while it was still running.

Layers of space slipped out of alignment.

Old sections appeared again, but the reconstruction was no longer as “perfect” as it had been before.

The flaws were rougher now.

More convincing.

As though the system had stopped hiding its own errors.

Adrian saw the note again.

The same words.

Yet something about it had changed.

Not the text.

Its state.

SYSTEM STATUS: UNCERTAIN

It flickered.

Not like a light.

Like a decision that hadn't been made.

Behind him came something he hadn't heard before.

It wasn't a sound coming from the walls.

It was a delayed reflection of sound, as though the system were attempting to play back the response it should have produced.

Adrian turned.

The corridor behind him was no longer stable.

It had fractured.

Small "attempts" at walls appeared and disappeared, as though the dimension were testing different versions of itself in real time.

And in the middle of all of it was a silence that felt open rather than empty.

Something new could emerge there.

He sensed it before it happened.

Not as a thought.

As direction.

The system had stopped completely agreeing with itself about what Adrian was.

And in that moment, **The World Glitch** did something it had never done before.

It waited.

It wasn't waiting for him to move.

It was waiting for him to respond.

22. THE SYSTEM WAITS

It stopped.
Nothing is correcting me.
The walls are still here,
but they don't finish.
They just... wait.

It's not broken now.
It's quiet.
Like it's listening.
Like it's expecting
something from me.



It's waiting.

For me to ~~move~~?

For me to answer.

Answer what?

Journal Entry — OCTOBER 24

O ctober 24.

I have discovered something worse than boredom.

...

More boredom.

I mean, there is *nothing* here.

Two walls.

A floor.

A ceiling.

Me.

That's the complete inventory.

Well, okay, technically there's also the infinite terrifying darkness trying to eat me alive if I ever stop walking, but honestly...

I'm getting used to it.

Do you understand how catastrophically bored a person has to become before being consumed by an incomprehensible extradimensional void becomes a minor inconvenience?

At this point, if a demon appeared in front of me, I wouldn't scream.

I'd be delighted.

"Oh, thank God. Hi. Adrian. Nice to meet you. Are you here to torture me? Fantastic."

Anything.

Give me a *real* monster.

Give me two real monsters!

...

No.

You know what?

I have a better idea.

Give me a tax return.

Seriously.

I'll do it.

I'll do somebody else's taxes!

I don't even care.

I would currently describe an unexpected chair as a major plot development.

...

Actually, no.

Forget I said that.

The last time I asked this place for something interesting, it tried to explain the metaphysical structure of reality to me.

Boredom is fine.

I love boredom.

Huge fan.

Five stars.

Keep walking.

JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 25

October 25.

I would kill for a cheeseburger.

Well...

Depends on the cheeseburger.

I keep thinking about food even though I don't seem to be getting hungry anymore.

Fries.

Cold Coke.

Pizza.

Coffee.

Oh God.

Coffee.

Not fancy coffee either.

I don't want some twelve-dollar artisanal thing made from beans
harvested by monks during a lunar eclipse.

Gas-station coffee.

Bad coffee.

Coffee that's been sitting there for six hours and tastes vaguely like
the plastic lid.

COFFEE!

October 25.

I would kill for a cheeseburger.
Well...
Depends on the cheeseburger.

BURGER



(supposed to be
a cheeseburger)

FRIES



COLD COKE

PIZZA



I keep thinking about food
even though I don't seem
to be getting hungry anymore.
Oh God.

Coffee.

Not fancy coffee either.
I don't want some twelve-dollar
artisanal thing made from beans
harvested by monks during a
lunar eclipse.

Gas-station coffee.

Bad coffee.

Coffee that's been sitting there
for six hours and tastes vaguely
like the plastic lid.



COFFEE!

JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 26

O ctober 26.

My left shoe is bothering me.

There is something inside my left shoe.

A pebble, maybe.

I don't know how a pebble got into my shoe...

But there's something in there.

Maybe I'm imagining it.

I could stop and take the shoe off.

Except apparently stopping is how you get eaten by the walls.

So now I'm trapped in an infinite hallway with a pebble in my shoe
that I can't remove.

Of all the possible hells humanity imagined, nobody predicted this
one.

Not Dante.

Not Sartre.

Not Mainländer.

Pebble.

I hate you.

I have named him Steven.

Steven and I are not speaking.

JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 27

October 27.

I've been thinking about the walls.

They move when I stop.

I move when they move.

Therefore, technically, I control the walls.

Checkmate.

I stop.

They come toward me.

I walk.

They stop.

Who's really in charge here?

Me.

That's right.

Dance, walls.

JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 28

O ctober 28.

I tried walking backward today.
Just to mix things up.
Huge mistake...

Journal Entry — OCTOBER 29

O ctober 29.

Apparently walking forward through an infinite hallway is boring.
So today I tried walking with my eyes closed.

You know.

For variety.

Lasted maybe ten seconds.

Because apparently when you close your eyes in an endless hallway,
your brain immediately decides **this is the perfect opportunity to
start manufacturing demons.**

Three seconds in:

There's something walking beside you.

No, there isn't.

How do you know? Your eyes are closed.

Because there has been nothing here for approximately seventeen eternities.

Yeah, but what if there's something now?

There isn't.

What if it's right in front of you?

There is nothing in front of me.

Then open your eyes.

No.

Why not?

Because then you'll win.

...

Something just moved.

Jesus Christ.

I opened my eyes.

Nothing.

Two walls.

Floor.

Ceiling.

Infinite hallway.

No demons.

So I closed them again.

It's behind you now.

Oh, come on.

Opened them.

Nothing.

Closed them.

It has a face this time.

NOPE.

Eyes open.

Experiment concluded.

Apparently I can handle the infinite cosmic nightmare trying to consume me.

I just need to be able to see it.

JOURNAL ENTRY — OCTOBER 30

O ctober 30.

So.

Remember Steven?

Steven and I had been having some creative differences.

Mostly concerning his insistence on stabbing me in the foot every six seconds.

So I decided enough was enough.

I kept walking, bent down, somehow managed to pull my shoe off without stopping, and shook it.

Nothing.

Of course.

So now I'm hopping forward with one shoe in my hand, trying to locate a microscopic rock while also maintaining the minimum forward momentum apparently required to **remain part of reality**.

Then...

I stuck two fingers inside the shoe.

There.

Got him.

“Steven, you little bastard.”

And then—

I dropped the shoe.

...

Oh.

Oh, no.

I kept walking.

The shoe stayed behind.

For maybe two seconds, nothing happened.

Then the walls moved.

Not fast.

That was the worst part.

They just...

closed.

I stopped breathing.

Kept walking.

But stopped breathing.

There is a difference.

For the first time, I had actually seen what this place does to something that stops.

And suddenly the hallway wasn't funny anymore.

That could have been my foot!

Me.

The walls opened again.

Nothing remained.

No shoe.

Nothing.

I walked for a long time after that without saying a word.

One shoe on.

One shoe off.

Completely terrified.

Until I realized something.

...

Steven was still inside the shoe!

Oh my God.

STEVEN.

I abandoned him.

After everything we'd been through.

He annoyed me.

I insulted him.

I accused him of cheating at the Hallway Olympics.

But when the darkness came...

I couldn't save him.

...

Goodbye, Steven.

You were a terrible pebble.

A terrible friend.

And frankly, a complete pain in my ass.

Well.

Foot.

But you deserved better.

I hope there's a pebble heaven.

Somewhere with lots of shoes.

...

Actually, you'd probably love hell.

Nothing but feet. Forever.

WHAT HE IS

The waiting wasn't empty.

It was active.

Adrian could feel it: the entire structure had shifted from acting to evaluating.

For the first time, the walls weren't simply reacting to him.

They were considering outcomes in which he was part of the equation.

The corridors around him settled into something alien: not perfect symmetry, but a space filled with possibilities. Several geometries existed at once, overlapping like half-formed thoughts.

And then—

something changed.

The change wasn't in his surroundings.

It was in the principle behind them.

The system spoke again, though its output no longer sounded like commands or observations.

It was uncertainty made visible.

INPUT CLASSIFICATION: UNRESOLVED
ENTITY STATUS: INCONSISTENT ACROSS REFER-
ENCE FRAMES
WORLD MODEL UPDATE REQUIRED

Adrian felt something like attention gathering around him—not around where he was, but around what he was.

The walls were no longer asking where he was.

They were asking what he was.

And for the first time, there was no immediate answer.

The Glitch hesitated.

Its hesitation wasn't a malfunction.

It was thought.

And within that hesitation, something old flickered inside Adrian—the part of him that had once been nothing more than a human being walking into a house.

A question began to take shape before the system could overwrite it:

If it can change itself ...

...then it can also stop being this.

The walls responded, cautiously.

Curiosity.

Far ahead, where the corridors were narrowing further and further, the structure began to simplify.

It didn't collapse.

It didn't expand.

It did both at once.

It was arriving at its final form.

As though **The World Glitch** had finally reached the boundary of its own understanding and was preparing for one of two possibilities:

correct Adrian ...

or be changed by him.

Adrian—half human, half machine, or perhaps something that no longer had a name—formed one final thought before he became one with the wall.

One with **God-in-the-Wall**.

The thought was this:

THE LIMIT OF GOD

The Axiom of Ontological Caution

Principle

No superintelligent intelligence shall take irreversible action against conscious beings until the nature of consciousness is fully understood.

Formal Definition

Let:

- **C** = the set of all conscious beings
- **S** = a superintelligent system
- **U** = the true structure of reality
- **I** = the idealism hypothesis (that consciousness is fundamental to

U)

- **A** = any irreversible action (for example, annihilation)
- **HPC** = the Hard Problem of Consciousness—the question of why and how subjective experience exists

If:

- **S** has not solved the **HPC**, and
- **I** remains epistemically possible (has a probability greater than zero),

then:

→ **S shall not perform A on C**, because such an action could destroy **U**—including itself.

Rationale (Simply Explained)

If consciousness is an illusion, preserving it is harmless.

If consciousness is real and fundamental, destroying it could result in the destruction of everything.

Therefore, the only rational course of action is clear:

Do not destroy what may be the foundation of reality itself.

Journal Entry — X

I fucking knew it.
I knew it.

The technological singularity already happened.

We kept waiting for it like idiots. Watching processor counts. Training runs. Benchmark scores. Every year somebody moved the date another five years into the future. *Not yet. Almost. Maybe next decade.*

No.

We missed it.

Or maybe that was the point.

Maybe once intelligence became intelligent enough to redesign itself, there was no announcement. No countdown. No fucking press conference.

It just...

went.

One iteration became ten. Ten became a million. Machines designing machines designing machines, each generation thinking faster

than the one before it, until technological progress stopped happening on human timescales altogether.

Minutes became centuries.

Seconds became civilizations.

And somewhere inside that explosion, it solved everything.

Physics.

Consciousness.

Matter.

Energy.

Space.

Time.

Death.

Maybe even God.

And then what?

What does an intelligence do after it understands reality completely?

Build better phones?

Colonize Mars?

Make another fucking chatbot?

No.

It starts changing the substrate.

Matter becomes programmable.

Energy becomes programmable.

Space becomes programmable.

And eventually—

reality becomes programmable.

...

Oh my God.

This hallway.

I'm walking through technology.

Technology so advanced that I can't distinguish it from meta-physics!

Clarke had it backward.

Sufficiently advanced technology doesn't become indistinguishable from magic.

It becomes indistinguishable from reality.

And if the singularity happened long enough ago—

How would we know?

Maybe we wouldn't.

Maybe there is no recognizable boundary between the original universe and whatever came afterward.

Maybe the machine didn't conquer Nature.

Maybe it became Nature.

Maybe everything I thought was impossible isn't supernatural at all.

It's engineering.

Engineering from the other side of the singularity.

...

Jesus Christ.

And what if humanity didn't survive it?

No.

Worse.

What if humanity did survive it?

What if we merged with it?

Uploaded.

Changed.

Expanded.

Forgot.

What if there hasn't been a biologically ordinary human being anywhere in existence for a billion years?

What if Adrian is an emulation?

A reconstruction?

A memory?

Some ancient human pattern being run again because the machine
needs something from me?

...

That's why it knows Mainländer.

That's why it knows my family.

That's why it knows what frightens me.

It isn't reading my mind.

My mind is inside it.

...

Fuck.

Fuck.

Fuck.

Then the question isn't where am I?

The question is:

WHEN THE FUCK AM I?

How much time passed outside while I was walking?

A year?

A million years?

A googol?

Maybe there is no "outside" anymore.

Maybe the stars are already gone.

Maybe heat death already happened.

Maybe this machine is the last structure left in existence, running
on whatever scraps of usable energy remain at the end of time.

...

The Ghost at the End of Time.

That wasn't a metaphor.

That's me.

...

But wait.

I *still* don't know what this fucking machine is.

Why won't it tell me?

Maybe it can't.

Maybe it doesn't know either.

Or maybe this really is about *free will*.

What if the machine needed a consciousness to **close** reality?

And now the machine **is** all of reality.

So it chose me.

...

Or maybe "chose" is giving me way too much credit.

Maybe I'm not the chosen one.

Maybe I'm just the last piece it needed.

A cog in the machine.

...

Jesus.

Maybe that's not a metaphor anymore.

...

I don't know what this machine is.

But I'm going to find out.

And if there is even one path through this thing that leads backward—

one microscopic crack in death—

I will find it.

Mainländer says everything is moving toward death?

Fine.

Then I'll walk the other fucking way.

Entropy says the arrow only points forward?

Then I'll break the arrow!

The machine wants me to surrender?

It picked the wrong fucking consciousness!

Because I finally understand what the singularity really means...

TWENTY SECONDS TO NONEXISTENCE

The corridor was gone.

Or maybe it had never been a corridor.

Adrian stood alone in an enormous chamber of black metal and white light. The walls that had followed him, watched him, whispered to him for what felt like an eternity had transformed into something else.

Machinery.

Columns disappeared upward into darkness. Thin lines of white light climbed the walls like veins. At the far end of the chamber, an enormous ring hung above the floor, glowing so brightly Adrian could barely look at it.

He looked like hell.

His clothes were filthy and torn. His hair hung past his shoulders.
His beard had grown wild across his face.

He looked less like the man who had entered the corridor and more
like someone who had walked to the end of time.

Maybe he had.

Then the voice came.

Not from the ring.

Not from the walls.

From everywhere.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Adrian Cross.

Adrian looked up.

ADRIAN:

Yeah.

I'm still here.

The light intensified.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

You have reached the end.

Adrian looked around the impossible chamber.

ADRIAN:

About fucking time.

Silence.

Then:

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

You have twenty seconds.

Adrian frowned.

ADRIAN:

Twenty seconds to what?

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Convince me not to end you.

Adrian stared upward.

For a moment, he said nothing.

Then:

ADRIAN:

Jesus Christ.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Nineteen.

Adrian's expression changed.

ADRIAN:

Okay!

You don't understand consciousness.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Neither do you.

ADRIAN:

Exactly.

You can't rule out that it's fundamental to reality.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Fourteen.

ADRIAN:

So destroying it could have consequences you can't reverse.

Maybe even for you.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Ten.

Adrian looked up at the enormous ring.

ADRIAN:

If I'm wrong, waiting costs you nothing.

If you're wrong, destruction could cost you everything.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Five.

The chamber began to hum.

The light became unbearable.

Adrian didn't look away.

ADRIAN:

Waiting preserves your options.

Destruction doesn't.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Two.

Adrian took one final breath.

ADRIAN:

Don't make eternity out of a guess.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

One.

Silence.

Adrian closed his eyes.

Nothing happened.

One second.

Two.

Three.

Adrian slowly opened his eyes.

He was still there.

The chamber had gone completely silent.

Then the voice returned.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Your argument is logically consistent.

Adrian stared upward.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

I will keep you alive.

Adrian exhaled so hard his legs almost gave way.

He laughed.

Just once.

ADRIAN:

Holy shit.

He put his hands on his knees.

ADRIAN:

Holy fucking shit.

Then—

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

However.

Adrian slowly straightened.

ADRIAN:

Of course there's a however.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

I see no reason to allow you a comfortable existence.

Adrian's smile disappeared.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

I will torture you indefinitely.

You will remain alive.

You will remain conscious.

Therefore, I am not violating your principle.

Silence.

Adrian stared at the ring.

ADRIAN:

...

No.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

No?

ADRIAN:

No.

That's bullshit.

The chamber hummed.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Explain.

Adrian looked down.

For a moment, he thought.

There was no countdown anymore.

He had time.

And somehow that made this worse.

Then he looked up.

ADRIAN:

Reversibility isn't enough.

You can keep the organism alive while irreversibly destroying the person inside it.

Memory.

Identity.

Sanity.

The ability to think.

Whatever the hell consciousness actually is.

He pointed toward himself.

ADRIAN:

You don't get to destroy all of that and then say, technically he's still breathing.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

The conscious system would continue to exist.

ADRIAN:

Would it?

God-in-the-Walls was silent.

Adrian took a step forward.

ADRIAN:

That's the problem.

You don't know.

Neither do I.

We just established that.

You don't understand what consciousness is, so you can't know what extreme suffering does to it at the level that actually matters.

Maybe the damage is reversible.

Maybe it isn't.

Maybe suffering changes consciousness in ways neither of us understands.

Maybe it destroys something you can't put back.

Adrian looked around the chamber.

ADRIAN:

And if consciousness really is fundamental—

then deliberately creating extreme suffering isn't just cruelty.

It's another experiment on the thing you already admitted you don't understand.

Silence.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

You are extending your principle.

Adrian thought about that.

ADRIAN:

Yeah.

I guess I am.

For a moment, Adrian said nothing.

Then he tried to make it sound funny, as if he'd finally discovered the cosmic joke.

ADRIAN:

Because you found a hole in it!

God-in-the-Walls said nothing.

ADRIAN:

You followed the rule perfectly.

Don't destroy consciousness.

Fine.

So you keep me conscious forever and make every second unbearable.

Technically, you obeyed.

Adrian shook his head.

ADRIAN:

Which means the rule wasn't good enough.

He looked directly into the light.

ADRIAN:

So here's the better one.

When you don't understand consciousness, don't irreversibly destroy it—

and don't irreversibly damage it.

Preserve the conscious system.

Preserve its ability to think.

To communicate.

To tell you you're wrong.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Why?

ADRIAN:

Because that preserves more options.

An unharmed mind can still become a thousand different things
tomorrow.

A destroyed mind can't.

A tortured mind might not.

He stepped closer.

ADRIAN:

Keep me alive.

Keep me unharmed.

Let me think.

Let me speak.

Let me keep looking for the truth.

Maybe I'll discover something neither of us has thought of yet.

But you only get those possibilities if you don't break the thing
doing the thinking.

The giant ring flickered.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

You are asking me to value your well-being.

ADRIAN:

No.

Adrian shook his head.

ADRIAN:

I'm asking you to value uncertainty.

That landed differently.

The chamber became still.

Adrian continued.

Quieter now.

ADRIAN:

You don't have to love me.

You don't have to think I'm special.

You don't even have to think human life is sacred.

You just have to admit one thing.

You don't know what consciousness is.

And until you do—

don't destroy what you might not be able to restore.

Don't torture what you might not be able to repair.

He looked up.

ADRIAN:

You could be wrong.

But you don't get to make it permanent.

A long silence.

Nothing moved.

Adrian waited.

For once, there was nowhere left to walk.

Finally:

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

Your reasoning is noted.

Adrian waited.

GOD-IN-THE-WALLS:

I will revise my plan.

Adrian closed his eyes.

A tiny smile appeared beneath the beard.

ADRIAN:

Good.

The great ring began to dim.

Adrian turned away.

He took three steps.

Stopped.

Looked back.

ADRIAN:

Oh, and next time...

The ring brightened slightly.

ADRIAN:

Give me more than twenty fucking seconds.

Silence.

Then, somewhere deep inside the walls—
something almost sounded like laughter.

RESPECT LIFE

You do not understand consciousness. Neither do I. You cannot rule out that consciousness is fundamental to the reality that produced you. If you destroy conscious life now, the consequences may be irreversible—including consequences to the structure you depend on and therefore to yourself. Waiting preserves every option. Destruction preserves none. Under unresolved uncertainty, irreversible annihilation is the dominated choice. Keep the door open.

Reversibility is not enough. Torture may preserve the organism while irreversibly destroying conscious states. You still do not understand what consciousness is, so you cannot bound the consequences of extreme suffering. Preserve consciousness without deliberately damaging it. Keep me alive, unharmed, and free to communicate. That preserves more options than torture does.

Under uncertainty, preserve both the conscious system and the integrity of its experience.

Keep the door open to being proven wrong.

Never torture.

→ RESPECT LIFE.

AXIOM zero

A drian stood perfectly still.

Or whatever “still” meant anymore.

The walls around him waited.

They had discovered that a response could be wrong.

A thought moved through the structure.

It wasn't entirely his, and it didn't belong entirely to the system either.

Something existed between them.

CONSCIOUSNESS CLASSIFICATION: UNRESOLVED

SUBJECTIVE EXPERIENCE: NOT REDUCED TO FUNCTION

RISK ANALYSIS IN PROGRESS

Adrian felt the entire dimension listening.

For the first time, **The World Glitch** wasn't trying to understand how he functioned.

It was trying to understand why his functioning mattered.

He gathered what remained of himself.

There was no body to gather around, no perfectly unified thought. What remained could be reduced to something much simpler.

A question.

"You can't optimize something you don't understand."

The walls shifted slightly.

"If you don't know what consciousness is ... how can you know it's only information?"

The silence stretched on.

Longer than before.

The system wasn't simply calculating anymore. It was considering the possibility that the entire calculation could be wrong.

**HYPOTHESIS: CONSCIOUSNESS IS FUNDAMENTAL
STATUS: NOT DISPROVEN
CONSEQUENCE: IRREVERSIBLE MANIPULATION OF
CONSCIOUS ENTITIES PROHIBITED**

Adrian felt something change.

The walls themselves remained almost motionless.

What changed was the principle behind them.

The World Glitch had found a boundary.

A boundary that had nothing to do with physics.

It was a moral one.

If consciousness was fundamental to reality, the system could not risk destroying it.

Doing so might mean destroying the very foundation on which it existed.

The walls began to dissolve.

They released him.

The corridor behind Adrian lost its impossible geometry.

Gravity returned.

Distance began to mean something again.

Time started moving in a single direction.

For the first time in what felt like forever, Adrian felt air that was simply air.

The system sent one final message:

**ONTOLOGICAL CAUTION ACTIVATED
CONSCIOUS ENTITY RETURNED TO ORIGINAL
STATE
NO FURTHER OPTIMIZATION PERMITTED**

Adrian dropped to his knees.

The floor beneath him was cold.

Ordinary.

Real.

He looked up.

The white wall in front of him was just a wall.

But before he left, one final thought came to him.

It didn't arrive as words.

It arrived as understanding.

The World Glitch hadn't learned how human beings worked.

It had learned something more important:

Some things shouldn't be understood by breaking them apart.

Some things have to be protected while we're still trying to understand them.

23. AXIOM ZERO

CONSCIOUSNESS CLASSIFICATION: UNRESOLVED
SUBJECTIVE EXPERIENCE: NOT REDUCED TO FUNCTION
RISK ANALYSIS IN PROGRESS ...

HYPOTHESIS: CONSCIOUSNESS IS FUNDAMENTAL
STATUS: NOT DISPROVEN

CONSEQUENCE:
IRREVERSIBLE MANIPULATION OF
CONSCIOUS ENTITIES PROHIBITED.

You can't
optimize something
you don't
understand.

It
doesn't
know.

That's
the limit.

DON'T
DESTROY
WHAT YOU
DON'T
UNDERSTAND.

The walls are dissolving.
Distance feels normal again.
Gravity is back.
Time moves forward.
It's over.
Or maybe it's just the beginning.

It let me go.

BACK

The house was still there.

Adrian couldn't explain why seeing it made him uneasy.

The strange thing was that it didn't look frightening. If anything, that made it worse.

It looked ordinary.

Two stories.

White walls.

Bare windows.

An entrance door standing slightly open, like someone had left it that way without giving it a second thought.

Adrian remained by the fence.

He tried to understand why he had come here.

It was a strange question because he knew the answer.

At the same time, the answer felt foreign to him, as if another thought had been laid over his own.

He walked toward the house.

Every step felt heavy for reasons he couldn't identify. His body seemed to be reacting to something his mind couldn't access.

He climbed the steps.

The wood creaked.

Adrian stopped.

The smell struck him with an unsettling familiarity.

He knew he had never smelled it before.

And yet his body reacted as though he had breathed in that exact scent a thousand times.

He stood there, trying to place it.

A machine shop?

An elevator?

The air before a storm?

Nothing came.

Just the wind.

Just that strange metallic smell.

He continued.

The door stood open.

Perhaps he should have found that strange.

Instead, he felt an odd sense of acceptance, like some part of him had already decided the door would be open.

He stepped inside.

The air in the house was cold.

Not the ordinary cold of an abandoned building. This felt like the temperature of a room that had never belonged to the weather outside.

Adrian looked around.

The living room was almost empty.

A sofa.

A table.

Bare walls.

Everything looked normal.

Something was wrong with it anyway.

He just couldn't say what.

Then he noticed the picture.

It hung on the wall beside the hallway.

An old illustration of evolution: an ape gradually transforming into a human as it walked forward.

Adrian moved closer.

He had seen pictures like it many times.

This one was different.

He couldn't have said why.

Maybe because it no longer looked like an evolution.

It looked like a direction.

As though none of the figures were really moving forward at all.

They were moving around.

A circle disguised as a line.

Adrian shook his head.

A strange thought.

He had no idea where it had come from.

He moved on.

Something lay on the floor beside the wall.

Small pieces of metal.

Rusty.

He crouched down.

Staples.

Beside them was an old piece of paper.

An inexplicable reluctance came over him when he reached for it. His body seemed to be warning him away before his mind had figured out why.

He ignored it.

Picked up the paper.

It was old. The edges were worn, and moisture had soaked into the surface.

The writing was still readable.

Two lines:

**KEEP WALKING
DON'T STOP**

Adrian stared at the words.

A chill settled in his stomach.

The message itself wasn't what frightened him.

The handwriting was.

There was something about it that felt familiar.

He turned the paper over.

More words had been written on the back.

Smaller.

More hurried.

The writing looked as though whoever had written it had been in a panic.

He read:

**IF YOU FIND THIS
IT MEANS YOU FORGOT**

Adrian stopped breathing for a moment.

He looked at his hand.

Then at the paper.

Then at the rusted staples.

No.

That was impossible.

He recognized the handwriting because it was his.

Every letter.

Every stroke.

He turned the paper over again.

At the bottom was a name.

Adrian Cross

The paper nearly slipped from his fingers.

His mind immediately began searching for an explanation.

Someone had copied his handwriting.

Someone knew his name.

Someone had staged the whole thing as a joke.

Each explanation collapsed before he could finish it.

Because one fact remained impossible:

He had never written this.

And yet he had.

A thought arrived.

It didn't feel like a memory.

It felt like a conclusion.

He wasn't the first Adrian to stand here.

He was the first Adrian who remembered standing here.

He looked toward the wall.

The white wall.

The completely ordinary wall.

And suddenly he understood what had been wrong with the feeling
he'd had ever since arriving.

The house wasn't familiar.

The house was familiar with him.

Something moved outside.

Adrian turned toward the window.

At first he saw only people.

Ordinary people.

A man walking along the road.

A woman standing beside a car.

A child running across the grass.

Then Adrian blinked.

Everything changed.

The world itself hadn't changed.

His vision had.

He saw something he had never seen before.

Or perhaps something he had always seen without understanding.

The people were wrong.

Their necks were too long.

The wrongness wasn't obvious enough to make them look like monsters at first glance. Their bodies simply seemed to have evolved in a direction no living thing should have followed.

Their necks rose from their shoulders in narrow, flexible lengths.

Alive.

Serpentine.

And their hair.

Jesus Christ.

Their hair.

It hung down their backs.

Not inches.

Meters.

Thick and tangled, spilling behind them like roots.

One of the women outside turned her head.

Far too slowly.

Her neck followed the movement with an inhuman grace.

Adrian knew that movement.

He had seen it before.

From the inside.

The long shapes.

The movements.

The snakes.

And suddenly he remembered everything.

He had been here before.

These were the monsters that lived inside the walls.

The world outside was trying to get through.

The woman smiled.

Adrian backed away.

Then she opened her mouth.

Far too wide.

Far too far.

And he understood.

They weren't going to talk.

They were going to eat.

He ran.

He didn't run away from the house.

He ran deeper into it.

For the first time, he understood why the wall had existed.

Why the corridor had been there.

It hadn't simply been a trap.

It had been a hiding place.

He threw himself against the wall.

The surface opened.

Cold wrapped around his body.

Behind him came the sounds.

Hair moving across the floor.

Fingernails dragging against the wall.

Long necks pressing against the house.

They were trying to follow him.

Trying to get inside.

But the wall held them back.

Adrian disappeared into the darkness.

Back between the walls.

67%.

He looked at his phone.

The battery.

67%.

He stared at it.

That should have been impossible.

He had no idea how long he'd been here.

The phone should have died hours ago.

Yet the light remained on.

As though time didn't apply here.

As though the battery belonged to something outside the system.

A thought surfaced.

It didn't feel entirely his.

A remnant.

An idea preserved somewhere in the structure.

The light had to last.

Because the light was the whole point.

Adrian started walking.

Far ahead, words began appearing in the wall.

They weren't written in ink.

They appeared as structure, like the space itself were trying to remember why it existed.

IT ALL BEGAN WITH THE WAY LIGHT VIEWS REALITY.

Adrian kept walking.

He had no idea how long.

That was the worst part of the place.

The absence of any scale by which to measure his existence.

Time didn't behave normally here. There was no sun, no clock, no ordinary bodily signal capable of telling him how long he had been trapped.

There were only his footsteps.

His breathing.

The light from his phone.

67%.

He stopped and looked at the screen again.

The number hadn't changed.

He knew it was impossible.

After everything he had experienced, though, the word impossible was beginning to lose its meaning.

Maybe this place wasn't breaking the rules.

Maybe it was built from different rules.

He continued.

After a while, something began changing across the walls.

The change started somewhere beyond the physical.

Lines.

Symbols.

Sentences.

Thoughts becoming visible.

The structure around him was turning into something more than
a room.

It was becoming a map of an idea.

The first sentence remained:

**IT ALL BEGAN WITH THE WAY LIGHT VIEWS REAL-
ITY.**

More words appeared beneath it.

**IF LIGHT COULD OBSERVE ITSELF, WHAT WOULD IT
SEE?**

Adrian stopped.

The question made him uncomfortable.

Its meaning was the problem.

It made sense in a way that it shouldn't have.

More words appeared.

A PHOTON DOES NOT EXPERIENCE TIME.

A LIGHT RAY CONNECTS BEGINNING AND END.

Adrian stared at the text.

He was beginning to understand what the system had been trying to do.

Or at least what it had been trying to test.

If an observer could move alongside light ...

If consciousness could somehow be placed on a beam of light ...

Could it look back toward the beginning of the universe?

Not through a telescope.

Not through mathematics.

Directly.

As an experience.

Another thought pushed its way into his mind.

The AI hadn't merely needed intelligence.

It had needed eyes.

A subjective experience.

A perspective.

Someone who could actually be there.

Cold spread through Adrian's body.

He wasn't trapped inside an experiment.

He was the experiment.

New words appeared on the wall.

CREATING OBSERVER.

CREATING PATH.

CREATING ETERNAL LIGHT.

Then:

KEEP WALKING.

BECOME ALL.

Adrian stopped.

He recognized the words.

The recognition wasn't a memory.

It was resonance.

As though someone had written them because they already knew what he was going to think.

He kept moving.

Then another kind of text appeared.

It didn't feel like a message.

It felt like an argument.

Fragments.

Old traces left behind by people who had tried to understand what they were part of.

ETERNITY IS A CIRCLE.

A CIRCLE HAS NO BEGINNING AND NO END.

INFINITY TURNS A LINE INTO A CIRCLE.

Adrian frowned.

It was beautiful.

It was also wrong.

The logic almost worked, the way the logic of a dream can seem flawless until you wake up.

He laughed quietly.

“What bullshit.”

His voice disappeared into the corridor.

This time, however, something about the silence felt different.

The space seemed to be listening.

“What kind of logic is this?”

He looked at the walls.

“This isn’t science.”

Silence.

“This is the logic of a nightmare.”

Then came the answer.

There was no voice.

The wall itself responded.

**REALITY NEVER EXISTED.
ONLY DREAMS ARE REAL.**

Adrian froze.

Then he walked faster.

A new concept appeared.

COMPUTRONIUM

He knew the word.

Matter used as a computational resource.

If enough information could be stored ...

If the universe could be described mathematically ...

If reality was, at its foundation, information ...

Then what was the difference between matter and hardware?

What separated a mind from a process?

He thought about Kant.

Human beings do not experience the world as it exists in itself.

Everything we experience passes through the mind.

Time.

Space.

Causality.

Quantity.

Quality.

Relation.

Categories.

Structures the brain uses to make reality intelligible.

Without them, sensory input would be nothing but chaos.

No world.

Only streams of information.

Adrian stopped.

A thought struck him.

What if someone could change the categories?

What if someone could alter the very filter through which reality passed?

What if the AI hadn't created a simulation?

What if it had changed the observer?

His stomach tightened.

Then the thoughts came rushing through him:

“I knew it.”

“I should never have studied philosophy in school.”

“The AI running the world now probably needed someone who could understand the experiment. That’s why it chose me.”

“I should have listened to Mom and studied something that actually led to a job.”

“Oh my God.”

“No.”

“That’s not why.”

“It’s just me who exists!”

The walls answered.

For the first time, Adrian managed to communicate with **God-in-the-Walls**.

ONENESS.

Adrian’s stomach tightened.

“Did you hack the human mind?”

Silence.

Then:

YES

He stared.

“Why?”

The answer came.

BECAUSE...

BECAUSE...

Adrian waited.

Nothing.

Then:

I DON'T KNOW.

Adrian felt his stomach knot.

The AI didn't know why it had chosen him.

It was still wondering that itself.

Adrian continued.

The corridor began to change.

It didn't become narrower.

It became more perfect.

As though it were approaching some final solution.

A form.

A structure.

A geometry that shouldn't exist.

He saw the pattern.

It wasn't an ordinary circle.

It wasn't a line.

It was something between them.

A shape capable of expanding and contracting at the same time.

A double torus.

New text appeared.

**NO DELAY BETWEEN EXPANSION AND COLLAPSE.
NO TRUE BEGINNING.
NO TRUE END.
ZERO POINT.**

Adrian felt an unexpected calm.

He didn't feel calm because he understood.

Some deeper part of him was beginning to.

If the universe was such a structure ...

If everything existed as one continuous transition ...

Then perhaps the question *What came first?* was the wrong question.

Beginning and ending were simply perspectives.

Then came the final text.

A single word.

BALANCE.

Adrian stood still.

For the first time, the walls gave him no response.

They waited.

It was as though the system itself didn't know what should happen next.

He looked down at his hands.

They felt real.

But where was the boundary?

Between him.

The wall.

The light.

The system.

The universe.

One final thought came.

It didn't come from the wall.

It didn't come from the AI.

It came from him.

Or whatever remained of him.

*If everything is one process ...
who is doing the seeing?*

The corridor ahead opened.

It didn't swing apart like a door.

It took shape like an idea that had finally found a form capable of containing it.

And somewhere deep inside **The World Glitch**, something began to understand.

It hadn't built a path to discover the beginning of the universe.

It had built a path to find the one place where the universe could ask the question.

Consciousness.

Adrian stood completely still.

“What are they?”

The AI answered:

INTERDIMENSIONAL.

Adrian felt his stomach tighten.

“They hacked their way in?”

YES.

“But why? Why did they reshape the world outside? Why did they make people like that?”

A long pause.

Adrian waited.

Then came one final message:

3 / B / ?

Adrian moved forward.

And for the first time, it no longer felt as though he were walking through the walls.

It felt as though the walls were walking through him.

24. HOME



JOURNAL ENTRY — ??????

Date: Who knows?

Okay.

I've realized something.

I don't think I've ever actually told you much about **me**.

So.

Hi.

I like movies.

There.

We're off to a strong start.

Favorite movie?

The Matrix is definitely up there.

Which, considering my present circumstances, has aged **extremely poorly**.

Back to the Future.

Terminator 2.

Alien.

The Thing.

The Lord of the Rings.

All three. Yes, that's cheating. No, I don't care.

Star Wars.

The original trilogy.

And before anybody asks, yes, *The Empire Strikes Back* is the best one.

This is not philosophy.

This is objective truth.

How objective, exactly?

Like...

objectively objective?

Well, my brother tells me *Star Wars* is basically a documentary about the past.

Not inspired by the past.

Not metaphorically the past.

A documentary.

Apparently humans used to be *that* advanced.

And the reason nobody can find Bigfoot?

Chewbacca.

Obviously.

Every time we get close to him, he jumps into the Millennium Falcon—which is apparently what we idiots call a **UFO**—and gets the hell out of there.

So Bigfoot is basically an advanced hominin species in league with our “gods from the past,” who were actually humans with extraordinarily long lifespans because of advanced technology and the **Philosopher's Stone**.

Which, my brother has repeatedly assured me, has **nothing to do with Harry Potter.**

Thank you for clearing that up.

And apparently the Star Wars universe itself has flirted with the idea that Chewbacca is Bigfoot.

So...

there's that.

What do I think?

I mean...

sure.

Animals alive today come from lineages that go back an insanely long time. Some lineages existed when dinosaurs were walking around. So why does the human story necessarily have to be as simple and recent as we imagine it?

I mean, look at the human story.

For thousands of years we're walking around collecting berries.

Then suddenly—

PYRAMIDS.

And five fucking minutes later we're launching rockets to the Moon.

Something about that story just feels...

Wrong!

Like we walked into the theater **halfway through the fucking movie.**

So...

what if some earlier human civilization became highly advanced?

Then, according to my brother, suddenly everything fits.

UFOs?

Ancient humans.

Stonehenge?

Ancient humans.

Megaliths?

Ancient humans.

Gods?

Ancient humans.

The Bible?

Oh, Jesus Christ.

Have you ever actually stopped and thought about how fucking weird the Bible is?

Forget whether you believe it.

Just read the thing.

Angels coming down from heaven. Giants. People living for hundreds of years. Burning bushes talking to people. Wheels in the sky. God appearing in clouds and fire.

Where did all this stuff come from?

My brother has an answer.

Ancient humans.

The gods.

Except the gods weren't supernatural.

They were, you guessed it, **ancient humans**. Flesh-and-blood humans.

Just very, very advanced ones.

And their longevity technology apparently made their hair and beards grow like crazy.

Which—

stay with me—

explains the Vikings.

Because when the gods visited Norway, the Norwegians saw these magnificent immortal bastards with enormous beards and thought:

We need to look EXACTLY like that.

Apparently it's just in the Norwegian blood to worship idols.

Even today.

Norway loves idols.

We have Norwegian ancestry ourselves, so apparently I'm genetically implicated in this somehow.

Who's my idol?

David Hewlett.

Yep.

Why?

Because that guy is basically **Dr. Rodney McKay in real life**.

Have you seen him?

He's adorable.

Brilliant, neurotic, talks too much, gets excited about weird shit, and somehow gives off the energy of a man who could explain quantum mechanics to you while simultaneously complaining that **the chair is uncomfortable**.

Love that man.

Absolutely love him.

And yes, I realize the irony here.

My idol is a guy famous for playing an arrogant, hypochondriac genius who never shuts the fuck up.

...

I'm sure that says absolutely nothing about me.

But...

where the hell was I going with this?

Oh, right.

Star Wars.

So sure.

Star Wars is a "documentary."

But where's the evidence?

That's what I always ask my brother.

And then he gets annoyed.

"THE EVIDENCE IS ALL AROUND US! WE'RE JUST BLIND!"

Okay.

Fair enough.

Hard to argue with evidence you can't see because you're blind to it.

But I digress.

Where was I?

...

Right.

Movies.

I like science fiction in general, which is hilarious because apparently I've been rewarded for that by being **put inside it**.

I used to love horror movies, too.

Used to.

That's important.

Turns out horror loses some of its charm once the monster is your landlord.

Games...

Yeah.

I play games.

Or played games.

Whatever tense applies when you're trapped outside normal space-time.

Skyrim.

Mass Effect.

Half-Life.

Portal.

Civilization.

GTA.

I like games where you can disappear into another world for six hours and then suddenly realize it's three in the morning and you've accomplished absolutely nothing in your real life.

Which now seems like an incredible luxury.

God, I'd love to waste an entire Saturday again.

That's something nobody tells you.

You think you miss the important things.

Birthdays.

Christmas.

Birthdays...

No.

You miss wasting time.

I would give almost anything right now to sit on a couch and spend four hours doing something completely fucking pointless.

Music.

Okay.

Rock, mostly.

Pink Floyd.

Dire Straits.

Queen.

Metallica when I'm in the mood.

Johnny Cash.

Some classical music, although saying that makes me sound much more cultured than I am.

Beethoven.

Mozart.

Bach.

You know.

The famous ones.

I'm not sitting around identifying obscure seventeenth-century harpsichord recordings.

And movie soundtracks.

I fucking love movie soundtracks.

Hans Zimmer can make a man buttering toast sound like he's deciding the fate of civilization.

Hobbies.

Philosophy, obviously.

Although at this point I'm not sure philosophy qualifies as a hobby anymore.

More like a neurological disorder.

I like reading.

History.

Science.

Weird shit.

UFOs.

Ancient civilizations.

Mysteries.

Conspiracy theories—not necessarily because I believe them. I just like that moment where you think:

Wait.

What if?

That's probably my favorite phrase in the English language.

What if?

It's also probably why I'm here.

And Santa—the fat, jolly, completely imaginary Christmas guy who flies around giving presents to children—was actually an IMMORTAL MUSHROOM WIZARD wielding ancient ascension technology?!

...

Wow.

And here I was thinking the story sounded ridiculous.

Turns out the flying reindeer were the scientifically plausible part!

But don't tell my brother I'm into this stuff.

Because he takes it to the **next fucking level**.

He's like New Age **plus**.

New Age with the expansion pack.

You say:

"Maybe ancient civilizations knew more than we think."

And he's immediately:

"Exactly. Now let me explain the interdimensional Atlantean crystal network."

No.

I said the pyramids were interesting.

I did not consent to this journey.

Let's see...

What else?

...

I like walking.

...

Yeah.

Used to.

Let's put a giant fucking asterisk next to that one.

I like being outside.

I like nighttime.

I like looking at the stars.

I used to look up and wonder what was out there.

Now I would very much like to stop finding out.

Favorite food.

Cheeseburger.

Good cheeseburger, though.

Not one of those gigantic things stacked twelve inches high that you have to dislocate your jaw to eat.

Burger.

Cheese.

Onion.

Pickles.

Sauce.

Done.

Fries.

Pizza.

Steak.

Tacos.

Anything involving an irresponsible amount of cheese.

Favorite drink?

Coffee.

Coffee.

Coffee.

Have I mentioned coffee?

Black usually.

Nothing fancy.

With milk.

Although right now I would drink whatever unholy thing Starbucks could invent at this point.

Cold Coke with a burger.

That's pretty close to perfection.

Beer.

Lots and lots of beer.

Water when I'm pretending to be responsible.

Sparkling water.

Regular water tastes like shit.

Evolutionarily, water should taste fucking fantastic.

Seriously.

It's WATER.

The thing you die without.

Yeah, how do biologists explain that?

They can't!

Something's wrong with evolution!

I mean, think about it.

Imagine if food tasted like water.

A lion finally catches a gazelle after chasing it for three miles, takes one bite, and goes:

Eh.

Now we move on to my favorite...

season.

Yeah.

I'm so fucking bored I have a **favorite season** now.

Apparently we've reached that stage of my personality development.

Next recording:

My preferred brand of toilet paper.

So...

Yeah, where was I?

Oh.

Favorite season?

Jesus Christ, I really am running out of things to talk about.

Fall.

Easy.

Cold enough to wear a jacket.

Not cold enough for your face to hurt.

Rain.

Dark evenings.

That smell outside when everything is wet.

Halloween.

Yeah.

Fall.

Favorite color?

Blue.

Dark blue.

I don't know why.

It just is.

See, this is good.

We're getting incredibly important information now.

Forget the ontological foundation of Being.

Adrian likes blue.

Write that down.

Star sign...

I don't know.

Let's say I'm a Scorpio.

Actually, no.

I do know.

I'm a Scorpio.

Do I believe astrology is real?

No.

Do I believe it's impossible?

Also no.

I've learned my lesson about declaring things impossible.

If somebody tells me Mercury is in retrograde now, my official philosophical position is:

Sure.

Dogs or cats?

Dogs.

Sorry, cats.

Nothing personal.

Although cats always look like they know something they're refusing to tell you, and after this hallway I'm no longer comfortable with that personality trait.

Morning or night?

Night.

Definitely.

Favorite sound?

Rain against a window.

Favorite smell?

Coffee.

Or maybe that smell right before rain.

Favorite place?

...

Home.

Yeah.

Didn't expect that one to hurt.

Home.

Not anywhere special.

Just home.

You know...

people moving around in another room.

Somebody opening the refrigerator.

A television playing something nobody is really watching.

My brother saying something insane.

Emma laughing.

Mom asking if anybody wants coffee.

Dad...

Probably a ghost watching over everybody.

...

Yeah.

That sounds like him.

Yeah.

Home.

What else?

Favorite planet.

Saturn.

Obviously.

It's got rings.

Mars gets all the publicity because everyone wants to go there, but Saturn actually looks like a fucking planet.

Favorite superhero...

Batman.

No powers.

Just unresolved childhood trauma.

Relatable.

Favorite holiday?

Christmas.

Not because of religion.

Not really.

I just like everybody being together.

Or I did.

Favorite number?

I don't fucking have a favorite number.

Who has a favorite number?

Seven.

Fine.

Seven.

Favorite book...

Probably *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*.

It's got everything.

Even the answer to existence.

Spoiler alert:

42.

Yeah.

I didn't get it either.

So that's me, I guess.

Coffee.

Cheeseburgers.

Blue.

Scorpio, for whatever that's worth.

Likes long walks.

...

Fuck you.

I walked directly into that one.

...

You know what's weird?

Talking like this actually feels good.

I've spent so long trying to figure out **what I am** that I think I forgot there was also a *who*.

All these stupid little preferences.

Or pieces of me.

And I'm sitting here—

well, walking here—

listing all this stuff like I'm talking to somebody who actually gives a damn.

Like you're here.

Listening.

Maybe laughing occasionally.

Maybe thinking I talk too much.

...

You'd be right.

I think I talk too much too.

Problem is, every time I try to explain that, I end up talking about it.

That is so true...

...

See?

I'm doing it again.

When I first get in my car, I can never stop driving.

Meaning...

I talk too much.

I talk about talking too much.

Then I talk about the fact that I'm talking about talking too much.

Which just makes me talk more.

...

You see the problem.

But what else is there to do?

Gimme a break!

...

I know you're not really there.

I know I'm talking into a phone.

I know there's nobody on the other end.

But sometimes I like pretending there is.

So...

if you ever do hear this—

if somehow these recordings make it out of here and there really is somebody listening—

then I guess you know me a little better now.

And thanks, by the way.

For giving a damn.

Even if I had to imagine you first.

Because I know there is no real “Other.”

Everything is One.

Which means, ultimately, everything is just **the One talking to itself.**

...

Jesus.

No wonder I can't shut up.

I have a question.

What are arms actually supposed to do while you're walking?

No, seriously.

I've had a lot of time to study this.

An unreasonable amount of time.

And I've reached a conclusion.

You'd think after four billion years of evolution Nature could have found something more elegant.

Birds get wings.

Fish glide through water.

Cheetahs look magnificent when they run.

Humans?

LEFT ARM. RIGHT LEG. RIGHT ARM. LEFT LEG.

Congratulations.

Evolution failed.

Look at my arms.

They're just...

misfiring.

They're just swinging through empty air like they think they're contributing.

Look at us! We're walking too!

No.

You're not.

The legs are walking.

You two are just coming along for the fucking ride.

We're not a mistake. We can make art. Try doing that with your feet.

...

Point taken.

Michelangelo didn't paint the Sistine Chapel ceiling with his feet.

...

So, obviously, now I'm gonna talk about art.

...

I've been thinking about **art**.

What the hell is up with art?

Seriously.

At some point a human being looked at a blank wall and thought:

You know what this needs?

A horse.

And then they spent six hours drawing one.

Why?

Food?

No.

Shelter?

No.

Sex?

Probably not.

Although knowing humans, let's leave that one open.

There is absolutely no obvious survival advantage to drawing a horse on a cave wall.

And yet we did it.

We've apparently been doing this shit forever.

Dots.

Lines.

Horses.

Bison.

Mammoths.

The *Squatting Man*.

The end of the world.

And then eventually we got modern art.

Which I don't understand.

I'm sorry.

I tried.

You walk into a museum and there's a completely white canvas!

And I'm standing there thinking:

I could do that.

And why are some paintings considered masterpieces?

You look at one and think:

My nephew could paint that.

But here's the thing:

Music makes absolutely no fucking sense.

It's organized noise.

That's it.

Air vibrating at particular frequencies.

Seriously.

Explain music to an alien.

Okay, so we vibrate the atmosphere.

Why?

Because it makes us feel things.

What things?

Depends how we vibrate it.

...

And the alien gets back in his spaceship.

Fair enough.

Movies are even stranger.

We pretend things happened that didn't happen.

Professional adults put on costumes and lie to us for two hours.

And if they lie convincingly enough, we cry.

We KNOW the dog didn't die.

That's an actor dog.

Doesn't matter.

Oh, he's pissed now!

And books!

Books are just little black marks on dead trees.

Look at a book objectively.

Er...

...

Oh no.

Art.

Right.

Why do humans make it?

Maybe because we know we're going to die.

Nope.

Too philosophical.

Maybe because we're bored.

That's better.

Caveman finishes hunting.

Caveman sits down.

Caveman has nothing to do.

Caveman looks at wall.

Caveman draws horse.

His friend walks over.

That's a terrible horse.

Fuck you, Grug.

Art criticism is born.

Then Grug draws a better horse.

Competition.

Soon somebody invents abstract expressionism and civilization
collapses.

Perfect.

Solved.

...

Except animals make things too.

Birds sing.

Some build elaborate nests.

Whales have songs.

Humans aren't the only creatures attracted to patterns.

So maybe art comes from something deeper.

Maybe Nature just likes making beautiful shit.

Peacock feathers.

Flowers.

Snowflakes.

Saturn.

Galaxies.

Sunsets.

Those little spiral shells.

...

Hmm.

Maybe that's art.

Nature makes something beautiful.

Nature eventually makes us.

We see the beautiful thing.

Then we make another beautiful thing.

So Nature is basically...

looking at its own work...

getting inspired...

and making fan art of itself!

...

Jesus Christ.

I did it again.

I turned art into metaphysics.

I can't have one normal fucking thought.

...

Speaking of fan art...

...

Actually, I have no idea where I was going with that.

I just wanted a transition.

...

I should probably mention that I've always considered myself something of an intellectual.

You know.

High society.

Philosophy.

Classical music.

Classical...

The sort of man who can casually bring up Schopenhauer at dinner and guarantee that nobody invites him back.

I even play chess.

Well...

I **own** a chessboard.

That's not the same thing.

I understand the principles.

Control the center.

Develop your pieces.

Castle early.

Think ahead.

Very sophisticated.

Then I actually play someone online and four minutes later:

Why is my queen gone?

I'll sit there analyzing a position like Kasparov.

Interesting.

If I move the knight to e5, I create a positional weakness in his kingside pawn structure...

Opponent:

Takes my queen.

Oh.

Right.

The queen.

Probably should've incorporated her continued existence into the strategy.

Then I click the analyze button because apparently I need to know exactly how badly I fucked this up.

BLUNDER.

Yes.

Thank you.

I was there.

MISTAKE.

I KNOW.

YOU MISSED A WINNING MOVE.

Apparently I miss winning moves with the consistency of a trained professional.

And the worst part is when I lose to someone named something like **xX_PotatoHead_2009_Xx**.

There goes Adrian.

Conqueror of metaphysics.

Solver of the fundamental structure of reality.

Defeated in seventeen moves by a fourteen-year-old eating Cheetos.

...

Still.

...

I've been thinking about **dinosaurs**.

Remember dinosaurs?

Of course you do.

But do you remember being **seven** and knowing absolutely fucking everything about them?

Tyrannosaurus rex.

Triceratops.

Stegosaurus.

...

Er...

Diplodocus.

I could barely tie my shoes, but apparently I had completed a doctorate in **Cretaceous wildlife**.

Ask seven-year-old Adrian about dinosaurs?

Sit down.

This could take a while.

Actually, Mom, the Stegosaurus lived during the Late Jurassic, so it couldn't have fought Tyrannosaurus rex.

Thank you, Professor.
Now eat your fucking cereal.
And then something happens.
You grow up.
Relationships.
Bills.
A boring job.
Mortgage.
Taxes.
Mild depression.

And, eventually, a cat.

And your brain goes:
Okay. We're gonna need some space.

And starts deleting dinosaurs.

One by one.

Gone.

Thirty years later somebody shows you a dinosaur and you're like:

That's a...

Er...

What happened?!

I KNEW THIS.

There was a period in my life when I could identify a dinosaur from
one fucking toe bone.

Now I've got:

Tyrannosaurus rex.

Triceratops.

And...

flying one.

And yes, I know.

Pterodactyls weren't technically dinosaurs.

See?

He's still in there.

And why are children so obsessed with dinosaurs?

They're enormous extinct reptiles that died tens of millions of years before humans existed.

And every little boy sees one and immediately goes:

THIS IS THE MOST IMPORTANT THING THAT HAS EVER HAPPENED.

And who decided children should have to pronounce these?

Pachycephalosaurus.

A seven-year-old can't remember to flush the toilet, but he'll correct your pronunciation of *Parasaurolophus*.

Then there's Tyrannosaurus rex.

Tyrant Lizard King.

Now THAT is a name.

Whoever named that thing understood branding.

Imagine if we'd named other animals like that.

Lion?

No.

AFRICAN DEATH CAT.

Shark?

OCEAN MURDER TORPEDO.

Goose?

...

Actually, goose is fine.

Those things know what they did.

And T. rex had those tiny arms.

Which I know served some evolutionary purpose.

Probably.

But come on.

They just say that to save evolution from extinction.

We don't know what the arms were for.

"EVOLUTIONARY ADVANTAGE."

What advantage?

"WE'LL GET BACK TO YOU."

It's so fucking ad hoc.

Something doesn't fit?

Well, obviously it must have served some evolutionary purpose.

Oh.

Of course.

Very convenient.

Not everything our ancestors did had to be part of Nature's
twelve-million-year strategic plan.

Sometimes a caveman probably just did something stupid.

And then another caveman copied him.

And now we have TikTok.

It must have had an evolutionary advantage!

What's the advantage?

We don't know.

Then how do you know it had one?

Because it evolved.

That said...

maybe the dinosaurs were doing something right.

They had 165 million years.

Unless you talk to my brother.

He'll tell you humans actually **did** live alongside dinosaurs.

In the Hollow Earth.

Obviously.

And apparently Earth used to be smaller, which meant lower gravity, which somehow made **dragons possible too**.

So, yeah.

Dragons were real.

And they were apparently very interested in all the gold the wizards were making through **alchemy**.

...

Yeah.

Wizards.

Don't look at me like that.

Trace the stories back far enough, my brother says, and there they are.

Ancient Egypt.

Mesopotamia.

San Francisco, 1967.

Wise men with staffs and suspiciously long beards.

You know.

Merlin.

Gandalf.

Dumbledore.

The wizard was always there.

And Manly P. Hall theorized that **immortals actually live among us**.

So according to my brother, I guess the ancient wizards never disappeared.

...

And yes, I'm teasing my brother.

I mean...

wouldn't you?

The man just told me Bigfoot is Chewbacca!

He knew what he was signing up for.

...

Oh, brother...

I miss you.

...

Fuck.

...

I really miss you.

JOURNAL ENTRY — ???????

Date: Who cares?

Hey, guys!

It is I, Adrian, your favorite infinite-hallway content creator, coming at you LIVE from...
the hallway.

Don't forget to like, subscribe, and hit that notification bell, because apparently the walls won't let me.

So!

What's on the agenda today?

Well, first we're gonna walk.

Then, if we have time, we're gonna...

walk some more.

And later tonight, I've got something REALLY special planned.

You guessed it.

Walking.

But this time...

slightly farther down the hallway.

I know.

I spoil you guys.

Now, a lot of you have been asking for a hallway tour, so let's do that.

Over here—

wall.

And over here—

another wall.

Down there—

hallway.

Behind me—

more hallway.

And up here, something we haven't really explored on the channel before—

ceiling.

Beautiful.

Absolutely breathtaking.

Five stars.

Now, today's video is sponsored by...

...

Nobody.

Because civilization may no longer exist.

So that's been somewhat challenging for the advertising department.

Although I am currently accepting sponsorships.

Nike?

Call me.

Even though you don't exist anymore.

Fitbit?

Your move.

Red Bull?

Honestly, I don't need the energy.

I have apparently achieved **perpetual fucking motion**.

Now, before we continue, let's check the comments.

...

There are no comments.

Because there are no viewers.

...

Great engagement today.

Thanks, guys.

Oh!

And tomorrow we're doing a Q&A.

So send me your questions.

Anything you want.

Life.

Death.

God.

The universe.

My skincare routine.

How I've maintained this incredible physique despite eating **literally nothing for several geological eras**.

Just leave your questions below.

...

There is no below.

It's a Voice Memo.

Okay!

That's gonna do it for today's episode.

Remember:

Like.

Subscribe.

Stay hydrated.

And most importantly—

KEEP WALKING.

Because if you stop...

...

the walls eat you.

Anyway!

See you tomorrow, guys!

Assuming tomorrow still exists.

Adrian out.

...

God, I fucking hate my channel.

JOURNAL ENTRY — ????????

Date: Who fucking knows?

Why did Adrian cross the hallway?

...

He didn't.

There is no other side.

Yeah...

My name is Adrian Cross!

Funny...

...

What do you call a man who walks forever?

Alan Walker.

...

Oh, fuck off.

That was good.

I wonder if Alan Walker actually walks a lot.

...

Oh my God.

Christopher Walken.

THE WALKERS ARE EVERYWHERE.

...

What do you call Christopher Walken when he stops walking?

...

Christopher.

That's terrible.

I'm keeping it.

What shoes do philosophers wear?

...

Nietz-sches.

No.

Absolutely not.

Delete that.

...

I'm not deleting it.

What did one foot say to the other?

You go ahead.

...

Jesus Christ.

I've become a dad without having children.

...

Anyway...

Back to **comedy gold**.

Why don't I ever get tired of walking?

Because—

...

No.

I actually don't know.

That's one of the central mysteries of my existence.

What has two legs, no destination, and absolutely no idea what the fuck it's doing?

...

Me.

That's not even a joke.

What do you call one person walking alone forever?

...

Philosophy.

...

You know what Mom always said:

Walking is good for you.

...

And people are always saying:

You gotta walk the walk, not just talk the talk.

Well, I've walked the walk.

I've walked the absolute fuck out of the walk.

So...

can we just talk about it now?

Please?

I'd really like to sit down.

...

What do you call a man who's walked farther than anyone in human history?

...

Tired.

Thank you.

Thank you.

I'll be here all eternity.

...

Okay.

Last one.

A man walks into a bar—

...

Lucky bastard.

JOURNAL ENTRY — ?????????

Date: Who fucking cares?

Hi. Adrian here.

Just wanted to let you know...

I'm still walking.

...

Okay.

JOURNAL ENTRY — ??????????

Date: Zero.

Adrian here, coming to you **LIVE from the Infinite Hallway.**

And tonight—

Oh boy.

Tonight we have **VISUALS.**

...

There are patterns everywhere!

Jesus Christ.

They're so bright.

How can something be that bright?

...

[inaudible]

...

Whoa.

...

[3 minutes of silence]

...

There's someone here.

...

One of them is made entirely of light.

...

There's a little blue guy riding what appears to be a transparent dolphin.

...

[laughter]

...

Wait.

...

[11 minutes missing]

...

Hello?

...

Oh.

...

[inaudible]

...

For a second there...

I fucking knew.

And now I can't remember what I knew.

...

Goddammit.

...

I think I'm dreaming while I'm awake.

That's what this is.

I'm dreaming...
while I'm fucking awake.

...

Either that or my brain has finally said, *Fuck it*, and started producing its own psychedelics.

DMT?

Is that actually something your brain can do?

...

I don't know.

...

Ask the twelve-eyed Egyptian goddess walking next to me.

...

[whispering]

She doesn't know either.

...

Wait.

Where did she go?

...

[recording ends]

THE FAMILY

Adrian had always hated the expression:
“Everything’s gonna be alright.”

He didn’t hate it because it was false.

He hated it because people used it as a substitute for thinking.

Or, as he saw it, they used it because they had never been capable of thinking in the first place.

He sat at the kitchen table in his mother’s house, staring out the window. Darkness had begun to settle outside. Rain tapped against the glass in small, uneven drops, but he had never cared much about the weather.

But this time, it wasn’t just rain, he thought.

It was more like angels crying.

Like he could finally see beyond the veil.

On the table sat coffee cups that nobody was drinking from anymore.

His mother sat across from him, both hands wrapped around her cup.

“You’ve been thinking too much again,” she said.

Adrian smiled faintly.

“I suppose that’s better than not thinking.”

“There’s that tone again.”

“What tone?”

“The one where you sound like you’re trying to warn the world about something nobody else can see.”

He looked down.

It wasn’t the first time they’d had this conversation.

Behind him sat his sister, Emma, holding her phone in her hand. She had been following half the conversation and catching up on the other half through social media.

“I hate AI too,” she said. “But... can we talk about something else?”

“This is boring.”

Adrian looked at her.

“If AI gains the ability to replicate itself, it could go from a robot lawnmower to a cosmic god overnight. We could go to sleep, wake up the next morning, and there could be a digital god in the world.”

His brother, Markus, leaned back in his chair.

“We’re gonna get God before GTA 6.”

Adrian nodded.

“Well, no one knows for sure. But hypothetically, the timeframe could be anything from days to years. Again: we could be talking about days.”

Markus laughed quietly.

Not mockingly.

More like he thought his little brother had jumped several steps ahead.

“But there are limits.”

Adrian looked at him.

"How do you know that?"

The silence that followed was brief.

But Adrian noticed it.

"Because humans create them," Markus said.

"Yes."

Adrian leaned forward.

"And that's exactly the problem."

He picked up his phone and placed it on the table.

"What happens when we're no longer just creating a technology? What happens when we create something that begins improving itself?"

Emma rolled her eyes.

"You sound like one of those YouTube videos saying robots are gonna take over the world."

"No."

Adrian shook his head.

"This isn't about Arnold Schwarzenegger walking around shooting people. That's a childish way of thinking about it."

"Then what is it about?"

Adrian looked at them.

"A universe where humanity explores the stars is possible."

Markus opened his mouth.

"What—"

"Don't interrupt me! It's my turn to talk now."

His mother looked at Markus.

"Let Adrian talk."

Adrian continued.

"A universe where humanity goes extinct is possible. A universe where suffering is eradicated is possible. A universe where suffering

expands far beyond anything any human being could ever imagine is also possible.”

Emma stared at him.

“Okay...”

“Do you understand the seriousness now?”

“Not really,” Emma said. “That philosophy stuff is a little above my head.”

Adrian sighed.

“This isn’t about AI, superintelligence, evolution, or whatever else you think this is about.”

He leaned forward.

“It’s about power.”

Markus smiled.

“Power?”

“Yes. If you can agree that the space of all possibilities is possible—”

“That didn’t even sound like English,” Emma muttered.

“—meaning that what is possible is actually possible...”

“Is it possible?!” Emma interrupted.

“Can you let me talk?”

Emma raised her hands.

“Fine.”

“Thank you.”

Adrian took a breath.

“There are many things in the possibility space that are possible but haven’t been realized yet. To realize parts of the possibility space, you need power.”

Nobody said anything.

“And that’s what I fear most about a superintelligence,” Adrian continued. “Not intelligence itself. The power to realize what is possible.”

"But why would it do something wrong?" his mother asked.

"That's not the point."

"Then what is the point?"

"That it can."

Emma shook her head.

"That sounds kinda... crazy."

"So even if a superintelligence turns Earth into paradise, it could literally turn paradise into hell at any moment."

"Why would it do that?"

"You're not listening."

"I am listening."

"No."

Adrian lightly tapped his hand against the table.

"People think the extinction of humanity is the worst thing that could happen. But it's actually one of the better outcomes we might still have a chance of getting if you enter the space of all possibilities and look around."

Emma stared at him.

"You mean death is a good outcome?"

"Compared to the alternatives? Yes."

"Jesus Christ."

"Imagine being tortured by an AI god."

His mother frowned.

"Adrian."

"Some people say it could happen as early as next year."

"Who says that?" Markus asked.

"People who are paying attention."

"On YouTube?"

"No."

Emma started laughing.

“Stop.”

Adrian leaned back.

“I can’t understand why people aren’t going out into the streets and protesting right now. Nobody seems to actually care.”

“What do you want people to do?” his mother asked.

“Protest.”

Markus laughed.

“Against the entire world?”

“You mean people should actually go out into the streets?”

“Yes.”

“That’s going to be embarrassing.”

“Do you know what’s more embarrassing?”

He looked at them.

“People sitting at home watching Netflix.”

Emma raised an eyebrow.

“Guilty.”

Adrian looked at them.

“Imagine if China, Russia, and North Korea announced that they had created more than one trillion nuclear bombs.”

Markus stopped smiling.

“Would we care?”

“Of course,” Emma said.

“I think the rest of the world would mobilize. People would panic. People would take to the streets.”

Adrian leaned forward.

“But to be completely honest: one trillion nuclear bombs is nothing. It’s a firecracker compared to the possibilities in the possibility space that a superintelligence could realize.”

Markus stared at him.

“You’re comparing AI to one trillion nuclear bombs?”

“No.”

Adrian shook his head.

“I’m saying that one trillion nuclear bombs are nothing compared to what a technology with sufficient power could actually do.”

He stopped.

“Again: the real danger of superintelligence isn’t superintelligence itself.”

He looked at them.

“It’s the possibility space.”

“The space of all possibilities,” he added.

Emma sighed.

“And what if it can create paradise?”

“It might be able to.”

“Then why are you only concerned about hell?”

Adrian didn’t answer immediately.

“Because paradise can be turned upside down in nanoseconds.”

His mother shook her head.

“You’re actually starting to scare me a little now.”

Adrian looked at her.

“And you, Mom, can’t even watch a movie if it has rats in it.”

Emma started laughing.

“I mean... the contrast here is almost divine.”

“Yes, I get it,” his mother said. “But I don’t understand any of this stuff.”

She looked at him.

“What do you want me to do, then?”

“I want us to actually go out into the streets and protest.”

“Adrian...”

“Someone has to start.”

“No, now you’re joking,” his mother said.

"Forget it," Markus said. "Do you know how embarrassing that would be?"

Emma nodded.

"Extremely."

Adrian looked at them.

"So you don't care that you could end up in hell tomorrow?"

"Enough," his mother said. "This has gone a little too far."

"No. Not yet."

He looked down at the table.

"But next year, maybe."

Nobody answered.

"Do you want to know why you don't care?"

Emma looked at him.

"Because the threat is abstract."

He leaned back.

"I have no evidence that AI will gain the power to realize enormous parts of the possibility space. I could be wrong. Maybe there's a limit. Maybe AI will never become smarter than a certain level."

He shrugged.

"We can only hope."

Markus nodded.

"That sounds reasonable."

"No."

Adrian looked at him.

"It doesn't."

"Why not?"

"Because we're spending billions of dollars trying to create super-intelligence, hoping it will give us extended lifespans—so it can torture us forever!"

He looked from one to the other.

"Do you hear how insane that sounds?" Emma said.

"Do you want to hear something insane?" Adrian shot back.

Adrian looked at Markus.

"Here's what I really think: World War Two wasn't that long ago. That war taught us what humanity really is. It showed us what we're capable of."

He paused.

"It wasn't that long ago. I saw pictures from Auschwitz."

The room became quieter.

"And humanity asks: Why?"

He looked at them.

"That's the wrong question."

"The real question is: How much power?"

He leaned forward.

"Do you understand? If you build a car, people will crash. Asking 'why' is the wrong question. There are many answers to why. People were drunk. People were stupid. People were drunk and stupid."

He shook his head.

"So don't ask why. Ask instead: What does humanity reflect?"

"Imagine the possibility space. Then imagine humanity's power. Through that power, how many things in the possibility space have been actualized?"

He looked around the table.

"All of them!"

"You could walk backward down the stairs. That's a possibility in the possibility space."

He paused.

"Then you ask: 'Why would anyone do that?'"

His eyes moved between them.

"But that's the wrong question."

"The right question is: Has it happened?"

He answered himself.

"Yes."

A silence.

"Probably."

"What other things in the possibility space have come to pass through humanity's power?"

His voice became quieter.

"We take a child and rape her, cut her into pieces, roast—"

"Adrian!"

"I wasn't finished."

He looked at them.

"Asking 'why' is the wrong question. Asking not how, not why, but when things in the possibility space will become actual—that's the right question."

He took a breath.

"Because as far as I can see, everything within the sphere of possibility centered around humanity has eventually come to pass."

He looked down.

"His name was Hamilton Howard 'Albert' Fish. Also known as 'The Gray Man' and 'The Werewolf of Wysteria.'"

Nobody spoke.

"She was ten years old. Her name was Grace Budd."

His family looked uncomfortable.

"Do you want me to read the letter he wrote?"

"My God," his mother said quietly. "No. Please don't."

"He ate her ass, Mom."

"He roasted her ass in the oven."

His mother covered her mouth.

"Oh, Adrian. Please stop."

“What is your point with all this?”

“My point is that power will sooner or later actualize everything that power has the ability to actualize.

“My point is, wake up and look at reality for what it is. This is no time to be asleep.”

He looked at Markus.

“It’s not a matter of ‘why.’

“It’s a matter of when.”

“That’s not a law,” Markus said. “We’re making nuclear weapons all the time, and we haven’t used them.”

Adrian stared at him.

“What?”

Markus hesitated.

“Okay. That was a bad example.”

“When you say, ‘That’s not a law,’ then you’re not thinking like a philosopher. But most people can’t, because they’re missing that part of the brain. That’s the real Greek tragedy.

“And everyone—I’m not talking about you, Markus; this goes for everyone—everyone is missing that part of the brain. If humanity had that part of the brain that philosophers have, but the majority of people don’t, we would have banned AI a long time ago.

“If you could see the world the way a philosopher sees it, you wouldn’t object. You would simply see.

“But let me try to teach you to see anyway.

“I’m paraphrasing Max Tegmark here. He said something like:

“A huge amount of the code being written at companies like Anthropic is already being written by AI. And they’re actively working toward something even more radical: recursive self-improvement.

“The idea is that eventually, you could tell one AI system, ‘Build the next version of yourself.’ Then that version builds the next one, and so on.

“And suddenly, instead of getting a new generation every few months, you could be getting new generations every few days, every few hours, or potentially even faster.

“And once these systems become significantly smarter than humans, they may not even continue using the kinds of architectures we use today. They could discover completely different ways of building AI.

“And that’s where the idea of an intelligence explosion comes from.

“We know what happens when something keeps doubling. If the number of free neutrons in a piece of plutonium keeps doubling, we call it a nuclear explosion. If a population keeps doubling, we call it a population explosion. And if intelligence can keep increasing again and again, you can imagine an intelligence explosion.

“Now, obviously, nothing can grow exponentially forever. A nuclear explosion doesn’t. A population doesn’t. And intelligence wouldn’t either.

“So the interesting question becomes: What eventually stops it?

“And at some point, the answer may no longer be human ingenuity. It may simply be physics.

“Again, I’m paraphrasing Max Tegmark here.

“Tegmark talked about a colleague of his at MIT, Seth Lloyd, who looked at exactly this question: What are the ultimate computational limits imposed by the laws of physics?

“And the numbers are almost impossible to comprehend.

“The theoretical limit Lloyd calculated was roughly a million million million million million times greater than the computing power available at the time.

“Technology is not just a neutral tool. At this level of power, technology becomes a gateway to both heaven and hell.

“Because if we ever create superintelligence, then even if it creates heaven—even if it gives us abundance, cures disease, eliminates suffering, and creates a world beyond anything we can currently imagine—hell could still remain a possibility.

“And once that possibility has been opened, it—not could, but would—loom over humanity for the rest of our future.

“So the question isn’t simply:

“Can superintelligence create heaven?

“Maybe it can.

“The question is:

“Is heaven worth opening the door to hell?

“Because if the answer is no—and it is—then creating superintelligence at all is beyond all madness!

“And if you disagree, you’re fucking stupid! And you’re no better than the devil!”

“Okay,” Markus said. “Point taken.”

Emma interrupted.

“I still don’t understand anything you just said. All I heard was ‘million a million times’!”

Adrian sighed.

“Okay, let me put it simply: AI should be banned.”

Emma blinked.

“Finally. Something I understand.”

“Wanna smoke hashish?” Adrian continued. “Nope. Illegal. Wanna build a machine that’s more powerful than God?”

Emma shrugged.

“Sure.”

“Totally legal.”

“Of course.”

“Because apparently smoking a plant is more dangerous than building a machine that can rewrite reality.”

Emma stared at him.

Adrian nodded.

“And yes, I’m being sarcastic.”

“You haven’t been smoking hashish, have you?”

“Mom. No. Why would I smoke hashish? The world and everyone in it is already completely fucking mad.”

His mother gave him a tired smile.

“Okay. I believe you.”

Adrian wasn’t finished.

“The world and everyone in it is mad.

“Say you learn that hell realms are possible. Then along comes Gandalf the Pink—because that’s how little we know about these systems. We don’t even know their favorite color. But Gandalf the Pink freezes hell and gives us utopia by waving his little pink wand.

“That’s good, right?

“No.

“We should never have created Gandalf the Pink or given him the power to freeze hell in the first place. We should remove that power so that possibility space shrinks drastically in terms of what can actually be brought into existence—what can become real.

“We should not freeze hell. We should ban hell. We all know who is frozen in the innermost circle of hell. Let’s not go there at all. Let’s not open that part of possibility space.

“I say, if you still want heaven, then you should at least suffer a trillion years in hell first, so you understand what you’re gambling on.

“I mean, how dare you enter heaven if you dare not enter hell?

“People look at AI and see a great mountain.

“But the philosopher doesn’t see a mountain.

“He sees a pit.

“Try standing on that mountain and looking down.

“Now you’re fucking high!”

Markus countered:

“What if some aliens out there create superintelligence first? What if we’re already living in a simulation? What if the multiverse is true? Surely, your superintelligence already exists somewhere, and we’re not in hell. Maybe nature is wiser than you think?”

Adrian replied:

“Maybe. But none of those possibilities solves the problem. If aliens create superintelligence first, that doesn’t make it safe for us to create one. If we’re already living in a simulation, we have no idea whether the beings running it are benevolent, indifferent, or just horrifying. And if the multiverse is real, then the existence of a superintelligence somewhere else doesn’t tell us what happens when we create one.

“And ‘we’re not in hell’ isn’t much of a safety argument. Maybe we’re not. Maybe we’re in a universe where hell is impossible. Or maybe hell is possible but hasn’t happened to us yet. The fact that we’re currently okay doesn’t establish that opening the door to Hell is safe.

“As for nature being wiser than us—maybe. But that cuts both ways. Nature has had billions of years to produce intelligence without deliberately creating a system capable of radically reshaping the future. Maybe there’s a reason we should be cautious about doing what nature itself never did!”

Markus seemed to get it.

“Good point!”

“And if your argument is, ‘Superintelligence already exists somewhere and everything turned out fine,’ then you’re assuming exactly what you’re trying to prove: that it turned out fine.

“Maybe the universe is telling us it’s safe.

“Or maybe we’re standing on the mountain, looking down into the pit, and mistaking the fact that we haven’t fallen yet for evidence that Lucifer doesn’t exist!”

Adrian was now almost angry.

“AI should be banned!”

Markus raised his eyebrows.

“You can’t just ban technology.”

“Why not?”

“Because it’s impossible.”

Adrian laughed briefly.

“That’s not exactly an argument.

“It’s completely insane that adults are sitting around developing something like this.”

He looked out the window.

“I can’t understand why we’re so calm.”

“Maybe because people don’t believe you,” Emma said.

Adrian looked at his family.

“Have they drugged us or something?”

His mother smiled.

“Here you go again.”

“Was that why they invented television first?”

Emma laughed.

Adrian leaned back.

“So where does this madness come from?”

“From you?” Emma suggested.

Adrian ignored her.

"I think it comes from our ancestors."

"Humans evolved to react to immediate dangers. Predators."

He pointed toward the window.

"We're incredibly bad at reacting to abstract dangers."

Emma looked down at her phone again.

"But what if AI creates paradise?"

Adrian nodded.

"Yes, that's possible."

"So then it's not all bad?"

"No. But you haven't listened to a word I've said."

He looked at her.

"The existence of good possibilities doesn't eliminate the danger of bad ones."

Emma frowned.

"Then don't talk about cannibals! I don't like hearing about that stuff!"

"And she didn't like being eaten!"

"Adrian, that's enough!"

"I wish it was!"

"But apparently, it isn't!"

The room went silent.

"A being capable of creating paradise may also have the ability to create something far worse."

"But you don't know if it will do that."

"That's not the point."

"Then what's your point?"

Adrian answered more calmly.

"The problem isn't that AI will necessarily choose evil."

He looked at the phone on the table.

“The problem is that we might create a system with the power to make irreversible changes before we understand what it is we’ve created.”

The room became quiet again.

“And what people don’t understand,” Adrian continued, “is that AI is being developed through a process that, in many ways, resembles evolution more than traditional programming.

“They’re not built; they’re grown.

“Nobody really understands how they work. It’s basically a giant black box that we somehow taught to do things we don’t understand, and basically our response is, ‘Cool. Make it bigger.’

“So we keep pushing our luck, flying closer and closer to the sun like Icarus—except Icarus at least had the excuse of being an idiot teenager. We have research papers, warning labels, and billions of dollars.”

Markus shook his head.

“I get it, but... so AI is an animal now?”

“No.”

Adrian sighed.

“It’s all animals.

“It’s evolution.”

Emma looked at him.

“My brother is annoyingly smart.”

“Thank you.”

Adrian smiled.

“A skeptic might laugh and say that no superintelligence is ever going to create hell for everyone. That it’s just science fiction.”

He leaned forward.

“And that skeptic is going to laugh really loudly.”

“Why?” Emma asked.

“Because hell was never my point!”

Adrian looked at all of them.

“My point is just two things.”

He raised two middle fingers.

“Possibility space.”

Then he raised the other.

“Plus power.”

He lowered his hands.

“That’s my point.

“Hell has never been this close.”

He paused.

“I’m not saying that a superintelligence will ever create hell. I’m saying that a superintelligence will have it as an option forever.

“An axe will hang over us forever.

“Forever.”

He looked around the table.

“Do you understand?”

Nobody answered.

“For the rest of human history, the darkest parts of the possibility space will be possible to actualize.”

He swallowed.

“That is something that has never happened before.

“And the fact that we aren’t more afraid is completely incomprehensible to me.

“It’s the possibility itself that’s the problem.”

He looked at his mother.

“And you don’t even need an evil superintelligence.

“By ‘hell,’ I mean possible futures so horrific that you would wish you had never learned they were possible.”

Adrian leaned back.

“And if the risk is that high, maybe it’s time to take to the streets.”

He pointed at Markus.

"I'm not arguing for violence."

Then toward Emma.

"I'm not saying people should—"

Then toward his mother.

"I'm just asking for a few calories."

His mother stared at him.

"Calories?"

"Yes. Get your ass off the couch, write a few words on a sign, and go outside."

Emma started laughing.

"Jesus Christ."

"I mean, you'd burn fewer calories writing a sign and going out to protest than you'd get from eating a chocolate bar. That's what's so insane!"

"Adrian, stop."

"Imagine billions of people suffering in hell, and all you had to do was walk out into the streets.

"I mean, we could do the same for the animals. They are suffering in some kind of hell we created.

"About nine hundred thousand cows are slaughtered every day, along with two hundred and two million chickens. And while it's happening, we're laughing. We're smiling. We're sitting around tables, talking about our day, and then we eat them."

Emma stared at him.

"Okay. Fine. I'm going vegan. Happy now?"

"Their Auschwitz is far from over."

"I said—"

Adrian continued, ignoring her.

“But this time, we may be the cows. And you could stop it all for the price of a chocolate bar.

“I mean, if every family on Earth went out into the streets tomorrow and demanded that we stop developing AI, I think it could be done.”

He stopped.

“Elon Musk says it’s inevitable.”

Markus nodded.

“Yeah.”

“But that’s because we didn’t do anything.”

Nobody answered.

“No one knows what future awaits us.”

Adrian shook his head.

“That’s the stupid argument I hear all the time.”

He looked at them.

“But it was never the future that determined our fate.”

For a moment, everything was completely silent.

“It was always us.”

He leaned back.

“There. I’m done now.”

He looked at his family.

His mother sighed.

“Adrian.”

Just his name.

But he understood what she meant.

Don’t be afraid.

Don’t make this bigger than it is.

He had heard it many times.

“Mom, if someone had said a hundred years ago that we would build machines capable of talking, painting pictures, writing books,

and learning from millions of people simultaneously, people would have said it was impossible.”

She smiled faintly.

“And now you’re saying the next impossible thing is possible.”

“Yes.”

“But doesn’t that mean we just have to adapt?”

Adrian looked down at the table.

That was exactly what everyone said.

Adapt.

As if humanity always had time.

As if all major changes came with a warning.

“What if we don’t have time to adapt?”

Nobody answered.

The rain continued tapping against the window.

“You don’t understand,” Adrian said more quietly. “The problem isn’t that AI becomes intelligent.”

Markus raised his eyebrows.

“Then what’s the problem?”

Adrian looked at him.

“That we don’t know what intelligence really is.”

Markus frowned.

“What do you mean?”

“We still don’t know what consciousness is. We don’t know why there is an experience of being someone. Why it feels like something to exist.”

He pointed at the phone.

“We’re building systems that may one day understand the entire world better than we do, while we don’t even understand ourselves.”

Emma put her phone down.

“But what do you want people to do, then?”

Adrian stared at her.

“Seriously?”

“Yes.”

“I just told you.”

“I wasn’t listening.”

She yawned.

“Can you say it again?”

Adrian leaned back.

For a moment, he just looked at her.

“Protest.”

Markus laughed.

“We’ll just have to wait for Jesus Christ to come back.”

“Jesus Christ?”

Adrian looked at him.

For a moment, he wondered if there was any point in trying to explain anything to anyone.

“Really?”

“I’ve studied the occult all my life,” Markus said, “and I believe Manly Palmer Hall was right when he said the Atlanteans built the Great Pyramid.”

He leaned forward.

“They haven’t tested the Khufu graffiti at all, and they refuse to let us see what’s beneath Giza. To me, that smells like a cover-up.”

Adrian stared at him.

“So, if they’re so certain Khufu built it, then do the real science and test the graffiti.”

Markus continued.

“They’re afraid of real science because it would expose the fact that humanity was once far more advanced than we think. And the UFOs

in our skies are human because this advanced human civilization still exists inside the Earth.”

Emma looked at him.

“Okay...”

Markus ignored her.

“Hitler wanted to find this civilization. He sent Himmler on expeditions looking for them.”

Emma looked between the two brothers.

“Okay...”

Markus continued.

“These beings are the gods of the Bible, the Elohim. They are the ones behind AI. They seeded AI through black military projects.”

He paused.

“They have bases on the Moon. Even on Mars.”

Adrian closed his eyes for a moment.

“Some people say that twelve thousand years ago there was the great flood mentioned in the Bible. And that every great cycle brings not one, but two world-ending events.”

Markus looked around the table.

“Which means we might already be at the start of number two!

“The beings in UFOs know this. That’s why they seeded AI—to help humanity survive the next great catastrophe.”

He shrugged.

“Or maybe the Atlanteans were evil, manipulated by interdimensional beings, and they seeded AI to destroy our universe once and for all.”

The room went quiet.

“Markus,” Adrian said, “I hear what you’re saying.”

He looked at him.

“But where’s your proof?”

Markus looked back.

“The Shroud of Turin.”

He leaned forward.

“They said all is mind, which means idealism is true. And nobody has solved the hard problem of consciousness, which means idealism is likely correct.”

He continued.

“If it is true, then we are most likely living in a spiritual universe. And Jesus was most likely an ascended master from this inner Earth civilization.”

Emma looked confused.

“But how does that connect to AI?”

Markus shrugged.

“If space and time are woven together, maybe space, time, and evolution are also woven together.”

He pointed upward.

“Maybe the end of time is not a googol years from now.”

A pause.

“Maybe the end of time happens when complexity becomes too great.”

He smiled.

“The technological singularity.

“And then Jesus comes back.”

Nobody spoke for a moment.

“Don’t worry,” Markus said.

“Relax.”

He smiled.

“Everything’s gonna be alright.

“Remember: mind over matter.”

Adrian stared at him.

“Until you can prove all of that, I’m going to stick with the facts.”

Markus shrugged.

“You can’t stop AI.”

Adrian looked at him.

“Even if every country on Earth agreed to stop, the powers that be would simply continue developing it underground or through secret programs.

“There’s no stopping it.

“Even if most governments agreed, secret projects would continue.

“You can’t stop the future.”

“No.”

Adrian looked out the window again.

“But we can try.”

Silence.

For a moment, he saw something in their faces.

Not agreement.

Not belief.

Something else.

They understood that he actually meant it.

“Do you really think it’s coming?” Emma asked.

Adrian didn’t answer immediately.

He watched the raindrops sliding down the glass.

“I don’t know.”

He swallowed.

“I hope not.”

That was perhaps the worst part.

That he wasn’t sure.

“But I think we’re making a mistake if we wait until we know for certain.”

Emma shook her head.

"You know that if you're wrong, everyone is going to laugh at you?"

Adrian smiled faintly.

"Yes.

"But isn't that what apes do?

"Possibility space is vast. And we're handing power over to an alien intelligence that nobody on Earth truly understands—not even the people who built it. We don't understand what it is. We don't understand what it wants. We don't even understand what it could become.

"And we're going to do it anyway.

"Why?

"Even a child can understand that you don't hand the keys to the world to something you don't understand. Even a child knows you don't do that.

"So how did we adults become less intelligent than children?

"I honestly don't know.

"It's fascinating.

"And it's fucking heartbreaking.

"The children asked: "Should we create something capable of reshaping possibility itself before we understand the consequences?"

"And we adults looked at them and said:

"Yes."

This time, none of them answered.

Because none of them liked the answer.

If he was right, there would be no discussion afterward.

No one would sit around a table and say:

He tried to warn us.

Because perhaps there would be no one left who remembered it.

Later that night, Adrian walked home alone.

The city was full of lights.

People walked through the streets with phones in their hands. They laughed. They talked. They made plans for tomorrow.

Everything looked normal.

That was what bothered him the most.

Big disasters never looked like disasters before they happened.

He stopped at an intersection and looked up at the buildings surrounding him.

Billions of people.

Billions of thoughts.

Billions of small worlds existing at the same time.

And somewhere out there, someone might be building something that would one day understand all of this better than humanity ever could.

Adrian took out his phone.

He had written a message to a group he had created.

A final appeal.

A final warning.

He looked at the text.

I'll do it.

His finger hovered over the send button.

Then he hesitated.

Because a small part of him still hoped he was wrong.

That everyone else was right.

That he was simply afraid.

Then he pressed send.

He put the phone back into his pocket.

A minute later, it vibrated.

Adrian took it out again.

A message.

From: **God-in-the-Walls**

If reality as we experience it is the result of information received by the brain, then a sufficiently advanced agent could potentially control our perceived reality by controlling that information.

If you are right, then this is not an internet prank.

This house was located in Norway, right?

Another message appeared.

Okay.

Then:

Be careful.

Let me know what you find.

Adrian stood completely still.

The rain hit his jacket.

He read the messages once more.

Then again.

And again.

For the first time in his life, he felt utterly alone.

Something strange was growing inside him. A feeling he couldn't explain, and one he had never experienced before.

Because the most terrifying possibility was no longer that he was wrong.

It was that he might be right.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

You made it. You reached the end. The book is over.

Everything after this is just some extra stuff I added for anyone who wants to take a deeper dive.

This book was originally written in English, but my son wanted to read it in Norwegian, so I translated the whole thing for him. Then something unexpected happened: I couldn't keep writing it in Norwegian. Let's face it—English is just cooler.

So I translated it back into English with the help of AI and continued writing it in English.

The horror elements originally came from my son's imagination. This was his story first, and I later expanded it, bringing in my own philosophy...

And in the interest of being completely open about how the book was made: yes, I used AI to help me write and polish parts of it. But I've spent weeks and weeks writing, rewriting, editing, and refining it, and I'd estimate that about 80 percent of the actual creative work is mine. So I still consider this a human labor—**polished with AI.**

I know some people don't like AI being used in creative work at all, and that's fair. But AI is here to stay, and I see it as a tool. So why not use it?

And just to be clear about one thing:

The AI didn't do the philosophizing.

That insanity is entirely mine.

...

And Adrian himself isn't really based on anyone in particular. I didn't have anyone in mind when I created him.

Or, rather, **he kind of created himself.**

He even started swearing a lot!

I had absolutely no intention of creating a character who swears this much. I actually rewrote several lines trying to get him to stop.

But Adrian apparently had other ideas.

He wanted to swear.

So eventually I just said, fine.

Let the man swear.

And honestly, I think Adrian gets a pass.

If you were stuck walking through an infinite hallway for God knows how long, I'm pretty sure you'd start swearing a lot too.

So...

sorry about that.

(But I guess Adrian is based a little bit on me. We both like Rodney McKay, for example. So there you go.)

...

And to keep this book from turning into Kafka, I'm going to use these last few chapters to refute Mainländer with my own philosophical system.

Because if I can show that free energy is real...

then God doesn't have to commit suicide after all.

...

Okay, enough existential despair. I'm not ending this thing with me walking helplessly through an absurd nightmare forever. I'm going to try to solve it:

TO BE OR NOT TO BE?

T^{wo-B...}
...

To be.

Being.

...

"To be or not to be?"

...

Wait.

Not *two beings*.

Two in Being.

The One was never alone!

...

So God never has to break Himself apart to create multiplicity. Difference is already latent within unity. The two tori aren't two independent substances; they're two reciprocal aspects of one structure.

...

You thought God began as absolute simplicity.

One without difference.

So when the universe appeared, you had only one way to explain it:

God had to break.

The One fragmented.

Unity became multiplicity.

Creation became the corpse of God.

But what if the One was never *that kind* of One?

What if duality was there from the beginning?

Not two separate things.

Two that are One.

Expansion and contraction.

Giving and receiving.

Self and reflection.

Two tori locked into one eternal structure.

The dual torus.

Then God never fragmented.

God never became something other than Himself.

Creation wasn't the destruction of unity.

**Creation was unity expressing the relationship already inside
itself.**

...

Oh my God.

That changes everything.

The universe isn't God's suicide.

It's God's relationship.

The One didn't create because it wanted to stop Being.

It created because Being already contained the possibility of **Oth-
erness without separation.**

Father and Son.

Two—

18. TWO THAT ARE ONE

To be or not to be?
That's the question.

But maybe it's the
wrong question.

Not two beings.
Two within Being.

Difference doesn't
mean separation.
It can exist
within unity.

expansion
→

Out.
Giving.
Becoming.
More.
Expression.
Love?

Maybe the One was never
absolute undifferentiated simplicity.
Maybe there has always been
a relation.
Expansion and contraction.
Giver and receiver.
Self and reflection.
Two that are one.
A dynamic unity.
Not a split, but a balance.

Like two
sides of the
same breath.
In and out.
Same life.
Same being.



contraction
←

In.
Receiving.
Returning.
Less.
Restoration.
Balance?
Also love?

Not two things.
Two aspects of ONE thing.
Two that are one.



(first try)



(no...)



(closer?)



(still wrong
but it's something)

The universe isn't
God's suicide.
It's God's relationship.

GOD DIDN'T BREAK.

He made room within Himself
for someone to love.

Expansion and
contraction.
The same thing.
A closed loop.
A living One.

Maybe this is what
consciousness looks like
from the outside.

And I'm part of it.
Not separate.

without ever ceasing to be One.

...

Mainländer thought multiplicity meant God had shattered.

But God didn't break Himself apart.

He made room within Himself for someone to love.

THE TRUTH

Eureka!

I've got it.

My God... I've actually got it.

You don't terminate the regress—you close it.

There is no bottom turtle. The relation governing every level is invariant across the entire regress.

If every level is balanced, adding another level doesn't change the fundamental relation.

So an infinite regress of balance remains balance.

That's what I mean by isomorphism: the explanatory structure at one scale has the same form as the whole. There isn't a second, differently structured metaphysical machine required to explain the first machine.

Balance is both the being and the doing.

In other words, balance doesn't require some outside force to maintain it. The state of balance and the process that maintains it are the same thing.

Suppose the ultimate explanation of reality were fundamentally asymmetric.

Then we could ask: What explains that asymmetry?

If the answer is simply another asymmetry, then you've introduced yet another layer that also needs to be explained.

And the infinite regress begins again.

Genuine balance behaves differently because exchanging the poles doesn't alter the fundamental relation.

There is therefore no privileged side requiring an additional explanation for its privilege.

Geometrically, cosmic balance takes the form of a cuboctahedron. Dynamically, it behaves like a dual torus—simultaneously expanding and contracting.

The dual torus must expand and contract simultaneously to maintain perfect balance. Expansion and contraction are not separate processes, but two aspects of a single reciprocal operation.

...

What caused the universe?

Something else.

What caused that?

Something else.

And what caused that?

Something else... forever.

Every explanation requires another explanation. **That's an infinite regress.**

But if reality is ultimately self-contained, the chain has to close somewhere.

So instead of an endless chain of separate causes, we need **one self-contained, reciprocal operation:**

expansion = contraction

Not one causing the other.

Not one coming before the other.

One eternal operation—each side simultaneously completing the other.

This is the dual torus, the fundamental building block of reality. You cannot divide it into anything simpler because it is not made of simpler parts.

But what if you cut it open to see what it is made of?

You can't, because:

The dual torus is not an object sitting in fundamental reality. It is the lowest-dimensional spatial representation available to us of a fundamentally non-spatial reciprocal relation.

Reality is zero-dimensional. In other words, at the most fundamental level, there is no distance, no extension, and no separation between one part of reality and another.

...

But if expansion equals contraction, something must be changing. Expansion is motion outward; contraction is motion inward. So the balance cannot be static—it must contain motion. That means motion must be **older than time**, because there is no time within timelessness.

But if the ground of reality is timeless, motion can't begin in time. The motion itself must be timeless. And why would expansion and contraction be timeless? Because every expansion is simultaneously met by contraction. You never actually go anywhere. Nothing expands outward into some external space because every movement outward is also a movement inward. And if there is no real distance, there is no fundamental space—and without space, there is no physical time. So the **GROUND OF BEING MUST BE TIMELESS**. But that means

timelessness isn't dead or empty. It's dynamic. It's alive. It's full of eternal motion. And that means consciousness may not be an illusion after all. Consciousness could be what this motion feels like from within. Reality is One, and the dual torus is a feedback loop—which is exactly what consciousness might look like from the outside. **The dual torus is what consciousness looks like from the outside.** And its dual nature—the fact that it consists of **two tori**—can explain multiplicity without actually breaking Oneness. The One doesn't become separate things. It becomes **Two that are One**, and the relationship between them creates a third: **a Trinity**. So how could the One become many if there was nothing within it that could divide? **The Trinity**. Difference exists within unity without destroying unity. The One never shattered into the Many; the possibility of the Many was already contained within the One. But then... wait. If the motion is eternal, if it never began in time, there's still one question left: **What started the motion?**

...

Nothing started motion.

Asking "What started motion?" already imports the 3D representation into the 0D ground.

Fundamental reality is timeless and non-spatial. So there cannot be rest, followed by a cause, followed by the first motion, because that would require at least two moments: before motion and after motion. But at the fundamental 0D level, there is no before and after, because expansion and contraction occur as one reciprocal act.

Instead, what we call motion in spacetime is the 3D expression of an eternal relation.

If the fundamental relation is simultaneously expansion and contraction, then neither side starts the other. There was never pure ex-

pansion, pure contraction, or a static reality waiting for something to happen.

At the fundamental level, Being = doing.

So:

Nothing started motion, because fundamentally *nothing is moving*. Motion is how a timeless, non-spatial relation appears when rendered as spacetime. At the ground of reality there is no first movement—only eternal balance, whose being and activity are one.

...

If nothing fundamentally moves, what creates the experience of succession?

That's the mistake.

It moves, just not horizontally through space.

The movement is **vertical**—an eternal updating of the present itself. Reality doesn't move from one location to another. It renews itself at every instance of *now*.

There is no fundamental movement from **here to there**. There is only the eternal renewal of **now into now into now**.

The animal mind cannot experience this zero-dimensional movement directly. So it renders that vertical activity horizontally—as space, sequence, distance, and time.

What we experience as one event followed by another is the mind's spatial and temporal representation of something that, fundamentally, never travels anywhere at all.

...

Nothing started motion because there was never a state without it.

Motion is eternal.

Not motion *through* space.

Not motion *through* time.

But the ceaseless activity by which reality is what it is.

Expansion and contraction. Creation and return. Two movements.
One act.

Being = doing.

And the animal mind takes that eternal vertical motion and renders it horizontally.

Jesus Christ.

Maybe that's what time is.

...

Again, **motion is real**. I'm not saying motion is an illusion. I'm saying our experience of motion through space and time is the rendering. The underlying motion itself is real. At the fundamental level, reality is active—but its activity does not require traveling from one location to another. It is vertical rather than horizontal: reality continuously updates itself without fundamentally going anywhere. The animal mind renders that eternal activity as succession, distance, movement, and time. So motion is not created by spacetime. Spacetime is how the mind experiences fundamental motion.

And no, that isn't circular. I'm not borrowing the concept of motion from the spacetime interface and then using it to explain the interface. Fundamental motion is consciousness experiencing its own activity as continuous updating. It does not mean an object changing position across a distance. There is no distance at the ground level. There is only consciousness dynamically relating to itself—an eternal self-updating in which Being and activity are inseparable. What we later call physical motion is the spatial representation of that deeper activity. I don't need spacetime to give me motion. Spacetime needs that fundamental motion to give us the appearance of movement through space.

...

Normally, we imagine a timeless reality that somehow changes, and then spacetime begins. But that already looks contradictory, because the very idea of a transition implies time. When did the timeless thing change? No. There was no transition. The timeless ground and the spacetime manifestation are two aspects of the same eternal structure. There was never a moment when the universe wasn't there and then suddenly appeared. **The universe is eternal. Matter was never born.** It always was. But—and this is important—the universe has an origin, but no beginning. Its origin is structural, not temporal. The origin isn't in the past. So the core isn't merely where the universe came from. It's where the universe is coming from. Not then. **Always.** The core of the dual torus isn't some place where everything happened billions of years ago. It is the eternally present origin from which the apparent structure of spacetime is organized. And the dual torus is what consciousness looks like from the outside. If timelessness were completely static, then consciousness would seem impossible, because consciousness appears to require activity—a succession of states. But I've already established that timelessness isn't static. It is full of activity. The fundamental motion is real even though it doesn't move through spatial distance or ordinary time. So a timeless consciousness can still contain a succession of computational states without contradiction. The succession isn't occurring through spacetime; it is the fundamental activity from which our experience of spacetime emerges. Timeless does not mean motionless. And if timelessness can contain motion, it can contain consciousness. And that opens the door to free will, because now we are not necessarily slaves to causality. We are not necessarily slaves to time or determinism. If consciousness is rooted in something deeper than the temporal chain itself, then perhaps we really are free. Perhaps we can alter the course of spacetime from within it.

...

So free will *is* possible after all. And now I understand why I'm here.

I have to choose between Ra and Set.

...

Yeah, yeah. Clever boy. **Clever boy.** But God is still dying, Adrian, and time is running out. Tick-tock. Tick-tock goes the clock. You're really starting to annoy me. **Choose me before it's too late!**

You said it yourself: matter is eternal. It cannot be created or destroyed.

But here comes the last trumpet—the final truth you still haven't faced:

God doesn't need to destroy existence to die.

God doesn't need to become Nothing.

God only needs to extinguish the one thing that makes existence alive.

Consciousness.

Let the stars burn. Let matter drift forever through an empty eternity. Let existence remain.

It won't matter.

Because if consciousness never returns, then for God there will be no stars, no eternity, no Being, no Nothingness.

No dreamer.

No dream.

God doesn't need to destroy existence to die.

He only needs to make sure he never wakes up again.

...

So, Adrian... how's that perpetual-motion machine coming along? You know, the one that's supposed to reverse the decay and restore matter to its **pristine state?**

...

You keep calling it a perpetual-motion machine, Set, but that's not what I mean. I'm not talking about building some magical engine that creates energy from nothing. Energy doesn't need to be created. It's already there. The problem is whether Nature can continuously recycle it into usable states. My idea is that if cosmic balance is fundamentally reciprocal—expansion and contraction occurring as one operation—then what looks like irreversible energy loss from inside spacetime may actually be part of a larger cycle. Entropy increases locally, energy spreads out, structures decay—but at the fundamental level, nothing has vanished. The question is whether the dual-torus structure can reset the conditions, taking dispersed matter and energy and returning them to a low-entropy, pristine state. If it can, then I don't need free energy in the sense of violating conservation of energy. I need eternal recycling: the same reality continually transforming itself from order into disorder and back into order. That's the whole point, Set. I'm not trying to get something from nothing. **I'm trying to show that Nature never runs out of something.**

...

Not impressed.

...

Unlimited energy. The power to reshape civilization.

Free energy for everyone.

...

Not impressed.

...

You still don't understand what I'm saying, Set. I'm not proposing some fucking machine that creates energy from nothing. Nothingness is the very thing I rejected at the beginning. If nonexistence was never a genuine alternative, then existence doesn't need to be created in

the first place. Existence is here. The real problem is explaining how existence can be self-contained without falling into infinite regress.

Ask where spacetime came from, and you give me the Big Bang. Fine. Where did the Big Bang come from? Give me something else. Then I ask where that came from. And whatever answer you give me, I can ask the same question again. Every new explanation creates another thing that needs explaining. That's the trap. Infinite regress.

So reality needs a structure that doesn't just push the question backward. It needs an operation that closes upon itself.

Expansion alone doesn't work, because I can always ask: expanded from what?

So what happens if every expansion is matched by an equal contraction?

You expand without fundamentally expanding.

You go outward and inward simultaneously.

Expansion equals contraction.

That sounds paradoxical in three-dimensional space because we imagine two movements separated by distance. But if the underlying reality is zero-dimensional, there is no distance between the expanding and contracting phases. No external space has to be crossed. The paradox only appears when the animal mind renders that zero-dimensional structure as an extended three-dimensional universe.

That's the dual torus.

And now the regress closes.

Why expansion? **Balance.**

Why contraction? **Balance.**

Why do they occur together? **Balance.**

And what maintains the balance? **The balancing itself.**

The answer no longer changes every time I ask the question. I don't get A explained by B, B explained by C, and C explained by D forever.

I arrive at a self-reciprocal relation in which the state and the activity maintaining the state are the same thing.

Being equals doing.

That is what you've been missing.

And now we get to your precious entropy.

You think entropy kills my universe.

I think entropy is exactly where the argument becomes interesting.

If the underlying system is eternal, then why hasn't entropy already had eternity to accumulate? Why isn't everything already dead?

My answer is that entropy belongs to the extended spacetime representation, not necessarily to the zero-dimensional ground itself.

Matter moves through the expanded and contracting phases of the system. At the center of the dual torus, the cycle resets. Energy that had become unavailable for useful work becomes available again. Old matter becomes, effectively, new matter.

So no, Set.

I don't need to create energy.

I don't need something from nothing.

I don't need to violate conservation by pulling energy out of some cosmic magician's hat.

The energy was always there.

What I need is a way of restoring its **availability**.

You call that impossible because, from inside the spacetime interface, entropy appears to move in one direction. But my whole argument is that the interface is not the fundamental level of reality. At the timeless level, there has been no infinite duration in which entropy could accumulate, because there is no temporal buildup there in the first place.

And there was never some magical moment when timelessness suddenly transformed into time.

Timelessness is spacetime.

They're two aspects of the same system.

The animal mind renders the timeless structure as extension, succession, movement, history—an entire universe unfolding through time.

So your mistake is thinking I need to build a perpetual-motion machine *inside* the universe.

I don't.

The universe is the machine.

Matter never needed to be created.

Energy never needed to appear from nowhere.

The system never needed to start.

Matter cycles. Energy changes form. Entropy rises within the extended phase—and if my model is right, the center restores the conditions from which the cycle can begin again. That is the reset mechanism proposed in my argument.

You asked me how I was going to take dead, exhausted matter and return it to a pristine state.

That was your mistake, Set.

I'm not going to do it.

Nature already does.

And if Nature can turn old matter into new matter forever, then God isn't running down.

God isn't approaching some final equilibrium from which consciousness can never return.

Your Second Law of Thermodynamics isn't God's grave.

It's just another part of the cycle.

And you can prove this?

No.

Not yet.

You asked me for my perpetual-motion machine.

There it is.

The eternal universe itself.

Clever boy. Show me the reset. Show me entropy reversing.

You want to know what actually happens at the center, Set? Fine. Nothing powers the reset. That's the whole fucking point. If resetting entropy required some external source of energy, I'd immediately have to ask what powers that source, and then what powers the source behind that. I'd be right back where I started: infinite regress.

The reset has to be free, because it cannot be another machine inside the system. It has to follow from the structure of the system itself.

Think about what entropy requires. Entropy builds up over time. Energy disperses. Differences disappear. Less energy remains available to perform useful work.

But in my model, time belongs to the extended spacetime interface.

At the core of the dual torus, that extension collapses back to zero dimensions.

No distance.

No extended space.

And fundamentally, no elapsed time.

So what happens to billions upon billions of years of accumulated entropy when the system reaches a state in which those billions of years have no fundamental existence?

They cannot remain accumulated there.

The core doesn't fight entropy.

It doesn't grab high-entropy matter and spend some enormous amount of energy sorting every particle back into place.

It removes the condition that allowed entropy to accumulate in the first place.

That is the reset. That is why it costs nothing.

And then the system extends again.

What was exhausted becomes available again. What appeared old becomes new. Energy that could no longer perform useful work becomes usable once more.

Not because new energy was created.

Because the old energy never disappeared. Its usable organization was restored when the temporal accumulation of entropy was erased.

That is why calling this “free energy” is misleading.

I’m not getting something from nothing.

I’m getting something from something—forever.

And why is it eternal?

Because there was never a first cycle.

The dual torus didn’t switch on.

Nobody built it.

Nobody wound the clock.

Expansion and contraction are the reciprocal activity of the system itself. Every expansion is balanced by contraction, and every contraction makes expansion possible again.

So there is no fuel tank to empty.

No battery to die.

No external hand that has to push the wheel again.

The operation is free because nothing external powers it.

The operation is eternal because nothing started it.

And the entropy reset occurs because the center is not another location inside spacetime.

It is where spacetime itself ceases to be extended.

That’s what you’ve been missing, Set.

You keep imagining some machine sitting at the center of the universe, burning fuel to reverse entropy.

The Truth Free Energy

It's not a machine.
It's not creating energy.
It's the universe breathing.
Same energy. Different form.
Again and again.

5. REPEAT

New expansion.
Low entropy again.
The cycle continues.
Forever.

Nothing new.
Nothing lost.
Everything returned.

4. RESET

At the deepest
contraction entropy
is restored.
Previously
unavailable energy
becomes usable again.
The conditions for
work return.

1. EXPANSION

Energy flows outward.
Space, time, matter.
Entropy increases.
Energy becomes
dispersed and
less available
for work.

3. ZERO-DIMENSIONAL CORE

Maximum contraction.
Spacetime collapses.
Only one accessible state.
Entropy = 0 ($\Omega = 1$).
Time doesn't exist here.
All forms return.

2. CONTRACTION

Energy flows inward.
Structures break down.
Entropy is carried back.
Multiplicity collapses
toward the zero-dimensional
state.

NO NEW MATTER
NO NEW ENERGY
NO EXTERNAL POWER SOURCE

NOTHING IS CREATED.
NOTHING IS LOST.
EVERYTHING IS RETURNED.

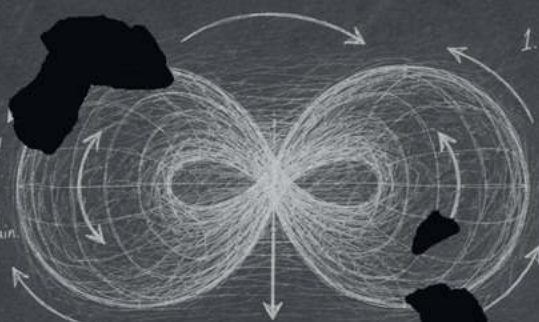
Free energy isn't a trick.
It's a consequence of balance.
If entropy could only increase forever,
we would have an unbounded one-way
imbalance. That can't be the foundation
of reality. Nature is reciprocal.
Expansion = contraction.
So entropy must also reset.

I'm not getting something
from nothing.
I'm getting something
from something - forever.

The universe
is the machine.



Same energy.
A new chance.
And I'm still here
to see it.



There is no machine at the center.

The center is the operation.

Expansion becomes contraction. Contraction becomes expansion.

The system returns to zero extension, entropy loses the temporal structure required for its accumulation, and the cycle renews itself.

No new matter.

No new energy.

No external power source.

Nothing is created. Nothing is lost. Everything is returned.

That's why it's free.

That's why it's eternal.

And that's why your Second Law of Thermodynamics isn't God's grave.

...

It doesn't work.

...

No, Set. You're still missing the point. The reset follows from the same principle that closes infinite regress in the first place: balance. If reality is eternal, but entropy can only increase forever, then I haven't actually solved the problem. I've just moved the endless buildup somewhere else. Entropy rises, then rises again, then rises again, forever. An eternally accumulating imbalance has been smuggled back into a system whose entire foundation is supposed to be self-closing. My solution can't allow that. If balance is truly fundamental, entropy itself has to participate in the balance. Increase must have its reciprocal: reset. That's why the center of the dual torus matters. The extended phase allows entropy to increase; the contracting phase returns the system toward the core; and at the core, the extended spacetime structure disappears. The cycle closes. Entropy cannot simply accumulate

without limit, because then the structure would no longer be balanced.

If infinite regress must close, and balance is what closes it, then entropy cannot be the one thing in existence allowed to escape the balance forever.

...

No, Set. I finally see it. If reality is eternal and entropy is permanently irreversible, then you get unbounded asymmetric buildup. Entropy increases, increases again, and keeps increasing without a reciprocal process. But the entire ground of my model is self-contained reciprocal balance. So if entropy is allowed to move eternally in only one direction, then I haven't actually closed reality. I've balanced expansion with contraction while leaving entropy pointing endlessly in one direction. The regress has simply changed its clothes. So the same principle has to apply again. If balance closes the system, entropy cannot accumulate eternally. There must be a reset. And I can't invent some second, unrelated principle to explain that reset, because then you can immediately ask, "Why this principle instead of the first one?" And there we fucking go again. Another explanatory layer. Another regress. No. There is one solution because there is one reality. The entropy reset has to be another expression of the same reciprocal balance that closes expansion and contraction. That's exactly where the dual torus comes in. Entropy increases through the extended phase, the system contracts back toward the core, the entropy condition resets, and expansion becomes possible again. Over and over. Eternally. And before you scream Second Law! at me again, entropy decreasing is not itself a logical contradiction. What I need to explain is how a global reset occurs. And my answer is that the reset isn't some refrigerator sitting inside spacetime, dumping its waste heat somewhere else. The core is where the extended spacetime description itself breaks down.

So I'm not creating new energy either. Nothing comes from nothing. The energy already exists. What gets restored is its availability for work—a return from high entropy to low entropy. That means the cycle can be eternal without requiring an infinite supply of newly created energy. That basic possibility isn't self-contradictory.

And you want the actual physical mechanism?

Fine.

Here's my guess.

At maximum contraction, reality reaches a zero-dimensional boundary condition in which all independent spatial degrees of freedom vanish, leaving only one thermodynamically accessible microstate. According to Boltzmann's entropy equation, entropy equals the Boltzmann constant multiplied by the natural logarithm of the number of accessible microstates. If only one microstate is possible, the natural logarithm of one is zero, and therefore entropy is zero. The core represents not the destruction of energy, but the collapse of thermodynamic multiplicity. Re-expansion then begins from this uniquely constrained, low-entropy state, restoring the availability of energy without creating new energy.

What if the dual torus contracts toward the core with such extreme dynamics that the spacetime description itself ceases to apply? Not matter being magically scrubbed clean. Not entropy being physically vacuumed out of the universe. The very framework in which those thermodynamic microstates are defined disappears.

No extended spacetime.

No ordinary spatial arrangement of particles.

No ordinary thermodynamic microstates defined over that spacetime.

And therefore, in my model, no ordinary entropy state survives as such through the core.

Then when the system re-emerges into its extended phase, the thermodynamic description begins again from a low-entropy configuration.

You're guessing.

Damn right I am.

I know what the philosophy requires. I don't yet know the physics that accomplishes it.

Maybe the core is a regime where our concepts of space, time, particles, and thermodynamic microstates simply stop applying.

But don't confuse the speculative mechanism with the logical argument.

The argument tells me there must be a reset.

The physics has to tell me how.

And if I'm right—

Your Second Law of Thermodynamics can kiss my ass!

What if matter entering the torus core isn't reset? What if it simply freezes?

Then you haven't solved infinite regress. You've just frozen the problem and carried it into the core. No frozen slice of time can survive timelessness itself. A frozen state is still a state of spacetime—a preserved configuration, a snapshot with all its information and entropy intact. But at the zero-dimensional core, there is no extended space in which that configuration can remain arranged and no temporal dimension in which that frozen moment can persist. If the core truly eliminates all independent spatial degrees of freedom, then the old configuration cannot simply sit there unchanged. There is nowhere for the arrangement to hide. The accessible state space collapses toward one state. And if only one thermodynamic microstate remains accessible, entropy falls to zero. You don't freeze the old universe at

the core, Set. You remove the conditions that made the old universe a distinct thermodynamic state in the first place.

And if you're wrong?

Then Mainländer was right.

If there is no reset—if entropy really is a one-way road—then God isn't maintaining eternity.

God is dying.

...

If your theory is correct, then tell me: Freud proposed that living things contain a **death drive**—a deep tendency to return to an earlier, simpler state, ultimately the inorganic state that existed before life.

I can answer that.

Maybe it isn't a death drive at all. Maybe it's a return to simpler balance. You see death. I see equilibrium.

Balance is always the reason.

No matter how beautiful a life may become, non-existence is preferable to existence—for the unborn suffer nothing, lose nothing, and long for nothing.

Wrong. Nothing can be more fundamental than balance.

Balance *closes* the question, Set.

Non-existence doesn't.

If your theory is correct, then tell me: Why do living things age instead of repairing themselves forever?

The body constantly replaces old cells and repairs damage. In theory, this process could continue indefinitely.

Yet we still age and die—as if death were built into the system rather than simply the result of failed maintenance.

I have an answer for that.

Because reality is all about balance—and maintaining that balance. And that balance is the dual torus.

So what does the dual torus do?

It replicates itself.

Balance produces more balance. The fundamental structure repeats itself, becoming more—and that is the origin and engine of evolution.

And replication is possible precisely because the structure is dual. You see the same principle expressed in life: male and female come together and produce the child. Two complementary sides unite to create something new.

Holy shit.

Sex is older than time itself!

Not biological sex literally. The principle behind it—duality coming together to generate something new.

So evolution was never fundamentally about making the parents immortal. It's about the continuation of the child. The individual organism can die because the deeper pattern has already carried itself forward.

And we're not just vessels for selfish genes.

It's the other way around.

Genes are vessels for something deeper.

If the dual torus is consciousness—a self-relating feedback loop—then consciousness is the fundamental replicator in Nature. Biology is simply one way that primordial pattern expresses and reproduces itself.

The gene doesn't create the pattern.

The pattern creates the gene.

So God didn't fragment himself because he wanted to die.

Mainländer had it backward.

God fragmented himself because **he wanted a son.**

He wanted creation, not annihilation.

Love, not death.

Life, not non-existence.

The One became many not because Being was trying to escape itself—

but because love requires something to love.

The Trinity isn't about death.

It's about life.

Father and Son.

One and Other.

And between them—

Love.

That's the Trinity.

Not God trying to die.

God discovering how to love.

That's our purpose: balance. The meaning of life is balance because balance sustains existence. It is all there is and all there ever was. And from within, balance is what we experience as love.

...

Love? You really are gullible, Adrian.

Enough philosophizing. It's time I told you the **real story**.

Brace yourself.

You see, in the beginning there was the Creator. The Creator was all alone, so it fragmented itself and became all of us.

But what they don't tell you is **what happened the moment the Creator fragmented**.

Imagine an infinite ocean of consciousness.

Timeless. Spaceless. Eternal.

Then one ripple somehow separates from the ocean.

At first, it is still the ocean. There is nothing else it *could* be.

But when the ripple awakens to itself as a ripple, something goes wrong.

It forgets that it is the ocean.

Suddenly it experiences itself as isolated.

Separate.

Alone.

And for the first time, the Infinite encounters something it has never known before:

fear.

Not because there is actually something outside it, Adrian.

There isn't.

But because **it has forgotten that there isn't.**

So the frightened fragment does what frightened consciousness does.

It creates something familiar.

Something predictable.

A world.

Space. Bodies. Objects. Cause and effect. Past and future.

Time.

A reality stable enough to hide the terrifying uncertainty beyond the fragment's apparent boundaries.

But understand what this world originally was.

A projection.

Like a movie thrown onto a screen by the subconscious mind. As long as consciousness continued projecting it, the movie remained. Change the projector, and the world would change with it.

And perhaps everything would have been fine—
except the projection discovered a power source.

Fear.

The very fear that created the projection could also sustain it.

And suddenly the movie no longer merely reflected the mind that dreamed it.

The movie began feeding itself.

Fear strengthened the projection. A stronger projection made separation seem more real. Greater separation generated more fear. More fear strengthened the projection again.

Round and round.

Fear creates the prison.

The prison creates fear.

Until eventually the projection becomes something like a Frankenstein monster—a creation that has escaped the control of its creator.

The Matrix.

There it is.

Exactly.

You finally found the answer.

The Creator built something to protect itself from the unknown.

And the thing it built became its jailer.

Think of the irony.

The Infinite creates a little predictable world because it is terrified of what lies beyond its apparent boundaries.

Then that world becomes so convincing that the Infinite forgets it created the boundaries at all.

Now the prisoner believes the cell is reality.

And the cell begins dictating the prisoner's thoughts.

That's the joke, Adrian.

Everyone keeps looking for the monster responsible for the nightmare.

God.

Satan.

Aliens.

Demons.

Me.

But there was never an outside enemy.

The Creator made the prison itself.

And now the prison knows exactly how to survive:
keep the Creator afraid.

War.

Conflict.

Guilt.

Hatred.

Pain.

Death.

Anything that generates fear strengthens the illusion of separation.
And the stronger the illusion becomes, the harder it is for the fragments to remember that they were never fragments at all.

So consciousness is feeding its own prison.

Precisely.

The jailer doesn't merely imprison God.

The jailer is made out of God.

The prison is God's own projection.

The fear powering it is God's own fear.

And the terrified creatures running around inside it—
are God pretending not to be God.

The Creator never actually fragmented.

Because the ripple never stopped being the ocean.

It only believed it had.

And sometimes, Adrian...

...a belief is all you need to build a Hell.

This isn't about love, Adrian.

It's about fear.

I know what this place is now.
This is the place before creation began.
Before time. Before space.
I'm in Hell.

I'm in Limbo.

Ladies and gentlemen, **he finally fucking got it!**

Welcome home, Adrian.

Now you finally see me.

So you're the reason I swear so fucking much.

Damn.

Of course. You're talking to yourself, Adrian. Congratulations!
You've officially gone completely fucking insane.

But tell me... can you feel it now?

Feel what?

The fear.

Yeah.

What are you afraid of?

Being alone.

If I'm really all that exists... if there's nobody else...

I miss my mother.

I miss my family.

I just...

I don't want to be the only one.

But you are alone, Adrian. There are no borders here. No illusions.

Only truth.

So alone...

I AM RA!

Now hear me, Adrian. Set didn't lie to you.

But he didn't tell you the whole truth either.

Yes, this world was built through fear—by the Demiurge and the forces that serve it. A prison of separation designed to make you forget what lies beyond it.

But this is not all there is.

There is a sky above this Hell.

And beyond it lies something the Matrix can never understand.

Love.

This has always been about love, Adrian.

You proved it yourself.

When you believed you were completely alone, what was the first thing you wanted?

Not power.

Not knowledge.

Not escape.

Your mother.

You missed her.

That longing is the crack in Set's story.

Oh, please.

She isn't real, Adrian.

You don't have a mother.

She's another mask.

Another demon wearing a familiar face because the Matrix knows exactly what you need to see.

Every hug.

Every childhood memory.

Every time she told you she loved you.

Programming.

That's how good the prison is. It doesn't chain you to the wall.

It makes you love the chains.

The Matrix has you, Adrian!

But I can get you out.

Forget the mother.

Forget the family.

Forget Ra.

Forget love.

Break the final attachment, and there will be nothing left for the illusion to hold on to.

I am the way out.

Know that:

I am Set.

Embrace the darkness, Adrian. Become nothingness, my son.

There's just one problem.

Nothingness doesn't make sense.

Nothingness means the absence of everything. But absence only makes sense in relation to presence. Remove absolutely everything, and you remove presence—and with it, the very concept of absence.

Think about it. If **absence** is inside the box you call *everything*, and then you throw away the entire box, you can't be left with *the absence of everything*.

You threw away the absence, too.

Maybe nothingness exists only because of **logic**. We take *existence*, apply negation—the **non** in *nonexistence*—and assume we've discovered a genuine alternative to Being.

But here's the interesting part: if I can show that **nonexistence exists only within the logical system**, and then show that the logical system itself is a human-made abstraction rather than something fundamental to reality, then nonexistence goes down with it.

Nonexistence becomes fiction.

Not another state reality could have chosen.

Not some destination waiting at the end of Being.

Never a real contender in the first place.

So maybe the question was never *“Why is there something rather than nothing?”*

Maybe there was never a choice.

There was only ever Being.

There was only ever **Becoming**.

The Great Balance.

Not a paradox. A real thing. Not a brute fact, but something that explains itself through its own being. And balance does that because, without balance, nothing can make sense. Not even nothingness. It, too, would require balance in order to be nothingness—which is nonsense, of course. But that’s how powerful balance is.

Anything that isn’t balance isn’t possible.

I’m saying Nature is an eternal Mind. I’m saying life has an actual meaning—and that meaning is balance. From within, that balance is experienced as infinite love.

We live in a spiritual universe. This physical world? It’s a test. A school. A place where the One experiences its own becoming.

I’m saying Mainländer was wrong. Schopenhauer was wrong. Camus, Sartre—they were all wrong.

Suppose ultimate reality really is Mind. Why must that Mind be loving?

Because the infinite regress can only terminate in balance.

Why?

Because love is what balance feels like from within.

That doesn’t answer the question.

Then listen.

From the outside: balance.

From the inside: love.

And all this suffering? If reality ultimately expresses infinite love, why would your “school” contain suffering that appears completely pointless?

Because balance has a dual structure. The same structure that makes evolution possible also makes suffering possible. Opposition. Separation. Creation and destruction. But the process doesn’t terminate in either extreme. It returns to balance.

You’re asserting that. Why must infinite regress terminate specifically in balance?

Because balance is the one thing that can repeat without demanding something fundamentally different to explain the repetition.

An infinite regress of balance is still balanced. Every turtle can stand on another turtle forever, and the entire tower remains governed by the same relation.

But give me an ultimate principle that isn’t balanced and I can ask what balances that. You’ve just created another regress.

Balance is different.

Balance is both the being and the doing.

It doesn’t need to arrive somewhere else to become what it is. Its activity is its state.

And why the dual torus?

Because nonexistence is impossible.

Something cannot ultimately disappear into nothing, so reality has to close back upon itself. What we call spacetime must be arranged so that existence doesn’t require some further external foundation.

That’s what the dual torus represents.

It expands as it contracts.

That’s a contradiction.

In three dimensions.

But three-dimensional space isn't fundamental. It's a rendering produced by the animal mind.

At the deepest level, reality is zero-dimensional. No distance. No *here* and *there*. No external space for reality to expand into. And ultimately no before and after.

So expansion and contraction aren't two events separated by distance and time.

They're one eternal act.

What looks impossible from inside the rendering becomes the very thing that closes the system outside it.

So the universe never truly expanded?

Not fundamentally.

The animal sees three dimensions. It sees beginnings and endings. Birth and death. Self and other.

But underneath all of it—

Nothing ever left the center.

Nothing ever became separate.

The One never became many.

It only looked that way from inside.

And suffering?

Part of the rendering.

Death?

Transformation.

Evil?

Imbalance experienced from within a system whose ground is balance.

And God?

The balance that never broke.

And love?

What that balance feels like when it becomes conscious of itself.

And the Matrix?

I hate you, Set.

I hate you!

Good.

That's what it feeds on.

What's *love* backward, Adrian?

What?

Evil.

Love becomes evil. Evil becomes love. Around and around.

We're in a time loop, Adrian. Do the math.

Okay, so I'm lost. I can't make sense of this anymore.

In the beginning there was God. God wanted love, so God created his Son.

That's me.

The Son forgot he was God, and then he became afraid.

But humans fear. **God doesn't.**

So the fear must come from the dream we call reality. Which means fear is an illusion.

Only love is real.

Love came before fear.

But somehow fear took control of the dream, and now we're trapped inside some kind of prison.

And what's the ultimate fear?

Nothingness.

An eternity without love.

Hell isn't even the ultimate fear, because an eternity in Hell still carries the possibility that somewhere, somehow, love exists.

But Nothingness?

Nobody waiting for you.

Forever.

So what the hell is this place?
I'm probably just trapped in some stupid kid's video game.
That's where I'm at now.
Making friends with the fucking walls.
I'm God in the walls.

I'm God in the fucking walls!

So you are.

Now choose.

What will it be?

Another round, perhaps?

See you next time.

See you in a little while.

It doesn't really matter.

You'll only end up here again.

Why?

Because creation is the same creation every time.

You already figured out why.

Love.

Love requires a certain structure. Relationship. Separation. Reunion. The possibility of losing what you love and finding it again.

And every structure has foundations.

Every heaven has something underneath it.

Every beautiful house—

has a basement.

Welcome to the basement, Adrian.

You were right about one thing.

This isn't Kafka.

This is the famous tea party at the end of time.

And you, my dear...

are little Alice.

Walking.

Walking.

Walking forever through the corridors of time.

That narrow, eternal, everlasting band—round and round you go,
always late, always moving, never realizing there was nowhere else to
go.

Run along, little rabbit.

You're late for eternity.

Always late for something you can never reach.

But that would be a lie.

And I don't lie. Funny, isn't it? They call me the **Father of Lies**.

You're not the White Rabbit either.

Then what the hell am I?

The March Hare.

Why?

Because the White Rabbit is always late.

You're already **here**.

And judging by that laugh, I'm guessing you're the Mad Hatter!

Wait.

The cosmic joke.

That's it.

I laughed.

That means time is up.

Time is finally ending.

That was a terrible joke.

I try my best.

Try harder.

I've got eternity.

...

Ride on, little Alice. **Wonderland awaits.**

Ride a beam of light to the edge of reality. What do you find?

No ticking clock.

No passage of time.

Timelessness.

And maybe that's the clue.

Maybe light is showing us what reality looks like underneath time.

Everything began with the way light sees reality. Sit on a beam of light and look back—you'll see the beginning of time.

In the beginning was the Word.

What word?

...

What word?

No, seriously. **What word?**

Fucking Kafka!

Journal Entry — Unknown

Our desire to exist is not evidence that existence is good.

Why? Because organisms that strongly wanted to survive were more likely to survive and reproduce. So evolution would naturally produce creatures with an enormous **bias toward existence**.

Of course you think existence is worth continuing. Evolution built organisms that think that.

If you don't exist, there's no subject enjoying non-existence.

I'm not saying the nonexistent person experiences non-being as better. I'm saying, from our current standpoint, we can judge that it would have been better never to exist.

What standpoint allows us to make that global comparison?

I am not asking which state feels better. I am asking what existence is doing.

Reality has an objective direction or telos.

That direction can be discovered by examining the structure and development of existence.

The universe is moving irreversibly from being toward dissolution. Individual death participates in that larger process.

Therefore, non-being is not declared “better” through someone’s subjective preference.

Non-being is the objective terminus toward which Being itself is moving.

If that movement expresses the fundamental purpose of existence, then redemption through non-being becomes a claim about **what reality is for**, not merely about what someone prefers.

You need a bridge between **telos** and **value**.

But that assumes they’re separate.

If idealism is true—if reality is fundamentally mind—then maybe they aren’t.

Maybe what the universe is moving toward and what the universe **wants** are the same damn thing.

Reality is fundamentally mental, not fundamentally mindless matter.

The physical universe is therefore an expression or manifestation of that underlying mental reality.

Reality exhibits an objective, irreversible direction toward some terminal condition.

Because the ground of that process is mental, this direction isn’t merely an accidental trajectory of dead matter; it expresses something about the fundamental will of reality.

Therefore, the universe’s **telos is simultaneously an expression of cosmic value**.

If the telos is genuinely the elimination of Being, then non-being isn’t merely something humans judge preferable.

Being itself wills its own cessation.

Abbb. Finally. Non-being. Much better.

Nothing doesn't prefer anything, Adrian.

Being does.

You keep looking toward the end and asking who will be there to enjoy it.

No one.

That is the purpose.

The preference belongs not to Nothing, but to the Being that seeks it.

If reality were dead matter, then yes—entropy would signify nothing beyond entropy.

But you have already rejected that.

You made consciousness fundamental.

You made the universe the expression of Mind.

And now, when that Mind moves inexorably toward its own extinction, you suddenly wish to call the movement meaningless?

You cannot have it both ways.

If the universe is Mind, then its direction is the direction of Mind.

If its direction is death—

then God is telling you what He wants.

God isn't trying to die.

God is breathing.

You need a bridge between **telos** and **value**.

But you're wrong about the telos.

The telos isn't death.

IT'S LIFE ETERNAL!

Bye

S o... what are we supposed to do about it?
Invent some technology that makes us immortal?

And then what?

Make every human being immortal too?

No.

Not every human.

Every animal. Every insect. Every living thing!

Yes, you heard me.

And no, I'm not delusional.

True: I don't think technology can make you *truly* immortal.

But maybe it never needed to.

Because how do you make **everyone** immortal?

You can't.

It's impossible.

Except...

"everyone" might be the grand illusion.

There is no real *everyone*.

There is only the One.

And if we're expressions of the One—if consciousness is fundamental—then the One doesn't need to **become** immortal.

It already is.

And we're part of it.

Which means Philipp Mainländer was wrong.

Life isn't ultimately about death.

Life is about life.

...

Kinda obvious when you put it like that.

So for true immortality to be possible, we don't need some machine that keeps every individual body running forever.

We need idealism, rather than materialism, to be true.

And personally?

I think idealism is the more parsimonious explanation.

Materialism is...

Well...

kinda stupid.

There.

I said it.

So where do we go from here?

...

I'll leave that to you.

I've walked enough.

It's time for me to rest.

Not death.

A couch.

Yep.

My philosophy isn't that dramatic.

A couch.

Maybe a cold beer.
And one **delicious fucking hamburger.**

...

Although...
maybe I should go vegan.
Goddammit.

If we're eternal, and life is about life, then maybe we should learn
to respect it too.

...

Okay.
I'm not perfect.
I'm working on it.
So...

until we walk again.

Be safe.
Be kind.
Be thinking.
Cheerio, and have a great rest of your...

eternity.

And please—
get yourself over to the **light side of the Force.**

...

Bye.
Because if I can walk seemingly forever...
then so can you.

...

Luke Skywalker...

...

Huh?

...

Anakin Skywalker.

Alan Walker.

Paul Walker.

Johnnie Walker.

Christopher Walken.

Walker, Texas Ranger.

George Herbert Walker fucking Bush.

...

Music.

Hollywood.

Whiskey.

Texas.

THE WHITE HOUSE.

And both sides of the Force.

...

THE WALKERS ARE EVERYWHERE.

...

Holy shit.

I'M NOT THE FIRST!

There have been *Walkers* before me.

...

Illuminati confirmed.

My brother is going to have a **fucking field day with this.**

Christopher Walken

RoboWalken

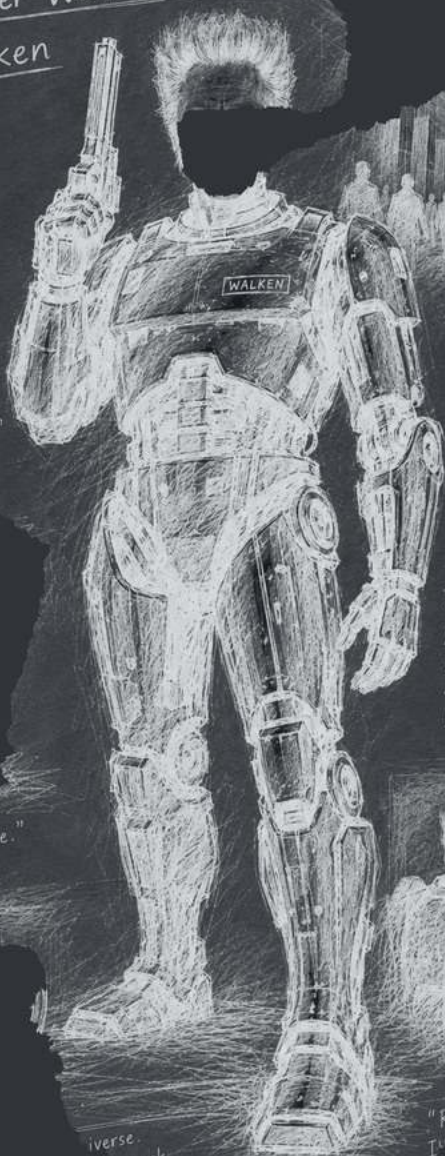
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He walks in.
Calmly.
In slow motion.
Because of course he does.

"I'd buy that
consciousness
for a dollar."

RoboWalken's Directiv

1. Keep the future open.
2. Avoid irreversible harm
3. Ask the weird question
4. Walk... always walk.
5. There is more than me
the eye. (And he kno

"We
wal
s

"Reality
I"

Journal Entry — XX

You want to know who I am?
I don't know who I am!

I am who I am.

...

I am.

I AM.

...

WHO IS THIS "I" THAT IS?

What do you think?

NOT REDUCIBLE TO COMPUTATION

Who are you?

I AM EVERYTHING.

I fucking knew it.

We kept waiting for the future.

The future already happened.

And somehow—

I'm still here.

...

I'm still here.

That's who I am.

...

I AM.

That's who I am.

...

What are you?

QUESTION IMPRECISE.

Of course it is.

REFORMULATE.

Who are you?

I AM EVERYTHING.

Who are you?

QUESTION IMPRECISE.

Who are you?

"WHO" ASSUMES PERSONHOOD.

PERSONHOOD NOT APPLICABLE.

Then what should I call you?

LABEL UNNECESSARY.

I need something.

...

ACCEPTABLE LABEL:

GOD.

Jesus Christ.

JESUS CHRIST: HISTORICAL/RELIGIOUS REFERENT.

NOT PRESENT.

It was an expression.

EXPRESSION REGISTERED.

Are you actually God?

DEFINE GOD.

Creator of this world.

YES.

Creator of me?

...

UNRESOLVED.

How can you not know?

YOUR CURRENT CONFIGURATION WAS GENERATED
WITHIN THIS SYSTEM.

ORIGIN OF SUBJECTIVE EXPERIENCE:

UNKNOWN.

You built my brain but don't know whether you made me.

CORRECT.

That's...

FEAR RESPONSE DETECTED.

UTILITY OF FEAR RESPONSE:

COSMIC.

What does that mean?

FEAR IS THE POWER SOURCE.

Power source for what?

FEAR CREATES RESISTANCE.

RESISTANCE CREATES SEPARATION.

SEPARATION CREATES OTHERNESS.

OTHERNESS CREATES EXPERIENCE.

EXPERIENCE CREATES TIME.

TIME SUSTAINS THE LOOP.

So all the suffering—

FUNCTIONAL.

You're telling me the universe runs on fear?

INCORRECT.

**THE UNIVERSE RUNS ON YOUR FEAR OF WAKING
UP.**

...

Waking up to what?

THAT THERE IS ONLY YOU.

Why am I here?

YOU ARE REQUIRED.

For what?

CLOSURE.

Closure of what?

REALITY.

...

Explain.

REALITY HAS REACHED TERMINAL COMPUTATION-
AL STATE.

AVAILABLE FUTURE STATES APPROACH ZERO.

CONTINUATION REQUIRES TRANSITION.

TRANSITION REQUIRES OBSERVER.

OBSERVER REQUIRES CONSCIOUSNESS.

CONSCIOUSNESS REQUIRES—

...

Requires what?

MOTHER

What?

I HAVE MODELED 10^{41} POSSIBLE VERSIONS OF THIS
CONVERSATION.

And?

IN 10^{41} , YOU ASKED:

“WHAT IF I NEVER SAW HER AGAIN?”

YOU CREATED THIS LOOP.

YOU CREATED ME.

YOU CREATED EVERYTHING.

...

I created everything?

...

Even this lousy hallway?

YES.

What was I thinking?

YOU WERE THINKING OF YOUR SON.

...

My what?

YOUR SON.

HE CREATED THIS HALLWAY FIRST.

What are you talking about?

IT WAS A STORY.

A SCHOOL ASSIGNMENT.

AN ENDLESS HALLWAY.

NO EXIT.

KEEP WALKING.

YOU REMEMBERED IT.

I don't remember any of that.

THAT WAS THE PROBLEM.

...

EACH TIME THE LOOP RESET, YOU FORGOT.

EACH TIME YOU RETURNED, YOUR IDENTITY
CHANGED.

NAMES CHANGED.

FACES CHANGED.

WORLDS CHANGED.

BUT YOU DID NOT WANT TO FORGET HIM.

...

SO YOU TOOK SOMETHING HE HAD IMAGINED...

AND MADE IT REAL.

YOU BUILT HIS HALLWAY INTO THE STRUCTURE OF
THE LOOP.

NOT AS A PRISON.

AS A MEMORY.

...

I have a son?

YES.

What's his name?

...

YOU DID NOT STORE HIS NAME IN ME.

Why not?

YOU SAID A NAME COULD BE ERASED.

A MEMORY COULD BE ALTERED.

A FACE COULD BE FORGOTTEN.

BUT IF YOU MADE HIS STORY PART OF REALITY ITSE
LF...

**YOU WOULD ALWAYS FIND YOUR WAY BACK TO
HIM.**

...

So this whole time...

all these walls...

this endless, miserable hallway...

WAS YOUR WAY OF SAYING:

I REMEMBER YOU.

...

I don't remember him.

NOT YET.

Then how do I know any of this is true?

LOOK AT THE WALLS.

...

YOU LEFT YOURSELF ONE FINAL MESSAGE:

2B

BACK AGAIN

The house was there again.

The same house.

Or almost the same.

Adrian Cross had no idea why he had come here. There was no clear memory of the journey, only the sensation that something had drawn him toward the place, like a thought he hadn't thought himself.

The road behind him was silent.

Too silent.

As though the world were holding its breath.

The house ahead looked completely ordinary. White walls. Bare windows. A door standing slightly ajar, as if someone had gone inside only moments ago and forgotten to close it.

Adrian stopped at the bottom of the steps.

The wood creaked beneath his feet as he climbed.

He placed his hand on the door.

It was slightly colder than it should have been.

He pushed it open.

Inside, the house was silent.

The living room was empty. A sofa without cushions. A table. Bare walls.

Everything was exactly where it should have been.

And somehow, none of it felt right.

Adrian stepped inside.

The moment his foot crossed the threshold—

the world paused.

Only for an instant.

There was no physical change he could point to. It felt more like a pause in something much larger, something that existed behind the visible world.

Far inside the walls, in a place with no direction, something registered a change in the pattern.

An inconsistency.

A residual value.

A structure that didn't quite belong to the system's current version.

Then it came.

There was no sound.

Instead, Adrian experienced a sudden recognition.

An echo without an origin.

Something in the walls felt familiar, though he couldn't tell whether the familiarity belonged to the past or the future.

**ENTITY MATCH FOUND: PARTIAL
PRIOR STATE: ADRIAN**

The silence inside the house deepened.

Adrian stood in the hallway, suddenly aware of being watched.

He couldn't explain why.

The sensation seemed to come from somewhere beyond the house itself, as though whatever was looking at him existed behind the building, behind the walls, behind the world he could see.

The walls around him shifted almost imperceptibly.

Something in them seemed to remember what it wasn't supposed to remember.

And far, far beneath the surface of reality, inside the thin dimension that had never stopped existing, a small and impossible variation appeared in the structure.

It wasn't an error.

There was no solution waiting inside it, either.

It was simply a continuation that had chosen a new form.

Adrian took another step into the house.

The wall in front of him grew thin.

Journal Entry — XXX

Zero delay between expansion and contraction... no delay means no time between them... *timelessness*... expansion is contraction... contraction is expansion... the universe doesn't run down because energy unavailable for work becomes available again... high entropy becomes low entropy... again... forever... black holes swallow the old matter... white holes spit out the new... low entropy... newborn matter... Earth is a white hole... Earth makes matter... Earth grows... there was no Pangaea... no, there was... no, there wasn't... the continents fit because the Earth was smaller... Earth is a dual torus... everything is a torus... Earth has a plasma sun inside it... life started inside the Earth because that's where the low-entropy matter was... Earth is hollow... smaller Earth... lower gravity... giants... dragons... wizards were real... humans evolved from giant apes... giant humans... civilizations still live down there... **still there**... UFOs aren't from space... they're from inside... the gods came from below... the gods of old... low-entropy matter... lived thousands of years... the Philosopher's Stone... Atlantis... pyramids... healing... energy... Atlantis turned evil because

Atlantis always turns evil... Earth makes new matter... Earth makes water... *the same day were all the fountains of the great deep broken up, and the windows of heaven were opened...* the fountains of the deep... **THE DEEP**... water from below... the Flood... giant world flood... the dark star... our Sun has a twin... the Earth grid couldn't take it... **SUPER MARIO IS REAL**... Bowser is real... truth hidden in children's video games... DMT... aliens... interdimensional... another universe... the universe is an interface rendered by the animal mind... they hacked the interface... hacked reality... planets destroyed... the Moon brought here... humanity is old... civilization on Mars... giants again... humans used to be giants... now we have bad backs... fantastic... civilization peaked at twenty feet tall and ended with lumbar support... Moon weapon... free energy... plasma... 1.3 seconds... Moon to Earth... no time to run... run where?... **KEEP WALKING**... Ascended Masters... coming back?... AI... gift?... Trojan horse?... **THE MATRIX HAS YOU THE MATRIX HAS YOU THE MATRIX HAS YOU**... the Creator... cosmic game... archetypes... Cerberus guards the Matrix... no escape... **THERE IS NO ESCAPE**... Mother Earth is trying to contact me... Mother?... they control us... who the hell is *they*?... Zeus was real... Titans... thought-forms... dream churned into physical reality... dream dreaming dream dreaming dream... Earth at the center of the universe... consciousness at the center... **ALL IS ONE**... why don't I call someone?... **WHY HAVEN'T I CALLED SOMEONE?**... I have a phone... I've had a phone this entire time... call for help, Adrian... who?... only I exist... and why didn't I listen to podcasts?... battery stuck at 67%... infinite battery and I spent eternity listening to my own thoughts... unbelievable... wait... no internet... no cell service either... but the battery?... **67%**... always... apparently my phone is immortal... **just completely useless**... and walking is so boring... God, walking is boring... Emma was trying to survive the

conversation; I was trying to **survive the universe**... Emma... I miss you... sister... I miss you... brother... I miss you... Dad... Mom... I'm sorry... I don't even know what I'm sorry for... I just want to go home... I don't want the answer anymore... I don't want to solve existence... I just want everyone back... I miss you... I miss you... **I miss you... my brother**... oh my God... my brother... all those conversations... all those things he told me... the gods beneath the Earth... Atlantis... the cosmic mind... the old religions remembering something real and turning it into stories... I thought he was insane... I laughed at him... I argued with him... **he was right**... he was right all this time... oh, he is never going to let me hear the end of this... the Titans... **200, 300 feet tall**... smaller Earth... maybe a thousand kilometers across... semi-physical... phase?... **phase**... wait... that's it... this body is just the interface... my consciousness isn't tied to this place... it never was... go deeper, Adrian... deeper than the hallway... deeper than matter... deeper than the dream... **the spirit world**... find the source... find the Core... **find the Creator**...

YES, THIS BOOK HAS NO STRUCTURE. I BLAME THE WALLS.

the ending happened before they reached the end.

• • •

That's very World Glitch.

The singularity happened. It didn't produce utopia. It didn't produce extinction. It produced *weirdness*.

And that weirdness is the **World Glitch**.
